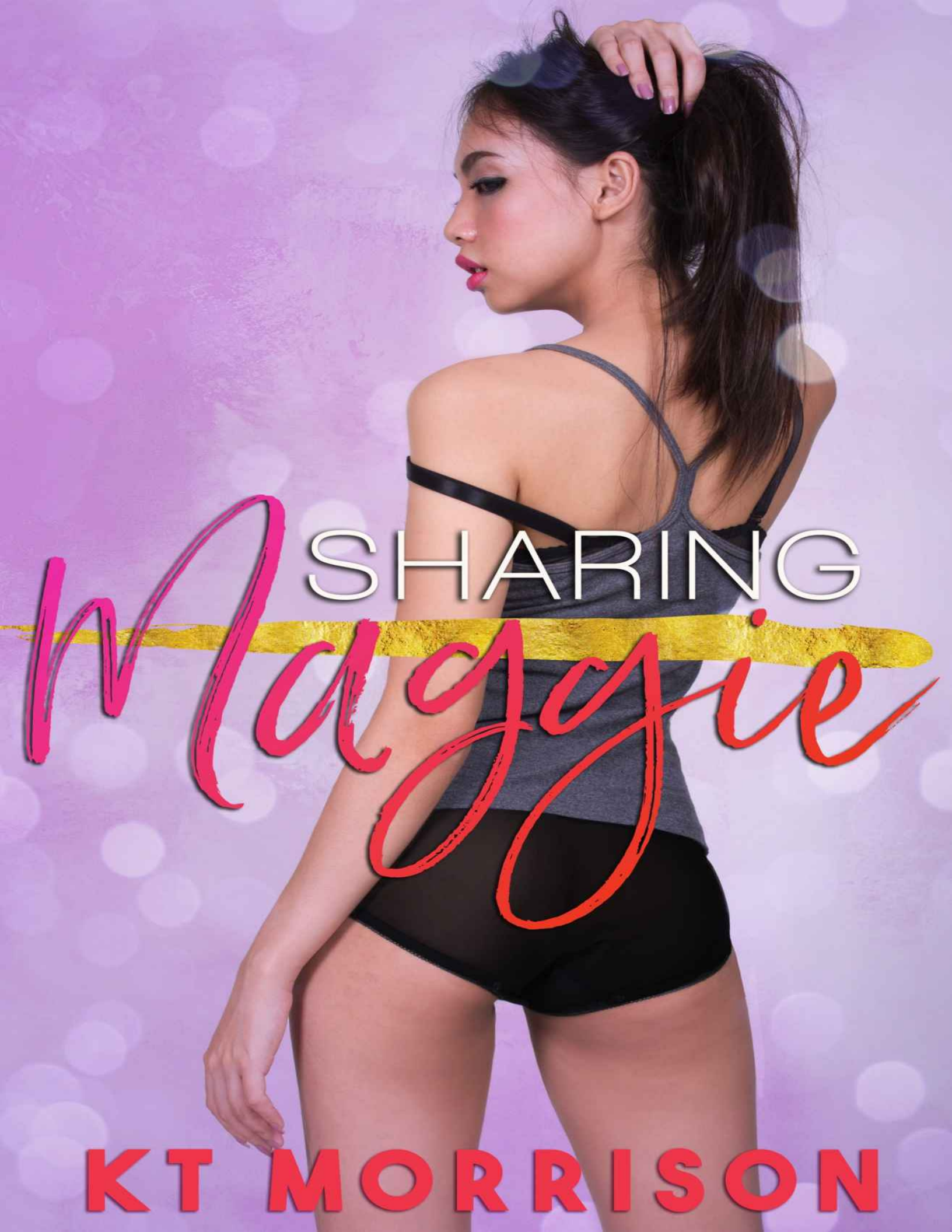




SHARING

Maggie

KT MORRISON

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Birdcage

FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 29TH

IT WAS ridiculous but it didn't stop Maggie from contemplating its purchase. An antique Chinese bamboo bird cage, three feet tall, chipped, aging, over a century old. It spoke to her. It was bold and impressive yet made of all these small and fine intricate details. The architectural structure of it was built in tiers, then capped with a hexagonal wire dome. The base was carved and had heavy wooden feet. Tarnished brass bells hung from some of the corners. The top was a finial with the hand-carved face of a woman. The cage had lost its door some time ago.

She tested its weight, lifted it from the wooden floor, pulling up on the cage by the curved rim of the hexagonal roof. It was lighter than she thought. They could fit it in Cole's Jeep, but it would have to take the passenger seat in the back next to Max.

They'd stopped for a break just inside the state border, coming into Rhode Island through Massachusetts on the North Smithfield Expressway. Three bouncy hours in Cole's Jeep, and when she saw the rusted old panel truck out front of a dilapidated Colonial schoolhouse with the words ANTIQUE MARKET painted on the side, she knew this was where they would stretch their legs and take a pee.

The last week with Max had been interesting. They were closer, she thought, in the hours after her fling with Jay. They still were, but there was a wedge easing its way between them, something intangible. They'd been very handsy and loving but there was *something*. She attributed it to Max. Latent jealousy over what he witnessed. He was fighting it. She thought he

was fighting it because he was worried if he complained she wouldn't do it again. And that was the strange part. She did want to do it again. She wanted to have sex with Jay. They both wanted it but were afraid to admit it to each other, she thought. She may even want something *else*.

But Max convinced her to take a break with Jay. It was a busy week, getting ready for this trip home, catching up on all the work she'd missed because of the obsessive thought over her sexy figure model. Having sex had broken the tension. She'd been able to get her schoolwork back on track. She agreed with Max. Felt bad for him in a way. So she'd texted Jay and said she couldn't do it this week. Then he called. Max was in the room and she felt so guilty, slinking out so she could talk to him. Like she was cheating. But she wasn't. She just felt strangely uncomfortable talking to Jay with Max next to her. She had managed to get naked and suck his cock, have him go down on her and make love to her. That was okay, but somehow a phone call seemed too intimate. She quelled Jay's concerns that he'd done something wrong or that she was mad at him. That felt good. She told him she'd see him the following Thursday.

After her secretive phone call with Jay she'd returned to Max and she could see him squirming. He suspected it was Jay on the phone. Was worried to ask, once again, she figured, worried that seeming jealous would cause problems. So he suffered. She liked it. She liked that his heart rate was through the roof and that he was biting his tongue and suffering. It was because of her. She did that to him. She felt sexually powerful. It was a strange swirling orb in her and it felt good. She'd never felt like that before.

It would be an incr—

A strong hand clamped her shoulder. The way it landed on her felt like doom. Like she'd been caught. Her mind had been read and now the authorities were taking her. She whipped around. Looming above her was terror. Eight feet tall. A monster. Her mouth opened. It had the head of a raven, black bird eyes like a demon's peered down on her, light danced on its impossibly black feathers...its pointed beak bowed to her. She yelped. Knew it was Cole but her fingers tingled in horror, her heart leaped and she went lightheaded.

"Asshole," she laughed and she kicked him in the side of the thigh.

He laughed from inside the raven head oddity he'd placed over his own.

"God, what the hell..." she said, holding on to her heart.

He lifted it off and shook his blonde hair out, said, "Isn't it awesome? I gotta get it. I could start a Secret Society with this. Skull and Bones shit," he said, admiringly, turning the raven's head to look in its eyes.

WHEN HE CAME out of the can, drying his hands with a wad of rough brown paper, he'd turned right and saw Cole with a raven head over his own, scare the crap out of Maggie. Max stood there feeling warm for her, smiling, throwing the balled paper into a green metal barrel with a garbage bag hooped into it.

They were at a roadside antique market, inside an old one-room schoolhouse packed with furniture and oddities like totem poles and huge defunct restaurant signs, gas pumps and, apparently, a costume raven head. A tall black-feathered helm one would wear at a carnival, or Mardi Gras, or perhaps a Satanic sacrifice. Maggie kicked Cole in the leg, clutched her heart and Max laughed out loud from across the bustling market. Cole popped the raven head off and shook out his hair and Maggie watched him, smiling and laughing.

Rooming with Cole in his Freshman year at Farmingham had been an incredible boon. Max was an easy friend and Cole was the best hang. That random room pairing—arranged in some stuffy closet in the Oren House—had changed his life. Two young ambitious guys coming together and seeing eye-to-eye on everything, spending every night together, then the weekends too. Fast friends. Best friends. Better than the guys he'd grown up with in Michigan. It was funny how something so beyond his control could have been so fortuitous and everlasting.

He headed to meet them, weaving through the shoppers. Cole flipped the raven around now and he slipped it over Maggie's head. Her legs buckled and she put her hands out blindly. She grabbed at Cole's face, her fingers tucking into his smiling mouth. Her hands went down his body and she punched him in the stomach with good humor.

"How much for the bird?" Max asked Cole when he reached them.

"Take her," he said, "she's too feisty."

Maggie bent over and let the raven head fall off and into her hands. She came up and her face was red, her hair wispy.

"I probably have lice now," she said, looking at the raven head.

“Lice?” Cole balked, “No. Fleas, yes. Probably fleas.”

She tossed the raven head to Cole and he caught it against his chest.

“Max!” she said, spying him, “Check this out...”

She showed him a huge and elaborate bird cage sitting on the floor amongst a clever display with old ladders and strings of lights and hanging sheets of linen.

“A bird cage?”

“I’m going to buy it,” she said, standing next to him, admiring it.

Cole came between them, said, “She’s worried about lice, has no fear about bird flu from a rotten old bird cage.”

Maggie frowned with scrunched incertitude, said, “There hasn’t been a bird in that cage for a decade, how—”

Cole poked her in the waist and made her flinch, said, “Zombie bird flu.”

She rolled her eyes and said to Max, “What do you think?”

“It’s huge.”

“Haggle for me, Max,” she said, putting a hand on his stomach and looking into his eyes.

“Haggle?” he laughed.

“Be a man for me,” she said.

He laughed. “Men haggle?”

Cole said, “I’ll do it,” stepped forward and looked at the bird cage. Raven head under his arm, he got down on his knees and peered at the details of the cage. He said, “Besides, Max looks like a fucking nerd right now. Owner will eat him alive...”

“What?” Max said, looking down at his outfit. He had pressed chinos and loafers, a chambray shirt tucked in and a birds eye sweater.

“Nerd,” Cole repeated.

Maggie said, “He’s afraid of my parents.”

“I am not,” he said, “I respect them, they mean—”

“Holy fuck, Maggie, it’s, like, three-grand,” Cole burst, holding the tag flipped over and reading the price.

“Throw in your raven head, see if we can get a deal.”

“Don’t buy me... You’d buy me a raven head?” he said as he stood.

“You’re our Best Man...”

Cole posed for her, stood masculine and tall in front of her and said, “I’m a man. I *always* buy my own raven heads.”

She laughed and pet his chest, said, “Whatever. Make a deal for me, Cole.”

It seemed on purpose. It stuck Max good. He’d imagined Maggie with Cole before but it was taboo. That would never happen. But given this display and their recent discoveries maybe Maggie was tuning in to his frequency and playing with him. That’s what it amounted to. At least he hoped that’s what it was.

Cole walked off to the counter with his raven head and holding the big cage at his side by its finial.

When Cole was gone Max said to Maggie, “Be careful.”

Maggie turned to him, her brow lowered, said, “Careful?”

“You’re playing?”

“Playing what, Max?” she said, her face open now, like she didn’t know what he meant.

COLE DROVE A LIFTED JEEP. Manual transmission, two door, lifted up and sitting on huge tires. It was a bumpy ride and even though they were cresting the smoothly paved Jamestown Verrazzano Bridge, the knobby tires made the small brass bells on Maggie’s bird cage softly chime. It was becoming maddening.

Max looked out over Narragansett Bay, smooth calm water out there, ahead of them the still-colorful fall hump of Conanicut Island. Maggie flipped through her phone, a thin white cord twirling up into the buds placed in her little ears. She sat in the passenger seat, up front with Cole. Cole’s stereo was broken. They rode in silence.

Maggie had her hair pulled back, neatly tucked in a ponytail. She hadn’t dressed up to see her parents, though her appearance was neat. Her long lashes blinked as she watched her screen and listened to her music.

She’d been raised by a strict mother. From what she’d told him, Mrs. Becker had been woefully restrictive. Mean, sometimes too. It had dwindled. He’d seen it dwindle. As she got older, Carol Becker seemed to let it go. Like she’d done her part. Her work was done—she’d raised an over-achiever. She did too. Maggie was smart and driven, creative, and astoundingly responsible. She’d suffered though, and for that he was sorry. In the time that he’d dated her, the last four years, Carol had let those reins

slacken and now Maggie barely mentioned her harsh childhood. Carol didn't hound her anymore, just kept on top of her grades. Maggie had straight As. But her mom had scoffed recently at her graduating at magna rather than summa. Max had seen it himself that day and it surprised him. He witnessed it. He'd thought sometimes she'd exaggerated her tiger mother, but he didn't think that anymore. No, Carol Becker was intimidating. Hong Kong born, Ivy-educated, cut-throat corporate lawyer. Martin Becker was also frightening, but somehow when set next to his wife he seemed like your friend.

Visiting the Beckers always twisted him in knots. Today he was clean-shaven, all stubble carefully removed. Swiped clean like he'd swiped their daughter's pussy clean last week so she could fuck another guy. Hair groomed, combed to the side like a good boy. Like a good boy who would start a paid internship next summer at Kohl-Kravitz. A job on Wall Street that he found on his own, without the help of Martin Becker. He was proud of that. Proud that, despite his future father-in-law's powerful connections, he didn't ask for any help.

Maggie pulled her ear buds out as they made it through Jamestown and into the quiet wooded comfort of the southern point of the island. She pointed out the streets to Cole, showing him which way to turn as he negotiated the narrow wooded hills, making his way to the southern coast.

"This is it here," she said finally as they wound up a steep knoll, felt themselves slump back in the Jeep's stiff seats. "On the left," she said.

The Becker's home was down a wooded colonnade, pausing at a blank and modern iron gate that stretched across from a sleek stone column, then disappearing into the fiery brush on the other side. She had her key chain in her hand, both hands poised over her open purse set in her lap. Her thumb pressed a button and the gate swung open as they approached. Through the trees they could see the Becker's home.

"Holy shit, Maggie," Cole said. "This is where you grew up?"

"Yup," she said, with little interest.

Maggie grew up in this Manhattan architect designed contemporary masterpiece. Steel and glass and metal railings. The odd support beam in polished vintage sailing ship masts. It won an award when it was built in 2005, the year she moved here from Holland. Featured in multiple magazines for its design and for the interior decorating that was also

Manhattan-hired. Eight-thousand square feet set on a short cliff that fell down to a breathtaking view of Narraganset Bay.

“What do your folks do, again?”

She turned to Cole, eyes still on the bay, said, “My mom is a corporate lawyer. My dad is in real estate and stock speculation.” Then added, “Mom doesn't have to work she just loves breaking opponents.”

MAGGIE MET her mother and her brother in the foyer. Ken was home from Stanford for the weekend. Second year in Stanford Med and doing a graduate program in bioengineering. He looked thin and tired.

“Oh Ken,” she said, overwhelmed with affection. She knew he'd be here today, she was just surprised how much she missed him. They hugged and over her shoulder she heard Max stiffly greet her mother. Max was Carol-approved, but she scared the shit out of Max. That was probably what had made him Carol-approved.

“Maggie, Maggie, I haven't seen you in so long,” Ken said in her ear as he hugged her. “What's with the hair?”

Her mom said, “We don't talk about her hair,” and she leaned to Maggie and put her dispassionate arms around her shoulders and they touched cheeks. She frowned at Maggie, closed her eyes, disgusted, held a hand up between them and shook her head. “The hair,” she said. “She looks like garbage.”

“Mom, Ken,” Maggie said, as though she hadn't said something so brutal, “this is our Best Man, Cole. He goes to Farmingham with us.”

Cole stood on her cold childhood doorstep with a confident smile. He was a big handsome white preppy kid with long blonde hair and that was Carol's type. Cole did look like a young Martin Becker.

Carol folded her arms and looked Cole over. Said, “Hm. He's going to look good in the pictures.” That's what she said. Cole had been approved for the wedding.

“Pleased to meet you, Mrs. Becker,” Cole said and held a hand out, charmed her with his blue eyes. Carol took his hand and held it, they gently shook and her mom's eyes bored into his. Cole's eyebrows lifted, bemused. Carol was powerless over him. For now, probably, she was scanning for weaknesses.

“You’re at Farmingham,” she said, not as a question. Maggie worried she would grill him about his grades. She hadn’t warned Cole about her mother.

“Yes,” he said, letting her hand go and running his thumb along her fingers as he did. Flashed her a very white and handsome smile. *Careful, Cole, don’t put your fingers in her cage.* He said, “Government and Policy. With Max.”

Max stood at Cole’s left, proud to introduce his Best Man. “We roomed in Freshman year, and we’ve been inseparable since,” he said, throwing an arm around behind him and gripping his shoulder.

“As long as you’re not in Art. I worried about you when I saw the beard. Come in,” she said and she stepped aside, held a hand out, gesturing for them to pass into the kitchen.

Cole grimaced as he stepped past her, his eyes fleeting towards Maggie’s. She looked down.

Carol brought them all into their sleek and sterile kitchen and they congregated around a granite-topped island, the young ones leaning on it on their elbows. Cole looked up and around the ridiculously high ceiling, eyes getting fixed on the towering old ship mast that ran up the center.

“This house is beautiful,” Cole said to her mother. Maggie bristled, worried about potential disastrous routes in an exchange between Cole and her mother.

“Do you know anything about architecture?”

“Not really,” he said.

Carol moved next to him, fixed him with a severe and orgulous gaze. She said, “It was designed by Heinz Mueller—”

Cole interrupted her, making Maggie flinch, “HMA, yeah, they won the ARK prize this year.”

Carol smiled, symmetrical and cold, all mechanical, no warmth in her black eyes. But she put a hand out and she gripped Cole lightly above his elbow, her thumb moving up and down his bicep. She said, “Max, will you take Cole up to the guest room? Margaret, get yourself ready for dinner. We eat in an hour, we have company coming.”

THOUGH MAX and Maggie were to be married, Carol and Martin had them staying in their home situated in separate rooms. Maggie was sleeping in her own bedroom and Carol put Max and Cole together in a guest room that looked out over Narragansett Bay.

Max and Cole carried their overnight bags up the steel steps to the second floor, Cole with his raven head tucked under his arm.

“Why are you bringing that in?”

Cole said, “It's going to be cold tonight, I don't want its feathers to get damaged.”

Max said, “Can I be in your Secret Society, please?”

“You and I *are* the Secret Society. You, me, and Maggie.”

“What are we supposed to do?”

“I don't know yet. Be awesome...”

“Already are,” Max said as they went in together to the room. It was ten-feet tall, spacious, with cold concrete walls and steel beams. There was a balcony out their window, railing in metal and braided cable. Standing in the center of the room it could look like you were on a ship at sea. There were two queen size beds with charcoal bedding, the furniture was sleek and glossy; life and color provided by a vase of fresh flowers on a dresser facing the feet of the bed and a Jackson Pollock above the headboards in shades of steel with splashes of blood red.

Cole claimed his bed by tossing his bag on it. He set his raven head on a table at the floor to ceiling window looking over the bay. “Max, I knew her parents were loaded, but...”

Max said, “This is just their Rhode Island home.”

Cole said, “Yeah, they have a home in Holland...”

“Holland, a condo in Hong Kong, and a cabin upstate.”

“Yeah,” Cole said. “Maggie’s talked about the cabin.”

Max quietly asked, “What do you think of Carol?”

He huffed, made his lips flap, and raised his eyebrows, said, “Intense.”

“I know.”

“What's her dad like?” Cole said, turning the raven so it could watch out over the water.

Max said, “Less intense. Still intense.”

“How did Maggie turn out so sweet?”

“I don't know. She just is, I guess.”

Cole watched him a moment without saying anything. He moved between the beds, turned to him, waited another moment, then said, "Max, I know I've said that I'm honored to be your Best Man. I've said it flippantly. Trying to make light of it. But really..." He sat on the bed and hunched forward, looking towards Max but not in his eyes. "Really, it means a lot. And I am truly honored. I am...I couldn't ask for better friends. You and Maggie both. You're really special people to me."

Max said, "Can I be flippant?"

"If you want to be a real asshole now, yeah," he laughed.

Max sat next to him on the bed and he thumped Cole's knee with his fist. "I wouldn't have made it through Farmingham without you."

"Yeah, you would have."

"Yeah. I wouldn't want to."

"This where we kiss?" Cole said, looking soulfully in his eyes.

"It's your move, buddy."

"I'm happy for you, Max. You found a real gem. Maggie is the most special girl I know. That I've ever met..."

"I know how lucky I am."

"You deserve it. You're a good dude. You're good to her."

"She's my Maggie. I'd do anything for her."

"Speak of the devil," Cole said.

Max looked to see his beautiful fiancée standing in the metal framed doorway. She had changed her clothes. Black skirt and black leggings, black cashmere sweater. Comfortable but neat. No sloppy lounging around the Becker house.

"Hey, you two," she said. "Father's home. You better come meet him."

MAGGIE LED Max and Cole down to meet her father. They went out through the antiseptic kitchen, onto the gravel and walked the curve of the drive to a low flat-roof garage that was separate from the house.

Max walked with nervous tension and Cole sauntered next to him with his hands in his pockets, gaze cast out over the bay, watching the sailboats out there, his messy blonde hair whipping around.

Father was home from golf, stepping out of his black SL roadster. He brought another man home with him. A stocky fine-boned man with a big belly and a red booze-blasted nose. They were both dressed for sport, in polos and slacks, the man with the belly had a Callaway cap pulled low over his thick-lens glasses.

“Hi, Father,” she said as they stepped from the gravel to the squeaky polished cement of his immaculate garage.

“Margaret,” he said loudly into his open car as he pulled out his windbreaker from the backseat. He turned then and she went to him and he took one of her hands and kissed her cheek.

“Max,” he said, holding his jacket in one hand and shaking Max’s hand. “How’s school?” he asked. Martin and Carol kept very close eye on her grades and they’d like to get the same sort of Intelligence on her future husband.

“Great, Martin,” he said, knowing the routine. He said, “4.0.”

Her father didn’t respond. He wasn’t impressed, Max was doing what he was supposed to.

Maggie said, "Father, this is Cole. I told you about him. He's our Best Man."

Her father looked him over and shook his hand while Cole nodded, shook firmly, and said, "Sir."

While Max was polite and acquiescent, properly dressed and groomed, Cole had a roguish charm. He wore the right clothes but they were unkempt. Untucked black polo, wrinkled khakis, scuffed Sperrys. His hair was wild and his beard was coarse. But he was fit and athletic, he had his summer tan, and fierce dazzling eyes. He was the man her father was at twenty-one. Martin was expressionless but she knew him, could tell he liked Cole and that pleased her.

"Oh," he said then, as an afterthought, "This is Hartley Westlake. Winter-Oxbow." The way he said it making her think it was an investment bank.

"Hey," the man said, and he shook all their hands, his voice a phlegmy crackle like there was something wrong with him.

Father took Hartley aside a moment and they talked quietly. Her father towered over him. Martin looked impressive even now in his mid-fifties. Six-two and thick salt-and-pepper hair. He commanded a room. Commanded this garage. She turned to Max and Cole, not sure what to do now.

Martin led Hartley up the drive, still engaged in whatever discussion of high-finance they were having and he said over his shoulder, "Max, would you put my clubs away, then you and Cole please meet me up in my office."

COLE INVESTIGATED Martin's liquor cabinet while they waited. It made Max nervous, feeling like he'd be in trouble if Cole got caught. Cole squeaked crystal lids off crystal decanters and sniffed their amber contents.

"Cole, come on," Max said.

Cole said, "It's all right, I'm not drinking it... There's no bottles," he said, looking over the black wooden shelves. "I can't tell what they are but they've got to be some elite-level whiskeys, right?"

"Yeah, probably," Max said, twisting in one of the chairs that sat in front of Martin's desk in his office. A room as austere as the rest of the

house. The view brought the room alive, a windy day out there and sailboats sliced across the bay.

“Cole, seriously,” Max hissed as he tilted a decanter to his lips.

“Wish I had a hip flask,” he said. Then, “Hey, did you see that Porsche?”

“In his garage?”

“Yeah, like a 550 Spyder.”

“I know. He has more cars in storage in Newport. That's just the one he's driving right now.”

“I fucking love Martin's style, Max,” he laughed, another decanter to his lips. He pressed the back of his hand to his mouth, said, “I wonder how expensive this is?”

The sound of footsteps on stone carried from the hall and Cole put the crystal down and took a spot in a chair next to Max, bringing him great relief.

Martin came into the room talking on his phone. He spoke in Dutch, and Cole and Max looked at each other. Cole nudged his foot and smiled, mouthed, *Relax*.

They sat in silence and waited, Max's feet jumping in triple time. When Martin was done he placed his phone down carefully.

“Max,” he said, getting right to business. “School is well?”

“Yes, sir.”

“Good,” he said. He took his spot on the official side of the desk and sat. “I approved the marriage. But you are young. You're both very young. I don't want the planning of the wedding to interfere with Margaret's work, yes?”

“I know, sir.”

“So,” he said, leaning further forward. “I know young men like to have fun. Joke. Yes? Tomorrow,” he said, “I want one-hundred-percent. We've got a lot to do, I want you in bed early, we accomplish what we need. Because, on Monday, it's back to school. I don't want Margaret thinking about this. The planning of the wedding? ...Carol will do that.”

“Yes, sir.”

“Bed early, yes? One beer,” he laughed. Eased, said, “Maybe two,” lightening them up. Even Cole laughed.

Then, serious as stone, he leaned in again, said, “Max. The wedding is ten months. You graduate in seven. You will be my Margaret's husband.

Your plan?"

Max bristled. Felt challenged. This was normal for Martin but he felt belittled in front of Cole. He could sense the discomfort. But he had proud news so he was undaunted. "Martin, I, uh, I'm going to Wall Street."

Martin didn't beam. It was the kind of news he wanted to hear but pragmatic as he was he needed more than stated intentions. "I start the day after our honeymoon at Kohl-Kravitz."

Martin sat up straight, looked at the ceiling, thinking.

Max said, "Paid internship. But they'll arrange for my accredita—"

"KK is," he mimicked sleeping like a little boy. "After your honeymoon I want you at Oxbow."

"But, Martin, I've made my int—"

"It's done," he said, with a dismissive wave of four fingers. "It's for the best. I will send you Hartley's contact."

In his periphery Max could see Cole's eyebrows raise. He felt shame, felt his own face go red.

"Now, you," he said directly to Cole, swiveling to face him. "You know my daughter?"

"Maggie...Margaret is my very good friend, sir. I'm friends with Max, but Maggie...Margaret is very important to me. I'm there for both of them."

"Good," he smiled. "You'll shave the day of the wedding?"

"Of course, sir," Cole smiled.

"What do you do?"

"Government and Policy, sir. Beltway bound."

"Law school?"

"Harvard, next fall."

"Sport?"

"Lacrosse. Midfielder."

It made Martin smile. He clapped his big hands together and then leaned forward again. Although he was well-groomed and elegant, there was a noticeable masculinity to him. He was lean but big, heavy-boned with large hands and joints. "And, Cole, what do I need to tell you about the Bachelor Party?"

"Nothing, sir," Cole said.

He held Cole's eyes a while, then eased back in his chair, said, "Good. That's all. Go," he waved them away, acting like he was annoyed. "Dinner is in forty-five minutes. Carol invited two of Margaret's best friends. Tell

her. I've got work to do," he said as he took his phone up again and started dialing.

"WHAT?" Maggie exclaimed.

Ken said, "Susie Kim and Lee Wu."

"Oh, come on, she has no clue..." Maggie groaned, putting her face in her hands as she sunk into an upholstered chair in the conservatory.

"It's the first nice thing she's done. She didn't let you see your friends when you were in high school...she's loosening up..."

"She has no idea who my friends are...or were. Or...even what Lee might...you know... Be to me..."

Ken's face went shocked, "Oh no, really? Oh, Maggie. Want me to tell her?"

She laughed. "Oh, can you imagine?"

"I'll tell her, Mom, you invited a guy Maggie had sex with to have dinner with her and her fiancé."

"She'd build a time machine to go back and stop him."

"Yeah. She'll think Lee was the reason you ended up in Art."

"Hey!"

"I'm kidding...Maggie..." he said as he put his arms around her shoulders.

They were in a concrete hall designed specifically for acoustics by two engineers from Boston. It had fabric panels screwed to the wall, angled with precision to the two Louis XIV chairs that she and Ken were sitting in. Ahead of them were a gleaming black grand piano and, resting in a stand, a polished cello. The two of them had spent thousands of hours in this room practicing. Sometimes she thought she would go crazy. It all seemed so long ago even though it was just a few years. She'd been so scared then. Still carried some of it, so did Ken, but it was nice to sit here in this cold scary room and not feel desperate. She felt like she had survived something.

"It's good to see you," Ken said with sudden thoughtfulness.

She said, "You okay?"

"Mm," he shrugged. "Tired."

They both heard Max and Cole before they saw them. Coming down the stairs from the second floor, trying to be quiet, trying to stifle laughter but

the act of preventing it making it burst out louder. They were whispering to each other.

They passed the square archway to the conservatory without seeing her and her brother, and Ken called out, "There's no laughing in here, guys."

The two of them came into the conservatory and they swallowed their smiles, worried that he might be serious. He didn't let them off the hook.

Maggie said, "He's kidding. What's so funny?"

Cole said, "We just got..." he looked around, worried, then got close and whispered, "We got put on the straight and narrow."

"I hope you guys weren't here to have fun," Ken said.

Cole said to Ken, "Hey, I hope you don't think we're making fun of your dad..."

Ken waved it off, said, "No way, I know...what did he tell you? ...Don't mess around tomorrow because he's got a lot to do? ...He hates nonsense."

"Yeah," Max said. "Pretty much, exactly."

"And more," Cole said, but he didn't elaborate.

Ken said, "Mom invited Maggie's old boy-toy."

"Ken," she said, slapping his arm.

"Oh, sorry," he said, rubbing where she'd hit him, his face conveying his realization maybe he shouldn't have said that.

Max tried to keep a brave face, but all that humor he came in with fell away. He said, "Who?"

Maggie slumped forward, elbows on her knees, she said, "Nobody. Lee."

"The one who played bass?"

"Yeah," she said.

BOTH KEN and Cole noticed Max's discomfort.

Cole scratched his cheek, said to Ken, "Boy, this place is stressful. What do you do to calm your nerves?"

Ken said, "Well, there's a bar in the living room."

Cole said, "Will you lead the way?"

"I will, sir," Ken answered and he headed towards the arch that led to the hall.

“We’ll catch up,” Maggie said quietly as they walked out. They acknowledged her, left laughing about something Cole said. Max watched them go down the hall and disappear under a different arch. He sighed, turned to Maggie and looked at her a moment. She raised her eyebrows and tilted her head, shrugged.

“Why did your mom invite him?” he asked her.

Maggie pushed herself to one side of the chair and she pat the edge for him to come and join her. When he sat down she squirmed next to him in the tight space and she slipped a bent leg up on to his lap and she faced him.

“She doesn’t know, Max. You think she knows?”

“Right,” he agreed.

Her hand came to his face and she stroked his cheek and tried to get him to look in her eyes. “You have a baby face,” she said.

“I hate shaving,” he murmured.

She kissed his cheek.

He asked her, “Is this...how weird is this for you?”

“Lee? Pretty weird. I wish Ken hadn’t said anything. It makes it weirder.”

“Why?”

She groaned and she put her forehead against his shoulder. “He’s...” she started to laugh.

“What?”

“He’s not very...cool.”

“Aw, Maggie,” he laughed and he squeezed her arm and made her close her eyes.

“I need to tell you something.”

“What is it?” he said.

“I was embarrassed before. I never told you...something...”

“Yeah?”

She hesitated, worked her mouth around. At last, said, “You’re my only...Lee is the only other boy I slept with.”

“What?” He feigned surprise, horrified at the thought of her finding out he had hid in her closet.

“You and Lee. And then Jay. That’s it. Before you, there was only Lee.”

“Oh,” he said. Then to be supportive, said, “I thought...I thought maybe...Remember I said that?”

“You were right,” she said. “Do you think...when you met me and we finally...did it...did you think I was good?”

“Maggie...” he rolled his eyes.

“No, really, Max, I thought about it a lot back then. I worried so much...”

“I didn’t think anything except how much I was in love with you.”

“Aw, Maxy,” she said and she kissed his shoulder.

“Really. You were great. I didn’t think at all that you were inexperienced. He slipped an arm around her, and they sat awhile in her spacious music room, squished together in an uncomfortable chair. “I’m going to have dinner with the boy my fiancée lost her virginity to?”

“You are,” she said. “Max?”

“What now?”

“It was only one time with Lee. We didn’t date.”

“Oh. Really?”

“Yeah. I only had sex one time before I met you.”

He put his hand over her knee that was folded in his lap and he kissed her forehead. “Was it good?”

“Max,” she laughed.

“Tell me,” he said. “If you want to.”

She wiggled herself closer to him, whispered, “Really?”

“If you tell me, I will have a complete knowledge of all the men you’ve slept with.”

She giggled. “You even watched,” she whispered.

“You were so amazing.”

Her hand went over his and he was aware she was looking in his eyes. He lowered his and stared into her. She smiled, kissed his shoulder again.

“I lost my virginity at Tanglewood,” she whispered close to his ear, then settled back to look in his eyes again.

He laughed. Tanglewood was an elite music academy. “This one time, at band camp...”

Maggie rolled her eyes, said, “Kind of. It was a weekend. We were there for a symphony. And we were supposed to play, part of a high school festival. There were lots of students, we were playing at the Shed, and we had hotel rooms. I felt really grown up. Independent.”

“How old were you?”

“Seventeen.” Her hand held his more firmly. He felt a tug, a guiding urge travel from her hand to his. “A year before I met you.”

His hand was led up the fabric of her tights, hers riding on top. Traveled the inside of her thigh, from her knee to the point where her skirt touched her leg.

“Did he wear a condom?”

She whispered, “I was a good girl, Daddy.”

A sexual surge hit him so hard he flinched. He gripped the flesh on the inside of her thigh and she gasped.

“Did you put him in your mouth?”

“No,” she whispered.

“Was he big?”

“Bigger than you,” she whispered and she leaned her face close and he met her lips for a kiss.

His hand slipped under her skirt and went up between her legs. She parted them, let her bent leg push higher up his lap. He felt his cock swelling in his pants. Like she knew, her hand went to him. His cock was upright in his chinos and she found his tip and her tented fingers stroked it through the cotton.

“I want to fuck you so bad, Maggie.”

“I have plans,” she said.

“Mm,” he laughed, his fingers stroking her sex through her tights. “Maggie? You’re not wearing underwear?”

“No,” she laughed.

“You’re so hot.”

“I want to fuck in this room.”

“Now?” he jolted, eyes wide.

“No, no. This room has a lot of bad memories. This room needs an exorcism.”

“We can do that,” he said, and he kissed her.

“I want to do something really bad in this room,” she whispered. Whispered it to the room, looking away from him now, and her eyes going up and around the four tall corners of the grim concrete space.

“You want to punish it?”

Her eyes came back to his and she looked at him earnestly and said, “That’s exactly it.”

Her hand joined his up her skirt and she pulled the waist of her tights away.

“Maggie,” he sighed in lust and disbelief. He looked out the archway at the space beyond the room, a space where any of the Beckers could walk by. They were sideways to the arch and it would be hard to miss what they were doing.

He touched the bare skin of her belly, felt its smoothness under his fingers. Let his hand pivot, turn upside down, and his bunched fingers eased down to where she was hot and wet. Her eyes were on his and she made his cock ache painfully for her.

She smiled as he began to stroke her, feel her wetness, and spread it through her folds. He slipped a finger inside her.

She said, “I want to tell Jay you watch.”

“What? Oh...Maggie, I don’t know...”

“I’m telling him, Max.”

“Why?”

“I’m going to have sex with him on Thursday and I don’t want you in the closet.”

“You don’t?” he said, feeling her sexual energy frighten him. Her pussy made wet popping sounds under his touch.

“Mm,” she said and she pushed her sex against his fingers and narrowed her eyes. Her hand went over the front of her skirt and pressed him tighter against her, making his finger slip deeper.

“I want you closer,” she said.

His heart hammered. This sweet girl who he’d proposed to was becoming a demon. He loved it. It was thrilling to watch. He liked how she scared him. Looking at him now through upturned eyelashes, narrow eyes like deadly slits, plump lips parted with lust. Her pussy was sopping in two strokes of his finger. She was always sexual, always responsive to his touch, but the last ten days had been more powerful than ever. His Maggie was becoming someone else in a way. She was discovering something about herself. And it was kinky. And he wanted it. As much as it scared him, he wanted it.

“What are you saying, Maggie?”

“You know...” she said, her voice a breathy whisper.

Footsteps echoed from the hall. More than one person on their way.

She hiked her skirt down, ripping it along his forearm in the same instant he yanked his hand away. She sat up straight, in time to see visitors approaching the archway, setting her loafers flat on the stone floor. Max didn't know what to do with his hand. It was soaking. He could see it glisten in his periphery, made slick with the excitement of the woman he was head over heels in love with. He snickered, and she did too. He saw Carol coming and he was so clutched with fear his brain didn't know what to do. He laughed, tried to chase it away and laughed louder. Maggie nudged him. He put his fingers in his mouth.

Carol stepped down into the conservatory and she had two young adults with her, Suzie and Lee he presumed. He sucked his fingers, curled them up in a loose fist so it didn't look like he was sucking his fingers like a mental patient, just maybe a pensive young man deep in thought.

Carol gave an odd smile as she approached. Odd in that she didn't normally smile. She seemed pleased with herself, she said, "Look who's here, Margaret. I've invited your friends for dinner."

Max witnessed a strange exchange. Witnessed the stunted Maggie of the youth he missed, the one before she escaped her chokehold and got to breathe sweet freedom in the forests of Vermont.

Old friends apparently, her and Suzie, yet they gave each other a curt nod, and a brief handshake. The same went for Lee. Not a word spoken. No cooing at time lost, at the way their faces had changed in the last four years. Just a *How do you do?* Max wiped his hand on the back of his pants, in time for Carol to introduce him.

"And this is Margaret's fiancé," she said, very cordially, to them. And they nodded like they knew who he was, as though they'd been following along in newsletters. "He's at Farmingham with Margaret. 4.0. And he starts at Oxbow in the summer."

He shook Suzie's hand first, a limp sort of powerless piece of flesh and she bit her own lip on the inside of her mouth, and nodded, but averted her eyes. Lee's hand was as weak and clammy as Suzie's. A lifeless handshake, and when Max stared into Lee's eyes he averted his gaze as well. This was the boy who had taken his Maggie's virginity. He had something between his legs that had slipped inside his love. He would be mad if Lee wasn't so damn anemic. His eyes looked down to the floor. He was tall and thin, Chinese he supposed, given the last name, and he had modest glasses.

Max could see Maggie looking at the side of his head and he turned and she mouthed, *Oxbow?*

He shook his head, waved his hand mildly, indicating he'd tell her later. Emerging in the background, coming into the hall outside of the conservatory from way of the kitchen were Cole and Ken. They had cocktails in hand, probably gin and tonics, and when they saw Carol and Lee and Suzie they darted out of the hall and back into the kitchen. He could hear a laugh from Cole.

Carol said, "Suzie and Lee are both at MIT, they come home on the weekends though. They love their mothers."

Lee's face broke as if he was laughing but he didn't make a sound. His eyes were on Maggie.

Max couldn't believe this was the guy that his hot little woman had slept with. *This was the boy who had broke her cherry?* He didn't seem like he was the guy who would take a girl's cherry. Let alone someone as incredible as Maggie. Lee, he felt bad to admit it, may not have had sex since that night at Tanglewood with Maggie. But if he'd like, he could give his hand sniff. Get a thrill, for old time's sake.

DINNER WAS UNCOMFORTABLE. Eight people sitting at a table long enough for twenty. There was not much conversation to be had. It was very different from the warm and supportive Milton family dining table back in Traverse City. Two brothers, a sister—and his dad holding court, applauded by mom, Dad's biggest admirer.

They talked about the usual things the Beckers talked about. About school and about prospects. They talked about the schedule for tomorrow. They took a few laps around that one. Caterer, church, music, venue... All were to be decided by end of day tomorrow. Next weekend Maggie would return and they would plan her dress. Then there was to be no more talk about the planning of the wedding. Once those tasks, spread over only two days, had been addressed there was to be no more distractions. Carol would take care of the day to day.

It was impersonal in a way, except that Carol was family of course. They seemed pushed out of their own wedding. Of course, Max had no illusions going into this that it would be any other way. Frankly, it might be

a relief not to have to plan the wedding. And it would be a relief to know that with Carol at the helm it would be run with precision. If they were left to do it on their own, and Carol was to be a guest, the panic would be immeasurable. This was for the best. He just hoped Maggie thought so.

After dinner they were given a treat. The Becker conservatory didn't have a bass but Lee was also a master pianist. He sat at the grand and Max and Cole sat in the padded chairs facing the piano. Ken sat on the other side of Cole with Suzie, and Maggie's parents stood behind them all with difficult smiles.

Max watched his poor girl take up her cello and tune it. Her face had changed. A light had switched off. She wasn't there. Her eyes didn't catch his. Graceful long-fingered hands went in practiced patterns, tuning and plucking, examining her bow with placid determination.

Then there was a collective breath, a silence, and the two of them readied themselves. Maggie still played. She took music in the first two years at Farmingham but she didn't anymore. He'd seen her play before. She was a gifted musician.

Her hand worked the bow. Her eyes closed, her expression like she was distant. Her mind was elsewhere, but her eyebrows would bow with the emotion of the song. Boccherini again. It made him cry. It was a composition he'd associated with her. She played it many times. When she was stressed, when things were tough. It did something to her. His eyes grew wet with emotion. He felt his heart bursting for her. If there weren't all these people watching, he would step right up to her and put his arms around her. She played like she was in pain. Like she was in mourning. His breath trembled. He made fists to keep it together. The last thing he needed was to have Carol or Martin witness him crying. Who knows what that would mean to them. He didn't imagine it would be good. He turned away. Couldn't watch her make those doleful notes anymore, the sound was killing him. He caught Suzie staring at Cole. Cole watched Maggie, his eyes darting over her hands as they worked. But he was being watched. Someone had a crush on him. Suzie was cute. A little out of shape, probably used to hunching over books, or microscopes, rather than exercising. But she had a pretty face and a nice smile.

When Maggie finished and the song descended from its crescendo, the piano stopped and all eyes were on Maggie, she groaned out a long dying note that got his eyes wet again. She set the bow down, her eyes still closed.

They all clapped politely for her but Max was overwhelmed again. She needed to recover from her performance. Sitting still with bowed head and closed eyes, her face was blank. Like she was crying inside, struggling with something. Then, without looking up, she went through the silent machinations of putting her cello and bow away. Lee sat at the piano and his sad eyes were bolted to Maggie but she wouldn't acknowledge him.

Martin looked at his Rolex, said, "Well, it is getting late, I think we should call it an evening."

Ken said, "We were going to go down to the beach."

Carol looked at her own Rolex and said, "It's nine o'clock." Making it sound like that was late.

Narragansett

FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 29TH

“WE ONLY HAVE AN HOUR,” Ken said.

Cole said, “I’ve built plenty of fires, it doesn’t take long.”

Cole had a bundle of kindling in his arms he’d liberated from a porcelain bin that sat in the family room next to the yawning square mouth of a concrete fireplace.

They’d been given an hour long grace. One more hour before bed, and Maggie wanted to show Cole their beach. Cole wanted to have a fire. That made Ken nervous.

They stood now on the black pebble macadam of shore that ran in a crescent. The gentle lapping of Narragansett Bay sounded at their backs. They were shielded from view of the Beckers home by a fifteen foot black rock cliff that glistened wet in the fading light.

In a ragged group, holding bottles of beer, they had come across the short rocky swatch from the house to the trail that wound down the cliff. It was chilly but pleasant enough with a jacket. Once they had all passed down the trail, Maggie and Ken and her friend Suzie changed. It was noticeable. Like they’d been holding their breath and were now getting the first taste of much needed air. Descending the path and turning onto the beach, Suzie had skipped a step and caught up to Cole. She let him see her smile, and tossed her hair in the breeze. Flirting with him. Like she was a normal person. Four hours he’d spent with her in the house and he honestly wouldn’t have been surprised to find out she was on the autism spectrum. One minute out of sight of the Beckers she was a horny little girl.

Lee, on the other hand, was wedged tightly in his shell. He'd bonded to his shell. And even now out of the strict gaze of Maggie's parents he was still his uncomfortable self. He'd straggled at the back of the group, a reluctant attendee, and Max had to encourage Maggie to welcome him. She rolled her eyes and it struck Max as oddly cruel.

Maggie went to Lee. They both walked with their hands in their pockets and had stiff conversation, Lee looked to Maggie, wanted her to return his gaze. Maggie looked at her shoes.

Max helped Cole and Ken arrange larger rocks in a ring next to a large disembodied tree trunk that lay on its side on the black beach, silvered by the weather. Cole arranged kindling in a neat little A-frame and as he tried to get some paper lit Ken came close to Max and he said, "Hey, I shouldn't have mentioned that. About Lee."

"It's okay. I know about him."

"My mother doesn't. She wouldn't do that on purpose."

"I know."

"She likes you."

When Cole's fire took hold Suzie got off the trunk where she'd been watching and she came to him with a happy face and said, "You're so awesome." She squat next to him and put an arm around him, her gaze in the growing fire. Cole put his hand on her knee.

Maggie was sitting with Lee who was telling her a story or something that involved drawing in the beach with a long jagged gray branch. She rose while he was talking, and Max watched Lee finish his sentence to her turned back. Maggie walked away from him and went to Cole. She put her arm around him from the other side and told Suzie to go up to the house and get some blankets. Told her where they were in the mudroom. Lee drew with his stick in the beach, his sad gaze turned down. Suzie was perplexed, looked from Cole to Maggie and back but she went up to the house and in a few minutes she returned with an armful of folded blankets.

They sat along the log, Ken took a spot on a black rock close to the fire. Maggie sat next to Cole and Suzie on the other side. Max tried to engage Lee but he wasn't a conversationalist and seemed content to draw in the sand despite how miserable his expression seemed. Max was surprised he stayed. Cole got along with Ken, and Suzie hugged his arm a lot. At ten o'clock on the nose Suzie's phone vibrated in her padded down jacket. She

withdrew it, read the screen and in an instant she was the same girl he'd met in the conservatory and who he'd had dinner with.

She said, "It's Mrs. Becker. She says it's time to go."

Cole made to move like he would walk her up to her car but Maggie held his arm. "Don't you dare. I don't want my right side to be cold."

Suzie said, "Your mom asked me to remind you that you have to go to bed."

Maggie said, "Okay, okay. Bye, Suzie. Nice seeing you again." She leaned her head behind Cole, said to Lee, "Bye, Lee. Take care."

Lee waved weakly, his ring-shaped lips puffed in an awkward smile, then he turned towards the path.

Ken rose, gestured to the trail and said, "I'll walk you guys back up to the house."

Cole put an arm out and said, "Ken, can you bring some beers down when you come back?"

"I'm not coming back."

"Why not?"

"I'm going to bed, Cole," Ken laughed.

"Du-u-de, you're letting me down."

"I'll see you in the morning," he said. "Bright and early," he added, smiling and cocking his head. He led Lee and Suzie up the path, disappearing in the dark.

"You are so mean, Maggie," Max said.

"What?" she said, eyebrows lowered defensively.

"To Suzie and Lee. You hardly paid them any attention."

She shrugged, her face morose, she murmured, "I didn't invite them. I wanted it to be just us three."

"It's us three now," Cole said and threw an arm around her.

She brightened said to Cole, "Was it bad? I just wasn't in the mood to entertain them..."

Cole squeezed her neck in the crook of his elbow and said, "Max is making too big a deal. It was fine."

Max said to Cole, "You get Suzie's number?"

"Ew," Maggie said.

Cole said, "Yeah. If she'd stayed I wouldn't mind seeing what happened." He winked to Maggie.

She threw her arms around his shoulders and said, “No! Tonight you’re mine!” Laughing and hugging him tight she kicked her legs like she was wrestling but he held his posture firm and she couldn't budge him. She laughed and gave up and he winked at her again, and pinched the back of her neck in his grip.

Max went quiet and watched Maggie and Cole. Their faces were lit by the fire’s warm glow, the color of their clothes saturated by its blazing amber hue. They sat side by side, not touching now but sitting very close, both of them throwing their gaze out over the bay. Max’s heart began to pump with awful excitement. Maggie couldn't sleep with Cole—that would be forbidden. He wouldn't allow that, but seeing what it would be like had filled him with an ecstatic anxiety that was sending a hardness through his shaft. He stopped himself from chewing his lip when it started to hurt. The idea of Maggie and Cole together was so taboo, so awful but it was driving his pulse mad right now.

Max stuttered, “You want...you want me to...I could go get some beers...”

“Fuck yes,” Cole said dryly with no hesitation.

“Look at brave Max,” Maggie said. “What if you encounter the dreaded minotaur? ...watching you sneak his beer while looking at his watch...”

“It’s your bedtime, Max,” Cole joined in, saying it in a decent Dutch accent, impersonating Martin.

“Ha. Ha,” Max said, pronouncing the two words with deliberate precision. “Martin gave us some leeway on the hops.”

“He did,” Cole said to Maggie, looking at her and nodding in affirmation.

“I don't care,” she laughed. “Drink as many beers as you want.”

“Yeah,” Max said, “Yeah.”

He held his hands clasped together, his thumbs going around each other in winding circles, trying to build up the nerve to leave Cole and Maggie together. Fearful to do it, worried that she might try something with Cole but also wondering how he would feel if she did. *She couldn't*. Their friendship could never survive.

He went anyway, just for the thrill of his racing heartbeat. He got up, said, “Okay, beers? ...” and he held up three fingers. Cole and Maggie nodded. They were all in. He shuffled along the trail, curling up the path towards the house. His cock had grown plump in his underwear. His ears

were ringing with a high metallic note, like the bells on Maggie's bird cage. His heart hammered so hard it blurred his vision. He walked the path, dying to look back but getting an awful pleasure from denying himself. He let his imagination wander.

COLE SAID, "It's beautiful here, Maggie." He was looking out over the fire at the gentle lapping of the waves on the shore. It was black out there now, black sky and black water. An indigo swipe at the horizon lit up silver peaks on the water.

"It is. I wish I'd taken the time to enjoy it when I was younger. You grew up by the ocean?"

"Mm-hmm," he nodded. "Connecticut. Old Saybrook, but we weren't near the water. We'd party at the beach...but this is so peaceful. And it's all yours."

"We *didn't* party though. Not here. Actually, not anywhere," she clarified, then laughed.

He said, "I love it here. It's so peaceful."

"It's cold," she said. Shimmied her butt in the sand closer to Cole so that their hips touched. She looked up at his handsome face. He had sharp eyes, piercing blue, a strong stubbled jaw and blonde hair. The fire lit him from below, showed off the masculine ridges of his face and put a dancing light in the bottom curve of his eyes.

"What?" he laughed, catching her looking at him.

"Nothing," she said, smiling. Took her blanket and lifted it over his lap so they were both underneath and she snuggled into him. "You know...I...I never had a boyfriend when I lived here."

"You didn't?"

"No. I was kept busy. With schoolwork. But sometimes...God, this is so embarrassing."

"What?" he said, a smile pulling up one corner of his mouth.

"I had an imaginary boyfriend," she said and she covered her face and giggled into her hands.

"Oh my God, Maggie," he said, "You're so cute." His arm went around her in a friendly maneuver. A wind picked up and rustled the licking flames and she shivered. Wiggled herself into Cole's side.

“Yeah,” she said. “I’d have...oh, man...I’d have conversations with him here, down on the beach.”

She felt him shaking with a laugh, looked up to see him stifling it.

“Stop,” she said and poked him under the blanket. “It’s so sad. We were in love. We’d talk about all our dreams. He was very supportive.”

“You guys make out?”

She didn’t answer him. They’d done more than make out, but that was up in her bedroom, her hand moving quietly under her sheets and her other hand over her own mouth.

Cole said, “I feel like I might have had a girlfriend like that, too.”

“Yeah, when you were eleven,” she said. “I was, like, sixteen.”

“Oh poor Maggie,” he said and his hand gripped her shoulder and shook her lightly. “What was his name?”

She rolled her eyes and looked to him, said, “His name was Cole.”

His expression didn’t change, an expectant smile staying expectant. He’d anticipated laughing at her answer but his eyes darted over hers and she didn’t look away. She let the moment get awkward, enjoyed the tightness spreading in her belly. The waves lapped and the bay gently roared, the fire hissed and cracked. “I’m kidding,” she said, frowned her brow low and laughed, thumped her forehead against his jean jacket shoulder.

MAX CREPT FROM THE KITCHEN, slipping out the metal and glass door with two half-liter bottles of Dutch beer under his arm and one in his hand. The door closed quietly behind him on gas-powered hinges. Crunched his topsiders through gravel, worked his way along the path. He could see an orange glow from Cole’s fire. A hazy amber brume, sliced on the bottom third by the grassy silhouette of the cliff’s edge. Beyond was black, but he could hear the water, feel it too, feel the cold humidity in the air. A seagull called. The sky was black with cloud cover. He missed the stars. As the path curved, angled to run parallel to the beach and began to slope down to its level he slowed his step. Slowed so he would quiet his footsteps.

Maggie wouldn’t try anything with Cole and he knew Cole would never do it either but he entertained the fantasy. Wondered how it would feel to see them in union. His Maggie’s skinny legs wrapped tight around Cole’s hips as he thrust himself into her with his pants pulled down to his knees.

Max groaned in his mind. The dirty thought tickling the strangest, most libertine part of his brain. *Why was that so arousing?*

He moved with care, bottles gripped tight against his body so they wouldn't clink. He found the two of them close together. His scrotum tightened, rustled in his underwear and it hurt his heart far more than he could have anticipated. A rake shivered over his scalp and he shuddered. They were side by side at the fire. They shared a blanket. Maggie's pale hand lit up, spread open on the center of Cole's chest. Their faces were close. So close together. He took another step, two, three. Saw they were kissing. He stopped.

"Oh no. Oh, wow. Ow," he murmured.

His mouth trembled and jumped like he would cry. He was cloven by a heavy claymore. Betrayal. His two best friends without him. They were both cheating on him. His best friend kissing his fiancée. His fiancée rocking her mouth against his best friend's. The pain was exquisite. His legs trembled. His knees knocked. He dropped a bottle into the rocky sand.

Their faces came away from each other, Maggie's eyes locked on Cole's, and she sucked her own lips, over and over as her pose eased back to sit against the gray twisted trunk. Cole's back was to him. He turned, looked over in Max's direction, peeking from the corner of his eye. A terror there. Realizing they'd been seen. Cole sat back now too, his body wooden, his eyes wide. Max could see his jaw tremble. He stared into the fire with. Maggie wiped her mouth.

Max collected the bottle and walked the rest of the way to the fire on shaky legs. The muscles of his thighs and rump jumped and twitched.

"Hey," he said as he got to the fire. Held a bottle out to Cole. Cole stared into the fire, couldn't look at him. His hand came out and took the bottle. Maggie's eyes met Max's but he couldn't read her expression. Her mouth was puffy from kissing, held slack. Her eyes were wet, glistening with the fire's reflection. Her eyebrows were neither afraid nor confident.

"Here," he said, and he handed her a bottle.

He sat opposite them on the cold black stone Ken had used, not quite on the other side of the fire. He twisted his bottle cap and threw it in the flames. He took a drink.

Cole played with his bottle and looked ill. He groaned a draggy moan that sounded like a car having trouble starting. "Mm-mm maybe we should go to bed."

Maggie said, "We just opened our beers. We have some time."

She still sat with her body pressed next to Cole though he looked like he wanted to pull away. He was touching her but his posture was recoiling. He still couldn't look away from the fire. He opened his beer, took an unsteady drink.

Maggie had Max's eye now, but she wasn't communicating anything. He stared back. Kept himself as blank as she was. His breaths came shallow, barely perceptible. Almost as if he wasn't breathing but he knew he must be because he was still alive. All three of them turned their faces to the fire. All three of them thinking about what had just happened. Max's insides were clenched like a fist. Equally exciting as it was enraging.

MAGGIE TWISTED the base of her bottle in the sand, drilling it next to her like she was extinguishing a cigarette. She got the bottle to stay upright and Max could see she'd consumed half already, an amber line of bubbles dancing at the midway point. Twisted at her hips and wiped at her mouth, stared at the side of Cole's head, waiting for him to turn to her. When he did, when he could sense her staring for too long, not looking at her became uncomfortable. Their eyes met. Maggie jutted her chin to him, her mouth parted again. Cole looked away. Her hand reached to him, her engagement ring winking off sparks from the fire. She held his cheek on the far side and turned his face to hers. She kissed him. Moving slow, with a slight jerking hesitation, her mouth came to his. He didn't move to meet it, but when he felt her lips he took them. Then pulled away.

"Maggie..." he said, his head shook from bewilderment. He looked away. Afraid to look up and look at Max.

"It's okay, Cole," she whispered. She kissed the sharp line of his jaw, her palm smoothing his cheek, the sound of his stubble against her palm heard over the crackling fire. Max took another drink. Swallowed big, his Adam's apple jumping. He wiped his mouth with the back of his hand.

Cole's eyes wandered near Max's, his gaze settling somewhere in the middle of Max's chest. Maggie kissed and sucked at his neck.

Cole stammered, "I—I..."

Maggie's hand moved from his neck down his chest, under his jacket, low, below the blanket. Cole's breaths came fast. Her hand settled between

his legs, and Cole turned to her and their eyes met.

“Maggie,” he said. “Don’t.”

Maggie kept his gaze, her hand flipped the blanket away and Max could see what she was doing. She was rubbing his cock through his pants. Both hands went to his waist and she undid the fly on his cotton chinos.

“Hey, whoa...” he said. His hand rested on hers, but he didn't stop her.

Maggie worked her hand inside his opened fly. Max’s heart pounded and that incessant ringing returned. His hand clutched at his own chest under his jacket.

Maggie was having trouble and her other hand went in to help, two hands working inside his open fly now. They stared into each other's eyes. Maggie unwavering and determined, Cole frightened, aroused, and unsure.

“Oh wow,” she said when she had his cock out in the bare night. Her eyes lowered to see what her good friend had between his legs. Cole's eyes narrowed and his head wobbled on his neck. His cock was erect. Very big. Not as long as Jay but at least as thick, maybe thicker. He had a big bulbous glans and a tight foreskin that threatened to plop right down his shaft. Maggie stroked at the foreskin with a finger and thumb, rolling it over his corona and up again. Max wondered if Lee had a foreskin or if this was her first time seeing one.

She kissed Cole again and his lips worked against hers though they were reluctant. Maggie's forefinger tapped at the very tip of his cock, her pad bouncing in the concave shallow of Cole's urethra. Each upstroke of her finger drawing back a shimmering silvery bow. Cole’s excitement spewing from him. Max wondered if his best friend had long harbored feelings for Maggie. She was smart and beautiful. He had to. It was evident in the reaction of his body. Maggie had his erection out of his pants for less than a minute and he was streaming his lubrication down his shaft. It pooled against the flap of his fly where it scored across the base of his cock and Max could see his pants turn darker there where it was being absorbed. Maggie slipped up and down with her fingers, dancing them around his cock, exploring all his shapes and ridges, tracing over the paths of the thick veins. Their mouths still kissed and sucked but Cole's hands stayed at his sides and he was still hesitant.

Maggie pulled her hair back with one hand, her eyes darting to Max, then back to Cole's cock as she lowered her mouth to it.

“Whoah, Maggie,” Cole said, his eyes glued to the back of her head, watching it lower between his legs. She took the head of his cock in her mouth. The mouth that had said, *Yes, Max, a thousand times, yes*, when he'd got down on one knee and presented the ring he'd bought her with the help of his brother on a trip home to Michigan.

That mouth turned to a thin ring as it stretched around his best friend's very thick cock. She sunk down a few inches, sucked back up. Cole's head fell right back and both hands came up as fists and pressed into his own cheeks. He groaned, “Ah, mm, no, Maggie, no.”

She wasn't hearing him. Her head bobbing and twisting seductively, trying to please him. His Maggie trying to give a good blow job. Cole had lots of girls suck his cock, Max had heard about most of them, but he knew that this one was going to be forever remembered. Cole's legs shook when she plunged, his feet stretching out and digging into the beach, plowing dark sand around the white soles of his deck shoes. “Mm, ah, no,” he protested weakly.

Max wrung his brow, it came low and it winced like he might cry but he was dry. No tears came, though he felt on the verge of flooding. He shook his head. Shook it at Maggie, shook it at himself. He should stop this but he knew he wasn't going to. He watched.

Her hand gripped his base, so wide her fingers only formed a loose c shape to keep it steady. She bobbed deep, enough to make her gurgle and gag for a moment. Cole was moaning, his body twisting and writhing mildly. His hands came away from his face but he stared up into the sky. One hand came and rested on Maggie's waist. She moaned around his cock. She opened her legs. One folded against Cole's leg, sitting on one butt cheek, her knee angling wide, opening her up like wings. Max could see a tremor in Cole's hand. His fingers walked her skirt, looking for the hem, found it, pulled her skirt up to her waist. Maggie's hips moiled the air, eager for her sex to be touched. Max clasped his hands together in the attitude of prayer and pressed both thumbs to his lips. His frown so severe he'd brought himself a headache. His eyes were dry and unblinking.

Cole had big muscular hands. Veined and well-groomed with big knuckles. It spread across the inside of her thigh. She wore black stockings, the material stretching the curve of her thigh and revealing the tone of her skin underneath. Cole clasped the inside of her thigh, stroked up and down and got Maggie whimpering. Max thought of her bare sex so close. Knew

she wasn't wearing panties. She was shaved now and he knew she would be sopping wet. Cole wouldn't touch her. Trembling hand threatening to raise higher but afraid. Afraid to touch his friend like that. Max was glad, but part of him was aching to see Cole's hand slip under those stockings, find out how slippery his Maggie could get when she wanted it. Max groaned.

Maggie sucked and slurped, and her head swiveled, her lips pouting and sucking on Cole's bursting glans, coming up and forming a kiss at his very tip. Thrusting her mouth back down. Cole's legs jumped.

The four of them had always been close. Spending so many days and nights together over the last four years. Good loving and caring friends. There was something that was at once so taboo about this, so awful, but another part seemed very nice. Very fun and caring and happy. Those feelings washed over him in crashing waves of duality, crashing like the Narragansett waves at his back.

"Ah, Maggie, ah," Cole softly whispered, head falling right back. "Oh shit, oh..." His hand came away from her waist and he held her head. Both hands gripping her, fingers running through her hair while her lips slipped up and down his fat shining cock. "No," he cried, "Ah," then his hips thrust to meet her mouth and she snorted through her nose, deep scoring breaths, and she went beet red. Cole shoved his cock in her face. She took it. Her hand clutched his balls through his pants. Cole's face contorted like he was in pain and Max could tell he wanted to yell and growl but he was holding it all in. He grunted and coughed. His legs kicked the sand in alternating sweeps, sand spraying around his shoes, Maggie moaned and hummed sweet positive sounds, encouraging him.

"Oh God, oh God," he cried now, both hands coming up and covering his face.

Maggie held firm on him, not moving. Cole's chest heaved. In and out, chugging like he might be crying. Then she slowly and deliberately slipped her lips up his shaft, leaving it gleaming in the firelight. Her lips stroked up to his glans and it made Cole shudder as she passed his most sensitive part. Her lips came to a pout at the very end of him, then off.

She held her mouth closed, her face puckered like she was holding a mouthful. She cupped her hand under her chin like she might spit up. Walked on her knees through the sand and came right to the bright of the roaring fire and caught Max's eye. They stared at each other a moment and her neck worked like she was gulping but not swallowing. She looked like

she might throw up. Lowered her face to the flames so he could see her clearly, opened her mouth for him, her lips forming a quivering ring. Angled her head so he could see inside her mouth, see the thick pool of Cole's pearly semen in the cupped birdbath of her quivering pink tongue.

“Oh, oh fuck, Maggie,” Max whispered into his praying hands.

She ran her hair back, held it behind her ears and leaned to the flames, spit Cole's semen into the fire. Coughed a bit, a gag, retched, spit a few more times, then sat back on her heels and looked at Max, her hands on her knees.

“Oh, Maggie, what have you done?” he whispered.

Her mouth curved to a trembling bow and her eyes went wet, her brows curling up in sorrow. She shook her head, mouthed, “I don't know.”

MAGGIE FOUGHT TEARS, fought the urge to retch. She could taste her friend's semen in her mouth. Smell it in her exhale. She gulped again. Her breaths trembled, her stomach fluttered, nausea and fear. She'd done something that would never be undone. Couldn't look behind her. Heard Cole's zipper, afraid to turn around and meet his eyes. She could look at Max and that was bad enough.

He was stuck with horror. Mouth hanging, eyes wide, cupping his hands over his face, smoothing his hair, covering his face again. Looking to Cole, looking to her, mouth trying to speak but nothing was happening. Then Cole was standing. Must have been, because Max was looking up. She heard feet moving through the sand, turned her head over her shoulder and saw Cole walking back to the house, moving from the warm of the fire until the light on his back was cold and blue. Now her tears came. She blinked and blinked, eyelashes fluttering and tears plopping. Max jumped up and he called after Cole.

"Wait! Cole, hold on," he said.

He made to follow, stopped and staggered to her instead and fell on his knees, grabbed her hands and held them.

"Maggie..." His head tilted sideways with the enormous weight of what she'd just done. "Oh, Maggie," he sighed. His eyes trembled too, getting wet like hers. When his arms went around her she sobbed. Her hands came up weakly to hold his back. His body was warm and she was so fucking sorry.

She cried into his shoulder and let him squeeze her. He didn't have time though, he jumped up, still holding on to her hands. "Maggie, we have to talk to him."

"I know," she cried. She could never talk to him again. She was so ashamed. It had been so hot and she'd wanted to do something like that for so long but now it was over and they were left with a bleak future.

"Come on," he said, a tinge of anger to his voice. He grasped her hand and led her through the sand to the path. She looked back at the fire, worried about the littered beer bottles and the flames but Max kept walking and she followed. He led her up to the house and into the kitchen.

"We have to be quiet," she reminded him. He let her hand go and she wiped the tears off her cheeks.

"I know," he said. They mounted the stairs without making a sound. No creaks in this concrete and steel mansion. At the top of the stairs and down the hall she cowered behind Max as they approached the guest bedroom. The tears came again when she saw in the room. The house was dark but Cole had the lights on in the room, lighting it up so he could pack.

"Oh, no, no," she cried. "Oh, Max."

Cole's back was to them and they watched him thrust his clothes into his open bag.

"Max," she squealed, her nails dug into his shoulder and his arm, then she ran. Ran all the way to her bedroom. Ran before her sobs turned to wails and she brought everyone running to see why they weren't in bed like they'd been told.

MAX WATCHED HER RUN, watched her disappear into the dark of the hall. He could hear the sand falling from her onto the polished wood floor. He wanted to run after her and hold her again. But Cole was leaving and he couldn't let him go.

"Hey, hold on," he said quietly, coming into the room behind Cole. Cole's bag was on the bed, zippered open. He stopped, his back to Max, he slowed his packing but didn't stop.

Without turning, Cole said, "I gotta go. You...you get a ride back to Vermont? ..."

Max didn't close the distance, stood behind his good friend, said, "Don't go."

"I have to," he said. "I have to get out of here."

"Please, Cole. Don't. Please..." He stood uncomfortably still, his hands on his hips. He wanted to put a hand on Cole, steady him, but he felt twisted inside. Trying to preserve his friendship. Mad at Maggie. Mad at Cole, too. He shouldn't be. Max was trying so hard to be big about this, to tower over it. He could do it but when his guard wasn't up he could see his friend's legs kicking in the sand, shooting his come into Maggie's mouth. He knew what Cole's face did now when he came. Knew how it twisted and what shape his mouth formed.

Cole shouldered his bag, still faced away, went to the table where his raven head pointed out to the black bay, just looking at its own reflection now. Max watched Cole's reflection. His face shadowed, head lowered, shoulders slumped, he lay his palm over the crest of the raven's head. "I can't be here."

"Don't you dare go."

"I didn't...do that."

Yeah, you did! Max yelled in his head. He said, "It's okay. Stay. I want you to stay."

"She kissed *me*, Max."

Max shook his head, bit his tongue. *Blaming Maggie*. Came in her mouth, blames her. "I know."

"Why?"

He took Cole's bag with both hands and eased it away. Cole let the strap come off his shoulder. "Give me your keys," Max said. "You're not leaving."

"On the table," he said, still looking out the same direction as the raven.

Max threw Cole's bag onto his own bed and retrieved Cole's keys from a table at the concrete wall facing the foot of the bed. Pocketed them.

Cole turned now, his face was flush, he ran his hands through his hair. "Max, I'm sorry."

"I told you it's okay."

Cole sat on his bed and put his head in his hands. "She did it, Max. I didn't...you watched..."

"I know," he said. "Cole, I can explain. I have to see Maggie. She ran off, I want to make sure she's okay. Just be cool, all right. Sit here. I'm

fine.”

“Is she okay?” he said, his worried face coming away from his hands.

“I’m going to go see,” he said.

“Hey,” Cole said, putting his hand out to get Max’s attention before he left. “It’s okay, right? We’ll be okay?”

“Yeah,” he said. “I mean it, all right?”

Max left Cole in their bedroom, patted the Jeep key in his front pocket to make sure he had it. Headed down the dark hall, peeled his deck shoes off when they started to give a wet squeak. Continued in his socks to Maggie’s room. Didn’t knock, opened it and slipped in. Big room, much like the one he was in, cold but personalized with Maggie’s artwork and turntable and collection of symphony vinyl. Her bed was a low queen size and she lay on it, on her side, curled, her back to the door. He went to her and sat behind her, put his hand on her waist.

“I’m so sorry, Max,” she whispered without turning. Her hand came to her waist and lay across his fingers.

“I’m okay,” he said.

She turned then, her lamp throwing beautiful warm light across her face. She’d been crying. “Did he leave?” she whispered, a tremble in her voice. Her eyes grew wet.

He pat his pocket. “I have his keys. He’s staying.”

“Oh God,” she sighed and covered her face with her hands.

“What the fuck did you do that for?” he said.

“I wanted to,” she said into her palms.

It wasn’t the answer he was expecting. He was looking to go after her, to punish her with how upset he felt. But she was blunt. It scared him. He huffed, said, “For how long?”

Still talking into her hands, she said, “I’ve wanted to for a long time.”

“What do you mean?” he said, pulling her hands away.

“I’m doing the things I missed, remember?”

“With me,” he whined. “We didn’t talk about this.”

“You liked it.”

“No, I didn’t,” he hissed.

“Yeah, you did,” she said. “You didn’t stop me. You sat and watched.”

HE GRIT his teeth and stared across her room. Looked at a painting she had done. Much like the Jackson Pollock, it was a spattered mess but it seemed to say something. Seemed to have order in its chaos. Maggie dried her cheeks with her fingers. Sniffed and stared at the ceiling.

“You have feelings for Cole?”

“Yeah,” she said. She put her hand on his thigh. “He’s my friend. He’s our best friend, Max. He means so much to me. Not like you, Max. He’s just...”

“Hot?”

“Well, he is,” she said.

“You’ve thought about him before? Before Jay?”

“Not for real. I...I have eyes, Max. I’ve always been able to see that he’s hot.”

Max groaned and doubled over, put his hands to his face. She sat up. Her hand smoothed his back in circles. He sat up again and looked at her. “You want to fuck him?”

“Yeah,” she nodded, eyes on his for a moment then darting to watch the floor.

He felt empty. It should have stung him but he was already throbbing with emotional pain. This revelation, which he saw coming, added no more discomfort to the omnipresent suffering. But still, while he hurt and mourned the lost innocence of their relationship just a week ago, he rode that hurt like a wave, feet steady on a longboard, feeling its splashes, wet from its slick pain, but cresting it, riding its thrill and feeling the exhilaration of taming something so powerful.

“Doesn’t that arouse you?” she said.

“I don’t know.”

“I want it to arouse you.”

“Ah,” he groaned again. “Maggie, it’s my best friend...”

“I thought you liked seeing me like that...”

“I do. I really do, Maggie.”

“That’s so hot, Maxy,” she said, rubbing his arm now and watching herself do it.

“But it’s Cole. We see him every day. He’s...”

“With Cole you can be there. Right there. Max, wouldn’t you like that?”

“Yeah,” he admitted.

“You don't have to hide, Max. You could be there. Maybe you could participate...”

“Ungh,” he grunted, a sudden lascivious swirl twirling up inside him like a dirty dust devil. He clenched his thighs together, picturing it. Being right there, touching her while she was shared. But he couldn't separate Cole from the picture.

“You really want to fuck him, don't you?”

Her hand fell from his arm and made a fist on his thigh. “Don't be mean, Max. You'll ruin this.”

He looked deep in her eyes. Felt very distant from her. In a strange moment he saw his relationship with her dwarfed in scale by this new thing, this sexuality. It bullied him. He feared it. He lightened her by saying, “A threesome?”

She shrugged and pinched a smile off. Stared into his eyes now. She shrugged again and leaned closer. Said, “I want you to get off on this.”

“Okay,” he whispered.

“Would you marry me if we met last year?”

“Yes.”

“Even if I had slept with Jay or Cole or whoever...before that? ...Before I knew you.”

He nodded.

Her thin arms went around his neck. She said, “That's what we're doing, remember?”

“I know.”

“Don't forget.”

“Yeah,” he said, trying to mask an irritation. Not because of Maggie entirely. An encompassing feeling of loss of control. Like Maggie had pulled ahead of him in traffic and now he was following her, trying to keep up with her. What had started as his manipulation—using data gleaned from devious spying—was becoming very slippery and he was afraid he would lose his grip.

“Is he mad?” she asked, her hands rubbing both his thighs.

“No. Freaked out.”

“Is he okay?”

“I'll talk to him. Maybe—”

“Kiss me.” She leaned to him, eyes lowered, then closing as her pouted lips came to take his.

He moved away.

“Max...”

“He...in your mouth...”

Her soft warm hands came to his cheeks and she stared in his eyes.

“You went down on me...after Jay...”

“I know Cole...it’s...”

“You know how hot that made me? You made me come so hard...”

“You liked it?”

She inhaled deep, her eyes intent, her front teeth pressing down very hard into her bottom lip, her hips raising up as if she was squeezing her pelvic muscles.

“Shit, Maggie,” he sighed.

She said, “You really love me.” Not a question. A statement. He did.

“I do.”

“Just kiss me,” she whispered again, her lips coming to his. He kissed her. She worked her wet mouth over his, her tongue parted his reluctant lips, he let her. She worked her slim slippery tongue over his, her mouth made wet sticky sounds. She pulled away, said, “Do you taste him?”

He shook his head no.

She took his wrist with both her hands and she led his hand under her skirt, rising to her knees. Slipped his hand under her stockings and he felt between her legs. She was slick and engorged. Plump lips full of excitement, begging for a cock. Cole’s cock. She held his shoulders and kissed him again. Her tongue probed his mouth, she was more passionate, heavy breaths scoring through her nose. She sucked his tongue, pulled back. His hand stoked her pussy. She said, “Taste him now?”

He shook his head again.

She wiped at her lips with the back of her hand, said, “I taste him.”

“Fuck, Maggie,” he sighed, his mouth hanging open, his heart beginning to pound.

She whispered right in his ear, teasing him, “His come tasted so good, Max.”

He slipped a finger inside her as she spoke. It stiffened and his heart jumped at her awful words. “Oh shit,” he said, feeling his innards constrict.

She sat back on her heels, her eyes wide, both hands covering her mouth, her worried brows raised. She said, “Is that okay? Can I say that?”

He worked his finger in circles inside her, heard how wet she was, her tight little pussy making slick crackling noises.

“Mm,” she moaned, enjoying it, pushing her hips for her pussy to meet his touch. “Ah,” she gasped, “It’s so hot. I’m so bad.”

“You are, Maggie. You’re so bad.”

Up on her knees again, hands on his shoulders, legs parted so he could finger her, she whispered in his ear again. “Max, did you see his cock?”

“I did,” he said.

“It was so fat. The head was so big, Max. I could barely suck him.”

“Jesus, Maggie,” he moaned.

She giggled, squeezed his shoulders. “God, that’s so sexy, Max. Mm...” she hummed, bucking her hips against his stroking fingers.

“Go get him, Max. Bring him here.”

“What? Maggie...”

“Please, go get him,” she said, eyes lowered, biting her lip again.

“I don’t think he’s in the mood, Maggie.”

“He is,” she said.

“No, he was really...like, upset.”

“Please...try, Max. Try,” she said.

He sat back so he could see her. Messy hair, lusty eyes, her hips flexing with excitement, like she needed it. Her pouted lips puffy from sucking a big cock, from kissing Max. He’d never seen her like this. He wanted to be excited, but it scared him. He had not anticipated her being such a devoted participant in his fantasy. He tempted her into fucking Jay and now, one week later, she sucked his best friend’s cock without his permission. He let her see the worry in his face. He was too much of a coward to give her words right now, but maybe if she saw his fear she would have sympathy.

She didn’t waver, whined in a whisper, “Please, Max.”

HE SKATED the hallway in his socks, back to his room, found Cole sitting on the bed. He had his phone out but his screen was blank.

Max said, “Shit, you’re not calling a cab...”

“No,” he said, expressionless. “I was going to. What took so long...I thought you weren’t going to come back...”

“Sorry,” he said, and he set himself on the bed across from Cole, their knees pointing at each other. “Sorry, we had to talk.”

“So what the fuck is happening?” Cole asked, anger scraping the edges of his bewildered voice.

“Fuck, dude,” Max said, wringing his hands and looking up at the ceiling. “I don’t even know where to start.”

“Is she okay?”

“She’s...fine, yeah. She’s sorry. She’s worried you might be...freaked out...”

“Freaked out? ...I am freaked the fuck out, Max.”

“Okay,” he said, “calm down. You didn’t exactly stop her.”

“Ah, fuck,” Cole sighed, looking to the ceiling too, rubbing his cheeks.

“Maggie wants...she feels like...she’s only been with me...” he said finally, lowering his eyes to Cole, hoping making eye contact would fill the gaps, stop him searching for words.

Cole looked in his eyes, his head shaking slightly, he looked away. “Why wouldn’t you fucking tell me...”

“It wasn’t planned,” he blurted, “it wasn’t something we talked about. She just did it. *She* didn’t even know she was going to until she...*was doing it*. I didn’t ask her to or any weird shit like that...it was all...organic. She...likes you...trusts you...”

“Aw, Maggie...” Cole said to himself, running his finger around a leather bracelet, tugging it in wide circles.

Max said, “Is that okay?”

“Yeah,” he said. “I wish...I wish, like, someone had said something. I was...” He looked to Max’s eyes again, said, “You’re not mad at me?”

“It hurt,” he said. “I didn’t enjoy it, but I...love her.”

Cole inhaled sharply, changed the subject fast, said, “I thought she was with that Lee guy...”

“One time. That’s it.”

“Shit, Max,” he said, lowered his head and ran his fingers through his hair and shook it. “Fuck,” he hissed.

“Is it all right? Are we all right?”

“Yeah,” he said. “I didn’t stop her...”

“I know...”

“I didn’t stop her because you were there. Whatever...” he said, throwing his hands up. “I didn’t want to...do *that*...but because you were there my

body wouldn't...let my brain tell me to leave.”

“I know.”

“I didn't kiss her. I would never...”

“She knows I’m okay with it, but she didn't tell me it would be...you...”

“Are we going to be okay?” Cole asked.

“Yeah,” he said. He held his hand out and Cole took it, pulled himself to Max’s bed and sat next to him. Put his arm around him, said, “Sorry. Sorry about this.”

Max made a fist and he bumped Cole’s knee. “I’m happy. I want this for her. I do.”

“I don’t know. I guess I get it.”

“Right? Not when we’re married.”

Cole nodded, his body rocking with his continued affirmation. Eyes lost in thought.

Max took a deep breath, held it. Slowly exhaled, turned to Cole so he would face him, but his eyes settled on his chest rather than his face.

“She wants...” He stopped. Breathed again. Said, “Would you? ...”

“Really?” he said. Max was bothered by a squeezed excitement in Cole’s voice. Knew he would agree to have sex with her just by that tone. Hurt that it was so easy to undo all the good in the relationship. Just friends this morning, now she’d sucked his cock, kissed him, tasted his come, and Max was negotiating intercourse.

Cole looked to the floor, wistful, a smile on his mouth. He chuckled, shook his head.

“Not tonight,” Max blurted. “Some time.”

“Yeah,” he said.

“I’ll be there,” Max added, trying to poison the offer.

Cole nodded. “Aw, little Maggie,” he sighed, his smile curling higher, his eyes still envisioning the two of them together or whatever it was he was lost in. “She’s so sweet.”

“Can I tell her you will?”

“Yeah, Max. You want me to go with you?”

“No, she’s still upset by what happened.”

“Shit, Max. I should talk to her.”

“Let me talk to her first.”

Cole agreed, returned to his bed, that dumb smile still plastered on him.

Max told him he'd be back and he slipped down the hall, head cocked, listening for any movement in the house. Got to Maggie's room and slipped inside.

Final Symphony

FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 29TH

MAGGIE LAY NAKED in her teenage bed, staring at the high ceiling. She couldn't close her eyes. She'd stripped out of her skirt, hose, and top after Max went to talk to Cole. Ran to her bathroom and put on deodorant and brushed her teeth, ran a brush through her hair. Hopped back in bed and waited and worried.

She sucked Cole's fucking cock. Why the fuck did she do that? She hadn't planned on it. Didn't lure him to the beach so she could. She loved Cole like a friend. He was a good guy. Funny and charming, and so handsome. Out of her league. One second she's pulling his leg about her imaginary boyfriend, the next she's kissing him. Craning her neck, eyes darting from his eyes to his luscious lips, moving slow, slower... Heart racing out of control when Cole's lips moved towards hers. Not away, but *to her*. He *wanted* to kiss her. She wondered if he'd ever thought of her that way before tonight.

She lay in the LED glow of the sleek scissored Toan Nguyen lamp next to her bed, bare shoulders poking above the duvet. Her hands stroked her thighs. She could feel herself slippery again, even though she'd tidied and talced in the bathroom, from front right up the back. What had got into her these days?

Cole had responded with more than his kisses. Her hand had found him hard in his pants. Then, with Max watching, she unzipped him. Hard as a rock. She made Cole hard. Gave her a deep thrill.

One week now and she'd slept with Jay—who might have been the hottest guy she'd ever seen—and now Cole, another solid TEN. Handsome, rugged, smart, driven, and he was funny. And God, his cock was so nice. It felt so good to have him in her mouth. The head of his cock was big and plump. She'd never seen a foreskin before and it wasn't gross, like she'd heard. She thought it was kind of—

Her door opened and she whipped her hands from between her legs where they'd wandered and played in her wetness. She dried them on her sheet, sat up.

“Max?” She whispered, then, seeing him alone, said, “Where is he?”

Max shushed her, a hiss, and then a finger to his lips. He came to the side of the bed, said, “I saw your dad out there.”

“What? Where?”

“I heard him in the hall...”

“He doesn't... Where's Cole?”

“It's too risky, Maggie. He's back in the room.”

“He didn't come?” she said, hearing a whine in her voice and a tension seared across her forehead.

“I'm here, Maggie. I'm here,” Max said, and he lifted the cover to slip in next to her. “Maggie, you're naked...”

“I know,” she said, scooting to give him some room.

“What did he say, Max? Is it okay?”

“He's fine, Maggie,” Max said, slipping next to her under the duvet. They lay on their sides facing each other.

“What did you tell him?”

“I don't know. I said...he said he would.”

“Would what, Max?”

“He would sleep with you.”

“He'd sleep...how did you ask him?”

“I said, you know, you didn't have sex with anyone but—”

“You told him that? Max...why would you say that?”

“No...it's...I said, no, I said, you wanted to experiment...”

“Experiment?”

“I don't know, Maggie. I don't know how to talk to him about this. I'm sorry. You could have tried talking with him first, instead of sucking—”

“Hey, Max, don't, okay, don't.”

He stared at her, rubbed his chin into his shoulder. Waited a moment and said, "Sorry, Maggie. I don't know how to do this, okay?"

"Does he want to? For real?"

"Yeah, he said he would."

"Why didn't he come?"

"He didn't feel like it tonight. He's still freaked out."

"Ah, fuck," she said, feeling an awful heavy feeling come over her.

"What?"

"He...what if he doesn't think of me like that..." Saying it out loud sealed the deal on the malaise that washed over her. She covered her face with her hands and moaned. "Oh fuck. I'm so stupid. Stupid, stupid. Oh, I made such a fool of myself."

"No, Maggie," he said and he pulled her hands away and she watched him through narrow eyes. "I mean it—he said he would. He will, too. Back in Vermont."

"It has to be here, Max. I want to do it now."

Max rubbed his head and looked across her room towards her records.

"How freaked out is he?"

"He's a little freaked out," he said without looking at her.

"Fuck," she said. "God, I'm so stupid." She spun her legs out of the cover and onto the floor.

"WHAT ARE YOU DOING?" Max asked.

"I don't know," she said. She got up and opened a drawer and found a pair of sweatpants. Grabbed them and a T-shirt. "I have to talk to him."

Max was behind her in an instant. His hands coming around her and holding her. He said, "Stay with me."

"Max," she said. "I have to talk to Cole."

"We'll talk about it tomorrow..."

"Max, let me go."

He lifted her. Her feet came right off the floor and she clutched her T-shirt balled to her naked chest. His arms were bars across her stomach and her legs kicked for balance, her sweatpants hooped around her ankles, not pulled up yet. "Max!" she hissed.

Thrown face first on the bed, her chin dug into the mattress and her head bounced. Max was on her. His chest pressed to her back, his hips digging his erection through his pants against her rump. He clutched her hair and he humped his cock into her crack. She kicked her legs behind her, trying to get higher up the bed but she was pinned.

“Max, what are you—”

But she knew. She was a bad girlfriend. He’d watched her suck his best friend's cock. A horrible thing. But he was turned on by it. She forgot. She fucking forgot about Max's turn. She’d sat with him on her bed and woe-is-me’d about Cole. She must have drove him mad. Her poor Max had an aching hard-on and all she was occupied with was getting her future-husband to convince their friend to come and fuck her. She wanted to laugh. She would have if the act she had performed on their friend wasn't threatening to rip apart a wonderful relationship she had with Cole. And a friendship between Max and Cole. And what if Cole was secretly laughing at nerdy Maggie going down on him? What if he told other girls what a loser she was? Sucked him right in front of her boyfriend. *You should have seen that little slut.*

She rounded on Max. Caught him with his hand in his zipper, pulling his stiff cock out. She slapped him right across his face. Kept her hand flat, she wanted to make noise, not hurt him. She had his attention. He looked like he might cry.

Pushed his hand out of the way, grabbed his fleshy rod sticking straight and eager out of his open fly. Stroked his little handful, said, “You want one too? Want a blow job?”

His head was rolling on his powerless neck. He was under her control. She stood, stroked, and walked him backwards until he sat down in a low leather chair in the corner of her room. She stepped out of her sweatpants and squat between his open legs.

“Max, I’m twenty-one and I never had sex in my bedroom.”

He caressed her cheek and she kissed his thumb.

“I’m sorry, Max. I’m sorry I got so crazy tonight. Were you going to rape me?”

“Maggie, don't say that...”

She kissed the heel of his hand, stroked his cock. Watched it in her grip, looked at her fiancé's sex organ. Now the fourth cock she'd been intimate with. Numbers expanding, experiences rippling in concentric waves, an

undulating pattern working away from the node—the day Max said he wanted her to sleep with Jay. She was growing, she was becoming whole. A light burning inside her glowing brighter and chasing her shadows away.

“Max, I’m going to suck your cock and you’re going to come in my mouth.”

“Okay,” he said weakly.

“Want some music?”

He shrugged. The leather squeaked.

“Take your pants down for me, Max,” she said as she stood. It was night and while this house was bombproof there were rules. No music past ten. It was well past ten now.

She flipped the green acrylic lid on her Beogram turntable. Opened the three-fold packaging of Final Symphony. Turned to see her Max watching her dumbly with his cock in his hand. She smiled. He’d taken his pants down for her.

She stood naked and had never felt so sexually independent in her life. Placed the vinyl on the deck, set the needle down. Beyerdynamics already plugged into the gold inset on her tube amp. Lifted the headphones and brought them to Max, placed them over his ears and he suckled at her hardened nipples while she did. She held his head like he was her little baby and watched him feed from her. She could hear the gentle strains of the London Symphony Orchestra around the seal on the headphones. Full London Symphony, mixed at Abbey Road, playing the music from Final Fantasy. Max’s level of interest in symphony, but expertly played. She lifted one of the black ears and said, “Too loud?”

He shook his head no, his face frozen with anticipation. She eased him off her breasts, encouraged him to lay back and receive her pleasure.

Max had told her she was good at this. She didn’t know. She *was* enthusiastic. She’d only sucked Max up til last week. Hardly performed for Jay. Too eager to have him inside her. Cole was responsive. Maybe just the taboo of receiving unexpected oral sex from a good friend. She’d like to think though that she’d done it with her skills. That he appreciated how she made him feel with her mouth. She liked to do it. Liked the feel in her mouth. Liked the smooth texture of the tight skin, that stretched bow along the frenulum, liked how it played over her tongue. Max’s was more pronounced. Jay had it too, but Cole didn’t really. The head of Cole’s cock was so big and round. That was a nice feel. The skin of his glans was tight

as a drum and smooth as porcelain. Jay's glans was rough. Not as plump, but still big. Max's was small and narrow. Easy to work with. She could do all kinds of things with Max's cock. Anything really. Take him all the way. Jay and Cole were a little unwieldy. Maybe that's why Max said she was good. Because he was small and she could perform easily. Maybe any girl could give him a good blow job. Maybe her skills would be diminished when applied across a larger sample number.

His cock flat in her palm, she ran her tongue up him. From between his balls all the way to the tip of him, pointing her tongue into the hole he peed from. Forced it in there until he grimaced. Smiled at him as he watched with the black phones on the sides of his head, like fallen Mickey ears. She held one of her breasts, brought it to his cock held in her other hand, ran her nipple over his tip. It made his legs jump and his belly flutter.

"You like that?" she said, but he didn't hear her.

Other nipple now, ran her pointed bud around the flared edge of his cock. Her pink nipple folded against his hard glans. Lowered then and squished both his balls into her mouth. Pulled them far from his body and watched his eyes on her. Tongue swiping up again to the very end and consumed him. Gulped him in one quick move that had his tip poking the top of her palette. Deep but not as deep as the others. He didn't make her gag. Made her eyes water. Tongue spread wide, underside scraped over her bottom teeth, covered his balls, stroking at them. Max shuddered.

Moved here when she was ten. Spent her unfolding years, opened like a flower in this house. Like a veal in a cage, or like a square watermelon. Confined, forced into a shape dictated by her mother. Exploding with youthful sexuality she instead played and played, practiced and practiced, painted, read book after book, homework, homework, homework. Dreamed of boys in here. But that's all they ever were. Ethereal conjuring, pretend manifest. Humped her pillows. Didn't hold hands or kiss until Lee. No movies, no late night phone calls. No dick pics.

She bobbed on Max, watched up his belly now. Eyes closed, head back. She was doing it. She was really making him crazy. The symphony played in his ears, drowned out everything but the feel of her mouth. Wondered what in him made him enjoy seeing her do things with other men. She was a sexual juvenile, not one to judge. She did have her own fantasies. She couldn't cast aspersions on her boy's turn-ons. She had her own weirdness.

He came and it was a surprise. He'd been holding back. It jumped out of him and hot splashes jetted against her palette. Deep, gagging her, sliding down her throat with no chance for her to stop it. She swallowed. Max thrust himself into her mouth and she pinched his base with an okay sign, braced him from hurting her. Swallowed every drop of him. When he was done and she'd squeezed him out, she let him fall onto his belly. She wiped at her mouth and sat on his lap. Lay on him. Lifted an ear of the headphones, said, "Can I talk to Cole now?"

MAGGIE FOLLOWED BEHIND MAX, sneaking through the halls of the house she grew up in. Just that was exciting. This was the kind of escapade she'd dreamed about when she was in high school. Boys in the house, maybe a party, intrigue and drama. Sex. Her heart was racing. They slipped along in their quiet socks.

When she got to the archway of the guest room she stiffened. It was all fun and playful until now. She saw the filament of light around the square seam of the door. Not closed, but pushed as far as it would go without clicking shut. Cole was in there. Sitting in there. She had blown him. He had come in her mouth. They were good friends. The best of friends. She had tasted his semen. All her bravado slumped, burst and splashed on the floor. She couldn't go in.

"I can't, Max," she said, stopping in the hall six feet from the door.

"He's okay, Maggie."

"I know. I'm not. God."

How could she face him? What did he think of her? Was she a little slut? One of those skanks who would go home with him on a weekend. Get fucked and forgotten. She'd lowered herself to their status. Another dumb bitch to be fucked or forgotten. Or worse. Laughed at. He'd laughed at girls before. Laughed that they'd even try to get with him. Was that who she was? Some horny girl who he wouldn't even dream of having sex with but because they were friends he didn't want to make her feel bad and push her away. Did he let her suck his cock because he didn't want to hurt her feelings by rejecting it? Was she being laughed at?

"Stay here," Max said.

She stood in the hall, hands clasped at her front. Cold suddenly even though the house was warm. Tight sweatpants and a T-shirt, warm socks, but she shivered. What would she say? She didn't think she could look him in the eye. She had to go. Had to get out of here. Right now Max was telling him she was in the hall. *Hey, go easy on her.* The two of them orchestrating some network of sympathy for her. Fuck.

She turned, saw her shadow grow large ahead of her. The door had opened behind her. She didn't turn back, stepped away. Grabbed again from behind. Cole this time. He was gentle. Held her, stopped her from leaving. But it felt like a hug.

"Come back, Maggie," he whispered.

He let her go. She turned, head down, eyes on the floor, and she walked below him with her arms folded around herself. Walked in the bedroom and saw Max sitting at the foot of his bed. His eyes were on her, following her as she entered. Cole closed the door behind her but he didn't say anything. No one said a thing, and she wanted to yell or something, she felt like she might burst. Cole edged around her, moving near the wall on her left side. She could see his reflection in the window out to the bay. He leaned on the wall, he was looking at her.

Max cleared his throat and she looked to him hoping he would say something.

Cole spoke. Said, "So, that was crazy."

Her eyes moved to him, her head following. She smiled, scrunched her nose up, getting an image of what she had done.

His arm jerked up and his hand came out, turned palm up. She looked at his hand levitating between them.

Her eyes went up to his.

He nodded his chin to his hand, waved it to her, said, "Come here," in a very soft and caring voice. "Give me your hand," he said as she got close. She put her hand in his and he pulled them together and his arms went around her. Hers went around his waist and she lay her head on his chest. She felt marginally less foolish. She'd hugged Cole like this before. This wasn't unusual. But the parameters of this situation removed all the context of their contact like this. Was this friends, sympathy, a brush off? ... Was it love? Commitment?

She wanted to say something profound but all she could produce was, "Sorry."

He said, "Don't be. Don't."

"I don't know why I did that," she said.

He breathed heavily, her head rising on his chest, hearing the air in his lungs. He said, "I Liked it."

That made her feel better. "Did you?" she said, which sounded stupid when she said it.

"Hey," he said. "Max told me...it's okay."

She nodded.

"Look at me," he said, taking her chin. He turned her face up to his.

"We're going to be okay, Maggie," he said.

"I want us to be okay," she said, which was what she feared the most. That they wouldn't be friends anymore.

"We will. I'm fine with what you want."

"With what I want?" She looked around Cole's arm and saw Max watching from the bed, arms spread out behind him, legs wide.

"Yeah, if you want to."

"Want to what?" she said, eyes going up to Cole now.

"Max told me," he said.

"Yeah, but what are we saying?"

"You want to sleep with me," he said, keeping it classy.

"Oh my God," she said, thumping her head to his chest. "It sounds so stupid when you hear it."

He hugged her tight.

"Yeah," she said, "I want to."

Cole kissed the top of her head and it gave her goose bumps. Her hair rose right up all along her arms. She didn't know if she could do this now. It did feel too weird. Too prepared. Like they should all have got drunk and tumbled into bed, that's how this should have happened. This strange negotiation had made her feel like some homely woman whose only saving grace was a dowry. Her dowry being their friendship.

She broke from him and stepped back, faced him, eyes on his.

He led her to the bed and they sat on it. Max got up and came to the side of his bed so he was facing them. Maggie sat nervously next to Cole while he eyed her all over the way guys do. She felt really uncomfortable now. Like she was performing again. Putting on a show for Max.

Max said, "We should do it when we go back to Vermont."

Cole turned to Maggie and he rested his hand on her thigh.

MAX WATCHED Cole's hand on Maggie's thigh, fingers spread wide, taking up a lot of her leg, tips curled and pressed into her firm flesh. They looked into each other's eyes, their smiles tentative, but something growing between them. Their chests lurched with breaths growing heavy.

He had a flashback to Jay on top of Maggie. Telling her he wasn't going to wear a condom and Maggie saying to fuck her. Picturing in his head the same scene, this time Maggie running her claws through Cole's long hair while he stroked the end of his cock across her slick sex and her saying, *Just fuck me*. Cole needed a condom.

He said, "Hey, I heard your dad...remember?" That was a lie.

"He won't come in here," Maggie said, without breaking eye contact with Cole.

"Are you sure?" Max said, looking over his shoulder at the bedroom door.

Maggie said to Cole, "How do you want to do this?"

"Let it happen. We both know what we're doing." His hand slipped higher up her thigh. Maggie inhaled and held her breath, her eyebrows raised high.

Max got mad at that face. He loved it but right now he hated it being distracted from him. Hated seeing that gaze in an other man's eyes. Especially Cole's eyes. He wanted time. Needed time.

Maggie's thighs parted, an invitation to be touched. Cole slipped higher, the curled knuckle of his bent thumb pressing the stretched crotch of her tight sweatpants and putting a divot in them.

"Maggie, are you sure about this?" Max asked.

Her eyebrows fell. "What, Max? You're not?"

"It's just...we're here..." he said, looking around the guest room—meaning her parents' home. With her parents in the house.

"I want it here," she said, eyes still on Cole's but her smile was gone and her eyes were troubled.

Cole's hand jumped from between her legs, skipped over her sex and lay flat on her tummy. Maggie watched his hand, leaned back with her arms

behind her and watched it slip under her T-shirt and touch her bare flat stomach.

“Maggie,” Max interjected.

“No one’s coming down, Max.”

Cole turned now, his hand frozen under her shirt. “Are you okay or not?”

“I’m okay,” he said.

“You don’t seem like it.”

“I am. I want this. I think I do...it’s just the timing, everything we’re doing this weekend...planning our wedding...we’re in your house...I watched you...”

His eyes welled up. Pictured her in the light of the fire, her mouth wrapped around his best friend’s hard cock. Maggie opening her mouth and proving to him Cole had ejaculated in it. It was sexy. It was cruel. It was fucking awful. He hated that he liked it. Hated that she knew to do that. It was too much. Too much was happening and it was all coming so fast. She’d slapped him. That was the cruelest blow. He reminded her. He whispered, “You slapped me...”

“Max...” she said.

“You slapped him?”

Max nodded, his mouth crumpling, but no tears came, no crying.

“He was out of control,” she said.

“I was,” Max agreed and lowered his head, looked down at his feet.

Maggie’s hand moved, went over top of Cole’s under her shirt. She was communicating to him, her eyes trembling, her mouth twisted. “I think he ruined it,” she whispered. She craned her neck and kissed Cole’s cheek.

“Ah, fuck,” Cole sighed. He grabbed his cock through his pants, he was hard. He adjusted it and Maggie watched.

Max said, “You don’t have to stop.”

“Yeah, we do,” Maggie said. “Look at you.”

“What? I ruined it?”

Cole leaned forward and put his elbows on his knees. Maggie rubbed her hand across his back.

Max said, “We can do it tomorrow.”

Maggie nodded, her grim expression unchanged.

“I mean it,” Max said. “Let’s do it tomorrow night, okay? I want it...it’s just...so fast. You know?”

Cole said, "You'll be okay with this tomorrow?" His expression was serious, his head cocked to the side and his brow set in a firm low and straight line.

"I will. I'm okay with it now. Please... Do you get it? I *want* to..." he gestured uselessly with his hands, looked up to the ceiling, at a loss to explain himself. "I just want to think about it first. I don't want it to happen so fast."

"I want it to be special too," Maggie said.

"You do?" Cole said, turning his head to her.

"Yeah. Maybe he's right. Maybe we should make a bigger deal of it."

That made Cole smile and some of the tension left his shoulders. He eased his elbows off his knees, made his way to her slowly, eyes narrow and focused on hers. She smiled wide and started to giggle. He moved his lips to hers and she leaned back but she didn't escape. When her mouth opened to take his kiss a small breathy gasp escaped her. They kissed. Not passionate and overwhelming. It was exploratory. Like they did in front of the fire, but without the trepidation that had stunted them. Max twisted inside. It was sweet. It hurt, but it felt good, too.

"It's a big deal, Maggie," Cole said in a low tone as his lips left hers.

"Sorry," Max said again, feeling like he'd let them down, like they might be mad at him. Strength though was rising in him and he was glad for it. Now, in the moment, he realized he had come very close to breaking down in front of them.

Cole said, "Fuck, I don't think I can wait until tomorrow."

"You don't?" she said, taking it as a compliment, a lusty look in her eyes.

"Feel," he said, and he took her hand and led it between his legs. Placed it over his hardness. Maggie explored its shape under the cotton. Her palm went up and down the wide curve in the front of his pants. She watched.

"Why... Why do *you* want to do this?" Maggie asked him, not looking in his eyes, still nodded low and watching her hand.

"What do you mean?"

"What I said." She looked into his eyes now.

Cole was puzzled. He said, "I don't know what you mean..."

"Never mind," she said.

His hand went over hers and stopped its movement, both their hands on his cresting bulge. "I get to have fun with you. I like that. I want that. It *is*

weird...but it's *not*. We're all friends. I want you to be happy, too. If you want some more experiences I want to be the one you do it with."

"Why?"

He laughed. "What do you mean *why*?"

Her eyes bulged wide and she thrust her face to him, like she thought it was obvious what she meant but didn't want to say it.

Cole said, "This is the hardest job interview ever," shaking his head, puzzled, still trying to understand what she meant.

"Sorry," Maggie said. "I just want to be sure that you're into this. I don't want you to think...bad things about me. Or do...me a...favor..."

Cole looked pained. "No, Maggie. I'm *so* into it. I feel like *I'm* getting the favor..."

"Do you see me...that way?"

His lips pursed and he regarded her seriously. He nodded. "I do."

"Okay," she sighed. "Tomorrow."

"Tomorrow," Max said. Cole still nodded.

They sat for a moment, none of them looking at each other.

Maggie said, "That's it?"

"I guess," Max said.

She shook her head, leaned back on the bed with her hands behind her.

"What's wrong?" Max said.

"Nothing," she said. Then, "I...just, I...went down...on you. Both of you. Now I have to go to bed...so..."

"Horny?" Cole laughed.

She didn't think it was funny. She was serious.

Cole saw her face and said, "Oh...we could..."

Max said, "You want me to go back to your room with you? I'll take you," he rose and held a hand out to her.

Cole put a hand out to pause him, his face buoyed by a great idea.

"You want this to be a big deal?" he said to Maggie.

She nodded, her eyes darting over his face and his body, sensing something from him. His hand gripped her thigh again, grabbing the sensitive inner part and holding it roughly. He curled himself against her, his face in the crook of her neck. In a low husky voice, he said, "Go to bed, Maggie. Think of all the dirty things you want me to do to you. Max and I are going to make you crazy tomorrow." His hand gripped higher. Maggie

thrust her hips out, wanting her pussy to be stroked. He worked around it. "Don't touch yourself tonight."

She nodded, her mouth hung open, her eyes looking to his now.

"Promise me."

She nodded again, her face inching toward his like she wanted to kiss again.

"No, Maggie, tell me. Tell me what you're not going to do."

"I'm not going to touch myself," she whispered.

"Tell me. Say my name. Tell me you're going to be a good girl."

"Cole," she gasped, her hips beginning to moil towards his touch, "I promise I won't touch myself."

"We want you aching, don't we, Max?" he said, without looking his way.

Max said, "Yes," but his voice broke.

Cole's hand went higher, up her belly and under her shirt. Turned, slipped under the wide waistband of her pants and moved low, but not between her legs.

"Oh fuck," Maggie gasped.

Cole smiled, face to face with her, foreheads near touching. His hand came out from her pants and he retreated, leaving her whimpering.

"Oh shit," Maggie gasped.

"I want you to come in your panties for us. Before we even touch you," he said.

Her lusty eyes narrowed on him. Her thighs clapped together, squeezing her pelvic muscles. "Mm," she moaned and bit both her lips into her mouth. Clapped her thighs gently, over and over.

Cole put his hands on her knees and brought them together. "A lady keeps her legs closed, Margaret," he said.

Maggie gasped and her eyes went wide.

Cole smiled, tuning into her sexuality. "Now go to bed. Remember you promised me."

She nodded. Moved to get off the bed and he put a hand out, said, "I might come in later and check your pussy. Make sure you've been a good girl."

"Oh my God," she laughed and closed her eyes, her head rocking on her neck like she was lightheaded. "Oh, fuck, Cole."

"Go to bed," he said, and he kissed her cheek.

When she stood, Max stopped her and he held her a minute. He took her hand and put it between his legs and showed her he was hard too.

“Good night, Max,” she said and she kissed his cheek.

She went to bed.

MAX DIDN'T HAVE much to say to Cole before they went to bed. There was an uncomfortableness to their interaction. Not tension just a pervasive disquiet. Things not being right. Things being out of place. And a peculiar sexuality that was new. Their sex lives, always separated, were now intertwined. They had shared a girl. That girl was his fiancée. He saw his friend's erection. Saw his face when he came. Things were very different, but somehow still familiar enough he really felt like they would be okay. So they said little.

Cole had said, "I guess this is good."

Max had said, "I think it is."

Then they got ready for bed and said nothing else on the matter.

Now Max was awake and on his side, looking out over his sleeping friend and watching the waves on Narragansett Bay. Sky was a hazy post dawn gray. Cole lay on his back and he was erect. Morning wood, he figured. The duvet was low, bunched around his thighs, a charcoal cotton sheet up to his chest. A hump between his legs, that thick thing pointing up and laying on his belly. Made him mad. Cole having dreams about Maggie, dreaming of fucking her. Turning her on with his dirty talk. Tuning into her secret kinks in a minute. Things he knew to say and do and Max had known her for four years and never done that.

Max opened his mouth, wiggled his jaw to relieve the tension in it, the tightness that had pursed his lips and made his temples ache. Mad for what? Mad that Cole had a sex dream about Maggie? They'd spent the night

virtually penciling in the day planner that he would fuck Maggie for real tonight and Max was worried about morning wood.

Cole slowly came awake. Eyes open and blinking. He stretched, scratched his balls under the cover, drew his knees up. Turned then to Max, their eyes meeting, two good friends laying face to face after what had to be the weirdest night of their lives.

“Hey, buddy,” Cole said.

“Hey,” he returned. Surprised at the pleasant tone he managed. He liked the pleasant tone. He wanted to be that kind of guy. He wanted this for Maggie, wanted it for himself, but he kept tripping up. He had to stop this or get out of its way. The more he tried to put his hands out to halt it the more likely it would roll right over him. He’d be better served by riding on top of it, looking ahead and steering where it would go. “Crazy, huh?” he said.

Cole scratched his beard. “You wanna get in the shower first?”

“I guess we got a lot to do today.”

“It’s a big day, Max. You’re a lucky guy. Don’t forget.”

SEEING Cole and Max this morning was going to be uncomfortable. She was up before seven o’clock after a fitful sleep. They’d left her hungry. Then Cole had turned that hunger into unexpected nourishment, and even though her sleep was listless and riled she couldn’t stop thinking about what they might do tonight. In a way that was better than having done it. And there came an acceptance in Cole’s foreplay. An ownership. He wasn’t some meek boy who agreed to have sex with her at a weekend event at Tanglewood. He was a man. He was taking this over, doing what needed to be done. And, holy fuck, did he know what needed to be done. She’d rather toss and turn, assaulted by belligerent dirty thoughts, than get a solid eight hours sleep. She’d rather be enervated during her wedding planning than have had a quick one with Cole while Max watched from the bed next to them.

Had a shower when she got up, shampoo, soap, cleaned the funk she’d produced between her legs. Rinsed her double-barrel semen mouth with Listerine. And then, a nod to Carol, she twisted her hair in a tight bun, getting the platinum and blue mostly hidden. Dressed in cable knit tights

and plaid wool skirt. Cashmere sweater under a wool jacket. Checked herself in the mirror. Becker approved. Prim neat and proper. Not vain. In style. This would not cause problems. Hoped to fuck that Cole remembered to bring good shoes. Topsiders were fine around Narragansett, but they were a little late in the season when they went to Newport. Carol would notice.

She poked her head into the hall and saw that it was clear. Walked down the hall, oxblood penny loafers clacking on hard surface. Slowed at the door to the boys' room, hoping they wouldn't come out, and simultaneously hoping they did come out now so they could get the awkwardness over. She picked up the pace when she passed their door.

In the kitchen she found Carol going after Ken. She'd missed the crux of it, walking in on the tail end. Heard no words but knew from the look on her brother's face that he'd just been dragged around, menaced, put in place and now he was going to go to his room like a good boy.

"What's up?" she said as he made to pass her at the corner of the bleached maple island with the granite top.

"I'll see you tonight," he said and tried to continue but she put her hand in the inside of his elbow.

"You're not coming?"

"No."

"You came this weekend to see me."

"I know," he said. "I'll see you at dinner." He kept an even expression, nodded to her and she let him go. He went upstairs.

Her mother said, "Did you see the boys?"

"No."

"Are they up?"

"I don't know. I didn't see them."

"Didn't think to check? It's getting late."

"We all have alarms these days."

"Your friend Cole looks like he's one to enjoy sleeping late."

"He does. Max will wake him." Carol couldn't argue with that one.

Carol was dressed in razor sharp black and white, hair stretched back, showing off her smooth face and her diamond earrings. She said, "Your father's in the car already."

"Good," she said and filled a glass of water from the tap.

"We have reservations at Aguillard at 8 A.M."

“It’s half an hour away,” Maggie said, looked at her watch. There was plenty of time.

The distinct sound of two sets of Oxfords came down the steel steps and she was glad to hear them. They’d arrived and Cole was wearing proper shoes. She saw them then, winced without realizing it. Then, when she did, forced her face to ease itself to a relaxed manner. Her two boys came into the kitchen, clean and dressed in jackets and ties, hair combed back. Max had shaved but Cole had not.

“Good morning,” she said, softly. So soft, her voice broke and the word *morning* was inaudible.

Max came right to her and held her. He grabbed her hands with his and kissed her lips. Strange for Max to do that in front of her mother but it was exactly what she needed now. She kissed back. Maybe too intimate but it felt nice. She sucked his lips and pushed her tongue to him. He frightened and backed off, but he got her to smile. Then he did too. They held hands for a moment longer, squeezed, and then followed Carol to the door. Maggie let Max get ahead and fell back to walk by Cole’s side. Followed her mother out to the round driveway, wind coming from the bay and rustling Cole’s hair at the back where his curls had been combed.

“You look good this morning, Margaret,” he said.

“Thank you, Cole. You clean up well.”

They both stifled smiles and she felt good walking with him. Father was in the Range Rover, motor running, working on his iPhone. Warm exhaust puffed in the cold behind the SUV.

Cole said, “Where’s Ken?”

Carol opened her passenger door and said, “He’s not coming today.” Like there was another day he might come.

“Oh, that’s too bad,” Cole said, “I was looking for a companion.”

“There’s no room in the vehicle,” she said and got in.

“Shit,” Cole said to Max, “we could have taken two cars.”

Maggie said, “That’s inefficient, Cole. That’s how one loses control of a schedule. And what then? More control would be lost.”

“Poor Ken,” he said, looking back at the house.

“Not really,” Maggie said under her breath.

Cole said, “Maggie’s in the middle.”

Max went around the driver’s side and climbed into the back seat. Cole extended his hand for her to get in and she did. He swept his hand over her

ass while she climbed past him. She flexed her muscles and her belly jumped. She sat down without letting on that he'd done it. Sat in the middle of the Range Rover's back seat, looking out between her father and mother with a wide-eyed expression. She stifled a laugh.

When they were on their way, out of the winding and hilly woods of the southern coast of the island and past Jamestown, Cole said, "Were you a good girl last night?"

Her wide eyes returned, and she said with a constricted throat, "What?"

He said in a sultry voice, "Did you go to sleep when you were supposed to?"

"Yes," she said stiffly. Looked to Max. His face was blank but he looked towards Cole.

Cole said, "You weren't up late? Playing around when you promised you would be sleeping?"

"No," she said, a smirk tugging at her lips now. "I went right to sleep."

"That's my good girl," he said, and her scalp tingled. She looked to the rearview mirror, her father's eyes were on the road.

"Good girl," Cole repeated and he put his hand on her knee.

She scrunched her toes up in her loafers.

Max put his hand on her other knee.

AGUILLARD WAS a Michelin-star restaurant in a side-gabled Colonial Georgian. Clapboard siding painted Waller green with white trim and worn red brick stairs, arrow shaped pediment and fluttering American flag made this place holler Rhode Island. They were in downtown Newport, near Newport Harbor, down from White's Wharf, nestled in a quaint street lined with cedar shingled cottages and boutiques. While everyone got seated Max ran back to the car to put the parking pass in the window. When he came back to the table Cole was sitting close to Maggie and they were going through the menu they shared together. There was an empty spot next to Maggie, but seeing her sitting at the table with her mother and father and leaning to read a menu together with handsome Cole made his insides tighten. He shrugged it off and took the spot next to her, held her hand. She gave it freely and offered a smile. He saw that Cole had his hand on her knee under the table. He shifted uncomfortably.

Maggie came close to him and said, “We’re getting the Galloni prosciutto, grilled bread and fig jam—”

“*You are?*” he said, eyeballing her, then Cole. *The couple ordering together.*

She rolled her eyes without rolling them, a tiny fluttering movement, an exasperated breath. “We’re ordering the same thing but I wanted to try the duck eggs. I was hoping you would order them so I could try them.”

“Yeah, fine. I’ll order the duck eggs.”

She set her menu in front of her and put her hand under the table, squeezed his thigh, her eyes on her parents as they silently went through their menus.

She got his attention and mouthed, *What’s wrong?*

“I’m fine,” he whispered.

Martin waved to a waiter with authority and irritation. They ordered. When the waiter left he regarded his watch and said, “We have to meet Valerie at 9:30. At The First Presbyterian.”

Valerie was the wedding planner the Beckers had hired. Max pitied the woman, considering how difficult normal weddings were, even his own sister’s. But at the scale and cost that Valerie was working at, and for clients like the Beckers, she must have nerves of steel.

Carol leaned forward, said, “There is time.” Then to Max, “How are your father and mother?”

“They’re doing great,” he said. The Beckers and the Miltons had met for dinner at a Manhattan restaurant in June. It had been cordial and light and the Beckers seemed to like his parents. In the days after, his dad had come up with funny nicknames for their coldness. Max thought they were funny but he knew his dad probably had worse ones he used around the house when Max wasn’t around, and sure his mother belly-laughed at them.

“I was wondering this morning how your father fared in that case against VitoTech?”

“Uh,” he stalled, trying to recall what his dad had told him, “They settled, I think.”

“I thought they would,” she said. Then added, “Your father is a good lawyer.”

It sounded like a statement but also a question and he wasn’t sure if or how he should respond. Max’s father was indeed a good lawyer. He also was a town comptroller. Max hated to admit it but the bulk of his money

had come from carpet stores. Partnering with an Iranian businessman twelve years ago and spreading his one store to eight that dotted Illinois, Iowa, and Michigan. Max's parent's money came mostly from people's urges to have their feet walk on something comfortable. And the Milton family fortune was a fraction of the Becker's. Practically on fumes, he imagined, with four kids going to good colleges.

Carol moved her gaze to Cole, said, "Martin told me you were heading to Harvard Law."

"I am," he said.

"Max is going to Wall Street," she said, "Winter-Oxbow. You'll miss him?"

"We'll keep in touch, Carol," he said, leaning forward and smiling for her. He kept his hand on Maggie's knee under the table, then went into a long tale about his political plans that Max knew was bullshit he was making up on the spot.

Maggie leaned to him, kept her legs still. She whispered, "Oxbow?"

He shrugged.

"I thought you wanted to go to Kohl-Kravitz."

"Your dad got me a spot at Oxbow."

"So you're not going to KK? You were so happy..."

"Maybe your dad knows something I don't...like KK is going belly up, or under investigation..."

"Maybe," she said. Her face showed disappointment, she turned back to the table. She whispered, "Maybe not."

THEY'D VISITED two other churches that morning but when they walked into the Trinity Episcopalian they knew it would be where they married. They stood, hand in hand in the creaking nave, looking around in circles at the gleaming white-painted wood.

"I told you," Valerie, their wedding planner, said. Carol and Martin were stone-faced, having known this would be the church all along.

A sea-coast church, three-hundred years old, a place where George Washington himself had attended services. Cathedral ceiling, the pulpit an intricate carved thing, massive, shaped like a chalice. The pews were elaborate numbered boxes. Brilliant ornate chandeliers, three of them, ran

the center, all of them dangling slightly northeast. Hundreds of years of coastal wind had made the building lean.

“This is it, Maggie,” he said quietly, wishing they were alone, rather than being watched for reactions.

“This *is* it, Max,” she said. She put her shoulder against him, lay her head on him. She turned quick, kissed him, led him by his hand between the white box pews and headed to the tall stained glass apse.

Valerie stopped her. “Oh, not so fast,” she said with a laugh. “You don’t want to take him up there.”

“I don’t?”

“Not until the day, Miss Becker.”

“Oh.”

Cole stepped past them, hands in his pockets, eyeing the height of the church, looking up at the upper deck’s white balconies. “It *is* beautiful, guys,” he said. Took a hand out of his pocket and held it out. “Let the Best Man take you up there. They can all see how beautiful you’ll look on your wedding day.”

Maggie stepped forward without hesitation and took his hand. He gripped her, pulled her to him and walked her up the aisle and the three steps to the first tier next to the pulpit. She struggled to keep a straight face. Standing high in the second tier of the apse she could see what it would be like on her wedding day. She imagined the pews filled with her family and friends. That mean little face that she loved, the one glowering at her and Cole right now, would be next to her. She would say to it, I do—right now, however, she was laughing at the effect she was having posing up here with his best friend.

Standing in the wood-paneled grid below, was her mother and father, her groom, their wedding planner. All faces turned to her expectantly but only one smile and that was on Valerie. Looked up at the balconies, the huge organ sitting at the rear balcony, below that the sunlight streaming in from the opened doors. She would marry Max here, then she might not ever step foot in this state again despite how beautiful it was.

Cole was nodding, holding her hand, smiling and taking in the beautiful church like she did. He leaned close, and still with a pleasant smile, he said next to her ear, “Did you wear any panties today?”

He returned to standing, looking down to her parents and to Max. She laughed. Turned him to face her, like they were getting married today, took

his tie and brought it out of his jacket, stroked her thumb along the patterned silk, ran her hand over its shine, said, “I like you with a tie.”

He leaned in again and now he said, “I’m going to use it to bind your little wrists back tonight while I fuck your ass.”

“Oh,” she startled. It turned to a laugh, performing for those watching. They couldn’t imagine he’d whispered something so dirty. She wanted this to look very innocent, but those words just set a fucking flame off in her. Her stomach trembled and her legs shook. Wanted to be home, somewhere private, anywhere but here.

“Well, did you?” he said, cocking an eyebrow.

“Did I what?” she whispered.

His eyes traveled her body, settled between her legs.

Her panties. She said, “Yes.”

His face moved towards hers and for a horrible second she thought he was going to kiss her in front of everyone watching, but his lips brushed her cheek and he whispered in her ear, “Down the nave, turn right, past the sacristy, left at the vestry, there’s a washroom. Go. Take your panties off and put them in my pocket.”

He pulled back, face beaming with a performing smile. He nodded to the audience below while they watched, crinkled his nose, said, “I think she likes it.”

MAGGIE’S EYES SAID A LOT. Whatever Cole was whispering up there was not sweet and supportive despite what that plastered smile might convey. He was saying things that made her lips part. She didn’t know what to think of them but Max could tell that she liked them. His best friend up there standing with Max’s fiancée in the spot where he would marry her—it was a violation.

Carol and Martin were non-plussed but who knew what they were really thinking. They never let anything on. Two poker players who laughed at the winnings of the world’s greatest poker players. Martin earned or lost that in a day. They were on a different scale. Was it obvious to them? Did they wonder what their daughter was doing? They were smarter than anyone he ever knew. Surely they could pick up on this. But what was he to do? He couldn’t make a scene. That would make it worse. Right now he felt himself

diminishing in their esteem. Becoming less than a man. His own Best Man handling his woman in an intimate way. Fuck, yes, they were all friends. Yes, Cole touched Maggie all the time. Had done this for years. It's just that now Max knew for sure he was whispering dirty things to her. He knew Maggie had sucked his cock.

But, shit, no one else here knew that. The fucking Beckers were always stone-faced. Maybe it was nothing. Valerie was cocking her head in an appreciative way, loving to see the bride-to-be up where she belonged, up in the spot where she would tie the knot. She didn't seem to let on that this was wrong. Maybe Best Men did this. *Was* this normal? Valerie had escorted couples through this procedure countless times, she wasn't bothered in the least. Maybe it was all in his head. He just didn't know anymore.

"What do you think?"

Max startled to hear Martin's voice so close. While he was lost in thought Martin had moved himself to stand next to him, arms folded, eyeballing Maggie and Cole up on the pulpit.

"I think she's beautiful," he said, words coming out ill-formed, just his truth tumbling out.

"About the church, Max," he said with an even tone, though his annoyance was implied.

"This is where I want to marry your daughter," he said, eyes still on her while Cole whispered something else in her ear, and she came away shocked.

Martin said, "I knew it," and he put his hand on Max's shoulder, imbuing him with some strength and bolstering him suddenly.

Yeah, Maggie was his. That wasn't going to change. She was Max's bride.

Martin squeezed Max once and this emotionless man handling him affectionately made his eyes well. He felt so welcome.

Martin looked at his watch and said, "We have to go. We have to do the tastings."

"Yes, sir," he said.

"Margaret," he called, his strong voice echoing off all the church's old hard edges. "Come. We have appointments."

She stepped down off the stage and walked towards them along the nave. She was blushing. Her cheeks were bright with color. She passed Max, didn't say a word, but caught his eye and smirked, eyebrows raised,

biting the corner of her lower lip. She went on and turned to cross behind the pews and disappeared under the archway that lead to the vestry.

Cole caught up and he said, "She just has to go the washroom." He stood next to Max, hands in his pockets, a smug smile on his handsome unshaved face.

Carol took Valerie by her arm and led her out the open doors and into the September sunlight, already talking business. Martin checked his watch and left Max and Cole alone without a word, following behind Carol and Valerie but turning left when they were all outside.

Cole said, "Have you ever seen a church like this? It's so crazy, Max."

"What are you doing?"

"What?"

"Flirting with her in front of her parents."

"They don't notice. I'm not doing anything...I joke around with her all the time anyway."

"It's different now."

"Yeah, but her parents don't know that. As far as they—"

"It looks bad, okay?" he said, his voice rising.

"Max—"

"You're fucking standing up there with my wife, Cole," he said, his voice taking a firm tone. "That's my wife. You think I like seeing you two up there?"

"What the fuck is wrong with you?"

"With me?"

"With you, Max. It's *me*. I'm fucking around. You think I'm trying to take her from you or something? We're playing. Maggie and I are having fun. She's into it. Fuck, I should have left last night. I knew this was going to be bad..."

"No. Don't go."

"Look, Max, you're fucking up here."

"I'm fucking up? *I'm* fucking up?"

"You're fucking up."

"I'm doing this for Maggie, Max. All this...teasing. I'm not trying to hurt you. I'm trying to make her crazy."

"Why?"

"We want her to have an awesome time, right? Want her to have, like, experiences she missed or whatever. Then she needs attention. You have to

work her over.”

“In front of her parents?”

“She has a hangup with her folks. I wonder why?” he said, throwing his hands up and rolling his eyes. “It turns her on. Trust me.”

“You're telling me what turns my fiancée on?”

“Max. Don't. Okay? It's me, dude. This will be our Secret Society. We'll make Maggie happy. You're going to marry her. You're the lucky asshole who gets to spend your life with that fucking goddess, okay? She's looking for a little fun. Don't deny her.”

“I'm not. I'm the one who agreed to this.”

“Yeah, but you're wrecking it for her.”

“No, I'm not.”

“Trust me, you are. Think about it. You agreed to something crazy. So fucking do it, Wild Man. Fucking do it. Show her a crazy time. But Max...really commit to it. She'll thank you forever. You keep throwing up road blocks because, dude, I think you're making this about you.”

He paused and they held eyes. Max could feel some truth seeping in and he didn't like it.

Cole said, “Stop thinking about what *you* want out of this. I know this excites you. You wouldn't agree to it otherwise. Stop being selfish. Start thinking about what *she* wants. What *she's* missing. Promise me. Think about it.”

He nodded with a smile over Max's shoulder and he turned to see Maggie come sheepishly from the archway, done in the washroom.

Cole left him there, went to Maggie. They stood in the light from the opened doors, two familiar friendly shapes, mostly silhouette, lit from behind by the outside. Maggie and Cole came toe to toe and she looked in his eyes. She had her hands together at her front, bunched in fists. She took one fist and put it in the pocket of Cole's jacket, stuffing something in there.

“MAX, I just want to go home,” she whispered to him in the back seat of the Range Rover.

“You feel all right?” he whispered back.

“Yes. I just...”

“What?”

“I *know* where I want the reception.”

“The Poirot?”

“You know,” she said, her eyes on his now.

That was where she wanted to have their reception, but for whatever reason, her parents were making her meet for samples at two other hotels. Truthfully, she didn't really care where they went, but given the three choices she'd have just picked the Poirot and that was that.

Max looked nervously up to the front of the vehicle. Could see Carol in three quarter pose, her stern brow fixed on the Newport traffic. The Beckers didn't speak, but the radio quietly played a symphony from the satellite radio.

“Maggie, they went and arranged all these meetings. We have to...”

“I know,” she sighed, a slight whine whirring up her voice. “I just want to get back home.”

He had a good idea that meant she wanted to get moving on her sexual activity. Like Cole had her so worked up she couldn't take it anymore. Didn't even care about planning their wedding, she just wanted to get stuffed with his cock. Shame washed over him because it aroused him. Made him mad, made him jealous, hurt his heart but he felt an excitement—low and primal, something in him got lit up by her badness. He could fight it, wrestle her to suit his whims but maybe Cole was right. He thought Cole was right, but he didn't want to admit it, because admitting it would lead to letting her do it. And as much as he wanted it, it frightened him. He'd wanted to fence in her sexuality and watch it like an exhibit. He was trapped in his own fucking cage now. He'd built it. Done it himself. Ran all the walls, barbwire along the top, maybe an electrified line. Got it all set up, a job well done, but he'd fucking locked himself inside it now. He was trapped with whatever it was that lurked in Maggie's psyche. Like a goddamn tiger, he was starting to think.

He sighed, didn't want the answer maybe, but asked just the same. “Maggie...what did you put in Cole's pocket?”

She let her eyes go wide, watching out the window between her parents. Without looking at him she leaned close and whispered, “My...panties.”

He brought his hands together in his lap, his thighs flexed like steel. Breathed softly, let his insides loosen before he started to hurt. Concentrated on his breathing. Anger came up and he moved away from it. Dodged it. He bit his lips and breathed some more.

“You okay?” she said.

He nodded, lips still pinched.

He whispered, “You're not wearing any panties?”

She shook her head.

He got close and said, “You're a bad little girl.”

She nodded and smirked.

Black Beach

SATURDAY, SEPTEMBER 30TH

SO SHE SAT through two tastings at two different restaurants with no panties on. While she was planning her wedding she had all her attention between her legs. On the excitement there. Cole had her wet. This was so bad. Badness on an unthinkable level. She would marry Max but she would always remember that the day they planned their wedding she was dreaming of another man. Dreaming of Cole—and her husband was going to watch her make love with him. It was the kind of naughtiness that she had fantasized but never thought would ever be a part of her life. Her ideas of relationships were formed in Classic literature. Monogamy and fidelity, devotion and love. That was her conception. Those were her rules, her morality. She couldn't deny she had urges but they were pure smutty badness. Hormonal blips, moments in time when her body craved masculinity by ancient processes of fertility. Now she had both. Love and smutty badness. Attached to Max and loving him but that good man had allowed her to explore. So wanting to be with her that he would allow her to be shared so she wouldn't wonder. It was a perfect situation. Max could get hissy at times but she would work with him. Knew what he liked, learning what he responded to. Liked to be challenged, liked to be humiliated. Wasn't sure how much yet, didn't think Max knew either but if the cost of admission for this wild ride was making her Max suffer in his weird little way she was on board. It turned her on too.

They were at the third tasting, sitting at a table in a private room at The Poirot on Cliff Walk. The place Maggie knew they would select for their

reception. An elegant, opulent mansion from the Gilded Age. It was perfect.

“Now this one, Margaret, I think you will love.”

She nodded for Valerie, showed her a semblance of enthusiasm.

The waiter appeared, dressed in white jacket and black pants. He brought a plate and set it in front of her. The plate was Limoges, the edges gilded.

“We’ve, of course, saved the best for last,” Valerie said, eyeing Maggie but moving to include Carol and Martin. “Butter poached Maine lobster, polenta, an heirloom tomato confit, hedge hogs, and a black garlic custard.”

Valerie leaned to her plate and smelled, her face showing elegant joy.

They sat at a table for eight. Gold linen draped over the table, a sheet of white over top. Crystal vase in the center of the table with orange blossoms. The room was small, set up one step from the rest of the dining room. Walls in mahogany panels, arm chairs in leather like a gentleman’s club from hundreds of years ago. They sat on white wicker around the table. French doors lined the wall that faced the ocean. It was crisp out there, lawn leaf-littered, white caps winking silently on the rough navy water.

The lobster was delicious. Maybe the best she had ever tasted. The flesh was soft and smooth, had the texture of the butter. The table was interspersed with plates they’d been served and appetizers she hadn’t yet tried. A pewter bucket in a stand at her elbow held a chilling bottle of Chateau Ste. Michelle.

She was not one of *those* young girls. One that swooned and day-dreamed of their wedding. She never kept a scrapbook of ideas, had no plans for her wedding dress, didn’t care about flowers. She was Dutch. Her mother was pragmatic Chinese. Her parents were cold. She could have told her mother over the phone: Trinity Church, The Poirot on Cliff Walk, lobster and steak. Stated the date. Shown up in white. She was not a princess. However, as detestable as even her parents found this, it was how it was done in Newport, and this was about connections and business as much as it was for their wedding. Martin and Carol needed to tell others of their choices and decisions for their daughter’s wedding. She was along for the ride.

Cole pulled closer a delicate bowl rounded with glistening amber-green beads of Golden Osettra. He scooped some into his mouth with a mother-of-pearl caviar spoon.

“Shit, Maggie,” he whispered. “God, that’s good.”

Max was trying the Angus prime filet mignon in a bone marrow bordelaise. "How is it?" she asked him. He answered with his eyes, letting them go wide while he chewed. When he swallowed he said, "We're miles from Altieri's."

Cole laughed. She turned to laugh with him as well and he lifted the spoon for her, held a small hillock of Russian caviar. Faces were turned. She held Cole's hand steady, opened her mouth seductively, looked in his eyes while he gingerly deposited something onto her waiting tongue. She tasted the salty fish eggs, sucked her lips delicately while they waited for her opinion, said, "We have to have the caviar." Her father nodded.

She poured a half glass of Chardonnay and watched her hand shake. She needed to get out of here. Needed to get home, get down to the beach and touch Cole's body. Feel what his hands on her would be like. She sipped her wine. Watched Cole's masculine hands pull over a plate of oysters. Watched the muscle and tendon at work, the cuff of his fine dress shirt slip along the tweed of his jacket. His skin was tanned and smooth. He worked the tiny fork under his oyster and she watched him unabashedly. He lifted, then tilted the shell to his lip. Watched now the muscles of his neck and face work, watched him consume the slippery oyster, then suck his own lips.

"Maggie, mm," he moaned, "they serve it in a pickled pear mignonette. Please," he said, preparing a shell for her. She wanted it fed to her. She wanted Max to watch. She wanted everyone to watch. Her handsome Best Man, with his nice build, dashing looks, roguish long blonde hair. At Farmingham she wanted people to know he was her friend. Now, here, she wanted people to worry they were intimate. She held her mouth open for him. He moved the shell to her lips while everyone watched this travesty. Fed her his oyster and she slurped it down with grace, her eyes on his. He watched her as she chewed twice and swallowed. Put the empty shell back on his plate. He scooted closer in his chair and he leaned towards her to tell her something. She covered her mouth, leaned in to hear it. Watched everyone's face waiting to hear what she thought of the oyster.

He whispered huskily, "Does it taste as good as my come?"

"Oh...wow," she muttered, her eyes wide and watching her parents. "Oh...wow."

"Is it good? How does it taste?" Valerie asked, her face was looking a little worn now. Late in the day, and Maggie liked to think this heat between her and Cole was starting to worry the woman.

“God,” she said. “It’s good. It’s so good. Wow. If you’ll excuse me.” She left the table politely and stumbled to the washroom, her face blossoming with heat.

OH. My. God. This fucking Cole. She had no idea it would be like this. He was hot and he was her friend and having sex with him when you were on a journey of missed sexual opportunities seemed like an obvious sort of thing. She had no idea he could turn up the heat so high. Her stomach was jabbed with dull tension, he had her aching. Was this what it was like for those other girls he dated?

She stared at her smiling but flushed face in the gold framed mirror of a small, elegantly decorated bathroom. So glad now that Max had slowed them down. He was right. He was right to stop them. This *was* a big deal. God, she didn’t know it could be like this. This was more intense than the anticipation of Jay. Though, to be fair, she was quite convinced she would not go all the way with him. Right now, looking in this mirror, looking in her own amber eyes, there was nothing that was going to stop her from having sex with Cole. Nothing. She was ravenous.

Dried her hands on the towel left at the edge of the sink, wished she’d brought her purse to touch up the shine on her lips but she’d left that table in a hurry. Smiled again at her blushing reflection. The color that Cole had put on her cheeks.

When she stepped into the hall he was there. Leaning against a mahogany paneled wall, elbow on a high marble topped table with an exploding bouquet of flowers in a crystal vase. She stopped short, froze in her tracks while the heavy bathroom door closed behind her. She smirked when he smirked. One corner of his lips coming up in a confident angle. Her smirk less confident.

Cole eased off the table and sauntered the three steps to come to her. Put a hand on the wall behind her, looked down on her, made her look up into his blue eyes.

“You ran off on me.”

“I had to...go to the bathroom.”

“I already have your panties. What did you take off for me this time?”

She shrugged, sucked on her lower lip and smiled. His hand worked in his pocket while his eyes still held hers. He brought out her bunched panties in his grip. He held them to his mouth and smelled them. He smiled mean, eyes narrow, humming appreciatively like she had the best smell in the world. She'd checked them before she handed them over and thought they smelled like detergent.

"Lift the front of your skirt, Margaret," he said, tucking her panties back into the pocket of his jacket.

She didn't even protest. Her hands dropped to the hem of her tartan skirt and she eased it up slowly to the tops of her thighs. They were in a hallway that bridged the restaurant to the hotel. A quiet well-appointed passage but one where someone could come through at any moment.

"Higher," he said.

She sucked her lips again, inched her skirt up almost to her waist. His hand was on her and she struggled to keep her eyes open. She gasped. His big hand flat on the front of her thigh. Sliding higher then, heel first, fingers dragging the cable knit tights.

"What are you doing?" she whispered.

He moved like he would kiss her and she jutted her chin to receive it, but he brushed his cheek against hers as his fingers worked under the waistband of her tights.

"Oh my God, Cole," she sighed.

The tips of his fingers worked over her soft flesh and she could feel each point where he touched her. They scored over her skin, low, to the side, coming to the crease where her thigh met her belly. Her legs began to tremble.

"I'm going to touch your pussy now," he whispered.

"Jesus, Cole, please just do it," she said, her whisper trembling with anticipation.

Using just the pad of his middle finger he explored her shapes. Tracing the cleft in her shaved mound, tickling high along her commissure where it crested above her hood. Then slipping along the plump engorged shaved halves on either side of her entry.

"Oh God," she moaned.

When he touched her labia she almost cried out. She was wet. Could feel how slick she was in the warm easy movement of his fingertip. He

stroked so lightly it tickled her and made her breaths heave and her eyebrows raise high.

"Mm, Maggie, this is one nice little pussy. It's so hot, it's burning. You know how wet you are?"

She nodded, let her eyes close now, concentrated on the feel of his finger.

"I've touched a lot of pussy, Maggie. You know me. I've never felt a girl get so wet." His finger found her center and tested her aperture, eased her apart but didn't penetrate. "Fuck, you feel tight. I can't wait to fuck this little thing. God, you're dripping. You really want my cock don't you?"

"I do."

"I'm going to give it to you. Don't worry, baby. In your ass, that little mouth again, balls deep in your pussy."

"Oh shit, Cole..."

"You going to take it all?"

"I will."

"Tell me."

"I'm going to take it, Daddy. Every inch."

"That's a good little girl," he said. He eased his hand up her belly and out of her tights. Her skirt fell. Touched her with the middle finger, slipped it along her lower lip. It was slick with her excitement. She could smell herself on him. He forced her lips to part with his finger, then her teeth. She took it. Took his finger deep, tasted her sex on him. Sucked his finger, regarded him with narrowed eyes.

"God, you can suck a cock. Max know how good you are?"

She nodded, her lips pouted around his gently plunging finger. Her hands came and held his wrist.

"He tell you?"

She nodded again.

"Margaret, did you show Max my come in your mouth?"

She nodded and smiled, laughed through her nose.

"God, you're my kind of little slut. You're a dirty girl."

"Mm-hmm," she hummed around his finger.

Her right hand lowered, found his belt buckle, smoothed his pants below that, found his cock down the right side of his pants. He wasn't wearing underwear. She handled his balls, then squeezed his penis through the gabardine.

“You going to fuck your husband’s Best Man?”

“Yeah,” she gasped, making a spit bubble on one side of his thrusting finger.

“You fucking dirty whore. You want my cock in that whore pussy?”

She nodded enthusiastically.

His other hand stopped her from stroking him. He held her wrist.

“Don't make me hard, Margaret. Unless you want your mother to see how fat my cock is.”

She smiled and laughed again. He thrust his finger deep in her mouth.

“Do you? You want her to know what you're going to take tonight. Want her to know—”

The door opened at the end of the hall on the hotel side and their waiter emerged, holding an empty silver tray at his side. His eyes caught them and he quickly looked down. Cole took his finger from her, and she wiped her mouth dry with both her hands.

They stayed quiet, unmoving. Waited for him to pass. He did, his eyes averted, went into the restaurant.

Cole kissed her lips when the waiter was gone and her hands came up, her nails scratching slowly across his stubble. He sucked her lip, pinched it in his and pulled it away, looking in her eyes. He winked, licked his lips, then went past her into the bathroom.

“Jesus Christ,” she whispered alone in the empty hall. She straightened her tights and adjusted her skirt, dried her mouth again and returned to the table.

RIDING IN THE RANGE ROVER, heading back to Narragansett, stomach full, tired, feet sore, Max couldn't shake the feeling that something had happened when she was in the washroom. Cole had left the table shortly after Maggie did and there was an overlap of time when they were both gone. Max was left at the table to smile and nod and do his best not to look as uncomfortable as he felt. And boy did he feel uncomfortable.

Maggie and Cole were friends, but the way he fed her that oyster? That was too much. It had to be obvious. Max put a brave face for her parents and pretended like that was normal at Farmingham. The three of them were just real good buddies.

He talked with Carol about the arrangements, told her what he and Maggie had discussed. And just like Maggie had told him, they could have done this without visiting. She wanted the Trinity, she wanted the Poirot. She wanted steak and lobster. He tried not to eye the door where they had both disappeared.

Could something have happened? It was just a few minutes but maybe Cole could have bent her over the sink and fucked her. Exciting thought, but he was left out. He didn't want to be left out. But then maybe if that was what she wanted maybe that was what he had to give her. Or support or allow. Or whatever it was he was doing. His control on this exciting project was getting weaker and weaker. He rubbed his sweaty palms together.

Maggie's slim hand worked down his wrist, slipped between his hands, laced her fingers through his and held him. Their eyes met, she smiled wanly. A look of guilt. An acknowledgement that today was a little too far. Could see the love in there. The love for him. She still loved him. He squeezed her hand.

She said, "It's going to be a beautiful wedding."

He said, "I can't wait," leaned close and kissed her cheek.

Maggie moved forward to speak to the front, her hand still holding his. She said, "I know we said we would go back to Vermont tonight but I think we'll stay."

"Another night?" her mother said. "You told us you'd be leaving."

"I know, but I think we're tired. It's been a long day. We'll stay, go to bed early, out early. You won't see us in the morning."

She checked her watch, suggesting it was a little late in the day to bring this decision to her, but given no potential conflict, no arriving guests needing the room he and Cole were in she said, "That's fine, Margaret. You should have stayed in the first place. It made more sense."

"I know," she said. "I wasn't thinking."

"I knew you'd be tired," Martin said.

"It's too much for one day, then to drive? ..." her mother said, turning to look out her passenger window while she talked.

Maggie eased back next to him, and put her shoulder to his. Saw her other hand go out and lay palm up on her thigh. Watched Cole's hand wander over, lace through her fingers like she'd done with Max and now his

fiancée was holding hands with two men. Two men she would have sex with tonight.

MAGGIE LOOKED like she was going to kill her brother.

They sat around a fire on the beach. Max and Maggie leaning against the old greyed log, Cole sitting on the stone where Max had sat and watched his fiancée suck Cole's cock. Ken was explaining what he studied at Stanford. Told them all about regenerative medicine and his work on studying the growth of an artificial liver. Cole kept asking questions, seeming like he was genuinely curious but there was a whimsical tone to his voice as though he knew by prolonging this conversation he was driving Maggie out of her mind. His poor little girl was next to him now, her brow low, a single crease formed above her nose. She looked like a surly little brat. Max could see the humor in it. Could see the joy in making her anxious. Max never did that for her, never made her wait, never made her beg. Of course, he wasn't sure he had that ability. Not sure if depriving her would lead to her heightened arousal. Also, if he were to act like Cole was acting she would climb on him and his resolve would wane and he would be doing what she wished in a matter of seconds. Cole had power over her. In a way, had power over both of them now.

They'd skipped dinner. Everyone full after all the tasting they had done during the day. Martin and Carol retired to separate rooms in the house. Ken hadn't eaten so he reheated leftovers in the kitchen and Cole and Max and Maggie had sat with him around the counter and told him all the things they'd done during the day. Not all the things, of course. Cole had kept his back to Maggie, like he was purposely disregarding her, though he did seem to have an easy friendship forming with Ken. When it grew dark they came down to the beach.

"When are you going back, Ken?" she asked. Max stifled a smile.

"In the morning," he said.

"Early?" she said.

"Pretty early."

She checked her watch.

"Mm," Ken hummed, recalling, "It's at 8:15. T.F. Green."

Maggie didn't follow through with an observation that he should go to bed, but given her rude performance last night with her friends he wouldn't have put it past her. Max snuggled next to her and rubbed her arm.

Cole smiled wryly, said to Ken, "So, what's the latest on stem cells?"

Maggie moaned and let her head fall against Max's shoulder as Ken raised his eyebrows, cocked his head, and told Cole all the latest news, starting at the beginning. Her hair was still in a bun and he stroked her soft cheek and kissed the top of her head. They shared a wool blanket, much like she had done with Cole last night. She settled against him, pulled the blanket up to cover them a little better.

He jumped when she touched him. Her hand settled between his legs under the blanket, curious fingers seeking him out, trying to find his penis. He wasn't hard, it was cold and her brother was there. Let his legs slide apart so she could locate it more easily. Found it then, her fingers divining its shape under his pants, putting some life in it, making it swell.

"Jesus, Maggie," he whispered into her ear while he cupped his hand on her neck. Her mouth climbed his neck, kissed his chin, took his lips.

He made out with her, felt the urgency in her kisses. She moved slow, but her tongue was eager. Ken's voice by the fire said, "Would you look at these two."

Cole said, "You should see them at school."

"Really? ...Aw, thats nice. After all these years too."

Maggie laughed and pulled her kiss away. "We're twenty-one," she said.

Cole said, "Yeah, Max is really good to her."

"Yeah," Ken said, "Max has been really good for her."

"Thanks, Ken," Max said.

"I mean it. She needed someone like you."

Cole nudged Ken with an elbow and said, "You need a ride in the morning? To the airport?"

Ken ran his hand through his hair, exhaled, said, "Yeah, I guess...that would be great."

Maggie said, "There's no room. The Jeep's small—our luggage, the raven head, my bird cage..."

Ken frowned, said, "What bird cage?"

"Long story," Maggie answered.

“Holy shit,” Ken laughed to the sky, “How did I end up with such a terrible family?”

“How bad a passenger are you, any way?” Cole laughed.

Maggie grimaced, rolled her head around. “You know what? ...No. I’m leaving my bird cage here. Leaving it behind.”

“So, I can come?” Ken asked, perplexed brows pointed up in the middle.

Cole checked his watch, said, “Yeah. We should hit the hay. Early start. The longer we’re up the more likely you’ll get bumped by another inanimate object.” Cole moved like he was going to head to the trail and Ken went ahead of him. When Ken had made some distance, Cole called behind him, “Okay, Ken, we’ll see you in the morning.”

“Night, everyone,” he waved over his shoulder without looking back.

ALL THREE OF their faces were turned to the dark path, watching the darker figure of her brother crunching the gravel, turning, scrolling to the right, higher up the path, to the top of the cliff and then he was gone. Maggie moved off his lap and made her way around the fire and across to Cole with her face turned to where she’d last seen Ken, watching in case he returned after forgetting something.

Max felt the coolness on his thighs, her absence robbing him of her heat. Maggie brought Cole to sit with them by the fire. She sat herself on Cole’s open lap, still watching the path.

“Is he gone?” Cole said to Max.

Max shrugged, he watched the path and all he could see was darkness. His eyes were blown out from the fire. “I think so,” he said.

Maggie held Cole's cheeks and she kissed him. His head turned up to meet hers and Max could hear them breathing through their noses while their mouths made wet sucking noises against each other. Maggie gulped like she was trying to talk around their twisting tongues, partial words being formed, swallowed by Cole. Things like, *all day, this guy, got me, couldn't wait, oh, touching me*. Cole's hand at Maggie's hip waved Max closer and he moved quickly to join them. He hated being left out but wondered why he was so easily disheartened, so easily dismayed. If Cole hadn't waved him

he may have sat there, four feet apart, until they were done, but nothing was *stopping* him from being a more positive and happy piece of this.

He sat himself next to Cole against the log, his Maggie sitting sideways in Cole's lap with her knees pointed at Max. Her attention was on Cole but he didn't feel excluded.

Max said, "Where do you want to do this? Out here?"

Cole said, "Just let it happen, bro," his eyes still on Maggie.

Maggie lifted the front of her skirt, brought it up her thighs. Cole's hand slipped underneath, worked under there and Max figured he was getting it inside her tights to touch her bare skin.

Max said, "Did anything happen when you two were in the washroom?"

They were kissing and they both started laughing, their smiling mouths pulling their kisses apart. They looked in each other's eyes.

Max said, "What?"

Maggie said, "Yeah..."

"What?"

"He said *really* dirty things to me." She opened her legs wider while Cole's arm moved, trying to get access.

"What dirty things—"

"Ah," she gasped, "oh, and he touched me, mm..."

Cole chortled softly, taking her mouth again with his own.

"He touched you?"

Maggie nodded while she kissed.

Max felt the jealousy come. His two best friends. His Maggie, who he loved and would wed, and Cole, who he was also beginning to presume he loved too. They were coming together without him. Doing things without him. Dirty things. She was sharing her intimacy with another man. Something that had been only for Max was now less exclusive. Something other men had experienced. And, as she shared herself, she learned other men's secrets. Learned the things they did. The way they kissed, the way they made love, their humor, their playfulness, their sex organs, their sexual abilities...their biology. Cole's semen was known to her. She knew its taste like she had teased him. She knew how much he came, knew he was uncircumcised. The most base and disgusting and private things that Cole had were now known by the woman he loved. And what if she liked his secrets better than Max's? What if she liked the taste of his semen, liked the size of his cock, liked his foreskin, liked those dirty things he said? Cole

was a better looking guy, smart and driven like Max, ambitious like Max, but he had a better build and a bigger cock...he made Maggie laugh too. Cole had spent four years with her at Farmingham. She loved spending time with him. Would those special things she loved about her Max be diminished? Would his offerings begin to seem meager?

“TAKE me to my room and fuck me,” she said to Cole, wrapping both her arms around his neck.

He whispered in her ear, “We’re a long way from fucking, Maggie. When I put my cock in you, you’ll be crying for it.”

“I’m crying now,” she said.

“You’re a sweet girl,” he said, and he kissed her lips, “but I want to see that whore again. Show me that whore.”

She whispered close to his ear, “Take me to my room and I’ll show you what a bad girl I am.”

He laughed, eyes low and mean. The sound familiar, she’d heard him laugh almost every day for the last four school years, but those eyes were menacing. He slipped his thumb into her mouth and she sucked it eagerly. Cole’s head angled over his shoulder but his eyes were still on hers. He said to her future husband, “You ready, Max? We’re going to turn your little slut inside out.”

He stood up and cradled her in his arms and she hugged his neck tightly. Max was quiet and she couldn’t get a good look at his face but every time she caught him in her periphery as Cole carried her across the macadam and up the trail to the house she saw that his face was crestfallen. She could see too his resignation. Her poor man a victim of his own erotic impulses. Every part of him hating seeing her with a bigger stronger man, one who was going to fuck her brains out, but yet he was surrendering. He even held the kitchen door for them to pass through.

“Thanks, Max,” she giggled as her face traveled past his, floating past him in his best friend’s arms. Didn’t know what it was that was turning her on about seeing her love like that. Was it truly erotic? Did it turn her on to be taken in front of him? Or was it the knowledge that the man she loved was so aroused by this? So overwhelmed to see his libidinous fantasies brought to life. It could be both. Both were true. She loved being fucked while he watched. Loved the feeling of Jay and knew she was going to like Cole. But also felt very satisfied for Max. She was delivering something precise to him. Who else could deliver such erotic angst? She had incredible power over her Max.

“Max, max,” she whispered while Cole crossed the darkened kitchen.

He was there next to then, “What?” he said, a small sane piece of him desperate to hear that she had changed her mind.

She appealed to the dirty crazy part of her man, said, “Can you take my shoes off, I don’t want them to fall.” She flicked her feet to show him.

Cole paused at the bottom of the steel steps rising to the second floor and angled her so Max could pluck her shoes off.

“Thanks, Max,” she sighed as she was carried off again. Each step taking her from Max, literally, as he drifted behind them on the stairs, and philosophically too. Each step bringing her closer to her bedroom where she would spread her legs for her best friend and fuck him. He’d got her wet today, got her aching to be filled and now it was going to happen. When she’d got home from the wedding planning she’d had to powder herself again, all her creases were slick with her smell and her sweat. She didn’t clean. Thought it was exciting not to. Thought Cole would appreciate her lust. He was turning out to be far more powerful than she’d ever imagined. More sexy than she knew. Almost *jealous* feelings rose. Getting mad knowing all those other girls she’d seen him with in the past years had got to know this dirty confident part of him.

Max got ahead in the hall and he held her bedroom door open for them. He closed it when they passed and now she was alone.

Alone in her bedroom with boys. Such a forbidden thing. She’d wanted this so bad since she was just a teen. Boy crazy but a caged bird only dreaming of what it might be like to be loved. To know the touch of a boy. Now here it was, happening for real.

Cole lay her on the bed and her arms clung to him, tried to pull him on top of her but he freed himself from her clutches with his hands. He rose off

the bed, looked around her room. Put his hands in his pockets and wandered. Max sat himself on the leather chair where she had gone down on him last night. Cole walked and admired her things, his erection curving out the fly of his cotton pants.

“So this is where my little Maggie grew up.”

“Yeah,” she gasped, her breathy voice surged through her, as desperate as she felt. Her heart was beating double time.

“You painted this,” he said, standing with his back to her, looking up at a canvas on her concrete wall. A painting she had done when she was seventeen, full of dumb angst, dumb but honest—exploding feeling, leaking through her fingertips and translating all that she was missing onto canvas in cobalt and cadmium.

“Yeah, I—”

“No, I know you did it. I recognize your work.”

He turned then and came to the foot of her bed, took his jean jacket off and threw it on the floor at the base of the low case that held her records and turntable.

“Such an amazing talent, Max,” he said, looking at her.

“I know,” Max agreed.

“All that emotion, raw, untouched. Something always there under that Maggie sweetness. Little girl Margaret looking to get out. Go and play.”

Max wrung his hands together. “I love her, she’s...so amazing...”

“She is,” he said. “So much more than I ever even knew. My best friend,” he said, biting his lower lip, one corner of his mouth peeling up. “Take those tights off, show me your bare legs.”

She couldn’t wait to. Her hands went up under her skirt and she hooked them under the waistband of her cable knit tights. Wiggled them down her thighs, over her knees, turned them inside out pulling them off her feet, threw them to the floor at Max’s feet.

“She’s not wearing any panties, Max,” he said.

“I told him,” she said.

“She told me.”

“She put them in my pocket like a good girl.”

He stepped closer, coming to the side of the bed, the three of them forming a tight-angled equilateral triangle now. Equally separated but very close.

“Lift your skirt for us, Maggie. Show us.”

She bit her lip. Her heart moved to triple time. Max and Cole both watched between her legs waiting for her to reveal her most intimate part. Her pulse pounded up her neck. Her hands tugged at her skirt hem, pulled it high. She sat with her legs together, her knees touching, but they could see her flat belly above her thighs. If she hadn't had Max shave her they would have seen her dense pubic patch. She felt a static tingle travel her whole body, raise every hair she had on her scalp. Both sets of eyes on her, looking to see her dirty little snatch, wanting so bad to see it, both their pants were bulging out. She was making them hard. Making them hard by showing them her body, making them hard by every action she made, communicating that both of them would fuck her tonight.

"Spread your legs, Margaret...show us your pussy," Cole said.

She let her legs part, slowly. Slowly for them, slowly for her. She wanted this exquisite tension to last forever. Her legs went wider and wider. Her pussy made a wet sticking sound and then a liquid crackle. Both her lips sucked into her mouth and watched two boys peer between her legs and look at her most sacred space.

"What do you think?" Max asked and she stifled a giggle.

"Nobody's seen this?" Cole said.

She shook her head.

"Lee?"

She shook her head again.

"Only Max?"

And Jay. But she nodded. Whispered, "My gyno is a woman."

He sat next to her on the bed, put his middle finger in his mouth, his eyes on hers. Her belly tightened with excitement. Took his finger out and moved his hand between her legs. She opened wider for him. She stopped breathing. Watched his hand move. He touched her with his finger, stroked down between the cleft of her mound and she gasped, and tried to catch her sound.

"What a pretty little slit," he said. He worked his finger between her folds, up and down, tickling and smoothing, his touch so light he was going to make her scream. "Lot of boys missed out on one pretty little pussy." His finger dipped into her, shallow, enough to make her eyes close and she grunted.

Then he was up, standing again and looking around her room. He wore a slim black cotton sweatshirt and he peeled it up over his head, threw it

over top of his jacket. Sauntered around her room in just a plain white T-shirt and cotton pants, his hands undoing his buckle and he let the two ends hang and swing while he admired her record collection.

“What should we listen to?” he said.

Max said, “We can’t play music after ten.”

“They’re going to hear music. I’m going to make Maggie sing all sorts of songs,” Cole said, bent at her stacked and alphabetized vinyl, peering up through his eyebrows at her with a rakish smile.

“Eh-el...” she stammered.

“What’s that?” he said calmly.

“L. Alphabetical. Lester, Richard. Cello. Chi-Chi Nwanoku playing double bass.”

His finger rode the spines of her collection, pausing, then hooking and withdrawing her request.

“Please, hurry,” she said as he read the liner notes.

COLE SET the needle down on the spinning vinyl. Unplugged the headphones from Maggie’s tube amp and the quiet sounds of a cello mournfully wavered from her speakers.

“That’s beautiful, Maggie,” Cole said, ears cocked, listening to the music. He stripped his T-shirt off, and he was bare. Maggie’s eyes went over Cole’s body. Not jacked like Jay was, but still a fit looking guy. Narrow waist and broad shoulders, trim, arms muscular. He had a trail of darker hair from his chest down his belly. Max watched Maggie’s eyes dance all over his best friend and she bit and chewed her bottom lip.

Maggie eased up the bed, making room, inviting Cole to return. He came to her, plopped down over her, an arm on either side of her, hovered, took her mouth with a kiss. Her hands came up tentatively, afraid to touch his naked skin intimately. Sucked his cock last night but this was weird. Then she felt him. Two good friends, spent so much time together, and this was the first time she was feeling him with her hands in an intimate way. They touched, flinched back, touched again. They kissed. Then her hands settled on him. Smoothed in slow swipes over his shoulders. They kissed and sucked on each other’s mouths. Her hands explored. Over his shoulders, down his sides. Her skirt was sitting high, her bare legs open on

either side of him. Her pussy would be bare between them. He wondered if Cole could feel its heat. He liked that when he made out with her. Sometimes when they kissed and rolled on the bed he would feel her hot little crotch press up against him and it drove him wild.

Max flexed his hands, worked out the tension, cracked his knuckles. His cock was hard. Pressed into the front of his pants uncomfortably. He was hunched over, elbows on knees, intently watching his two best friends be intimate. His mouth was dry as sand. He adjusted his pants, pinched his fly and pulled a tent to ease his discomfort.

Cole was on his knees now, over her, grabbing at her sweater and peeling it over her head. He tossed it to Max's feet. Maggie smiled up at him, nervous again, sheepish smile on her bashful little face. She had her arms folded over her bra. Cole reached around her and undid her bun, let her hair fall around her shoulders.

"I want to see you naked," he said to her.

"You first," she said, high and girlish. Cole reached around behind her again and he undid the clasp on her bra. Her straps jumped and slipped down the skin of her upper arms. Maggie was biting her lip again. Cole caressed her arms then his hand went down her bare back and he unzipped her skirt.

Maggie's eyes watched Cole's, looking to see what he would do next. Took the hem of her skirt and eased it down. Tugging a little at a time, inching it down her waist, down to her hips. She pushed her back into the pillows and he slipped it down under her rump, down her legs and onto the floor. She closed her legs up. Cole kissed her knees.

"Is this my shy Margaret?" he asked her.

She nodded, swallowed a smile.

"Where's that little slut that sucked my cock?" Her swallowed smile blossomed, went wide, showed him her white teeth. Cole raised up, undid his zipper slowly and she watched it open. Pulled his cock out and showed it to her. Walked closer and her legs opened. He bent and kissed her lips once, then up again, held her head and pushed his cock into her mouth. She opened wide for him. Her hands came up and the bra fell, she was naked. He eased his cock in and out of her mouth, running his hands through her hair and holding it straight up over her, letting it fall back down.

"That's a good girl," he said. "So good at sucking cock. Okay, that's it, that's it..."

He eased his hips back, took it from her and sat between her legs.

"I want to look at you," he said. "My little Maggie." She lay back now, her breasts exposed, her nipples scrolled far from her body. Her eyes danced over Cole as he took her in. "My Maggie," he repeated. "More beautiful than I even thought."

"You thought about me?"

"Of course. I've jerked off to you. Sorry, Max."

"Did you?" she said, before Max could say anything.

Max swallowed.

"Sure." He bent and kissed her bare chest, the spot where her heart was, right between her breasts. She heaved and her chest rose to meet him. "Yeah," he said, "I think about you. You ever think about me?"

"A little," she said.

"Now we can. Now we can."

"Max...is...generous..."

Cole turned to him, frowned. "Come on, buddy. You going to watch..."

"He likes to watch," Maggie said.

Cole's frown deepened, deciphering meaning in that.

Max got up before he asked if they've done this before and he walked around to the other side of the bed.

Max said, "Did you really...jerk off...to her..."

Cole shrugged. "That's not bad. I never did anything about it. She's always been my friend. Your girlfriend. I wouldn't..."

His hand wandered over her body, lay flat on her belly button. "Spread those legs, Margaret."

She inhaled, a brisk rush of exciting air went into her lungs. She complied. Her legs opened wider for him, showed him her bare sex.

"Do you...really...like it?" she asked.

Max said, "She's nervous about her..."

"You tell her? ..." Cole said to him.

"Yeah," he said.

Cole said, "Maggie, you have a perfect little pussy. Tight and pink and wet. Show me how you touch it."

"No, Cole," she sighed, her brows going worried.

"Oh, shy Maggie," he said. He kissed the inside of her knee with his eyes on hers. "Show me how you play with it, Maggie. Show me what feels good." He kissed lower down her thigh by a fraction.

Maggie's chest began to surge with her breaths. Hands came to her belly, folded nervously together where she used to have hair. Her eyes narrowed on Cole. Slowly her middle finger extended, curled. Slipped lower over her tightly packed slit. She stroked herself while they both watched, graceful middle finger slipping up and down her slippery pink sex. She was wet already and now she produced more while they watched. Her skin gleamed. The curve of her mound picking up the LED shine and making her high points shimmer white. She trickled her wet. Moved and wiggled her mound apart, brought her labia out for them, worked them open, showed them her bright pink wings, her bubble gum interior. Her hips started to moil against her moving hand. Middle finger hooked and gently inserted, a moan built in her throat but wasn't uttered. "That's it, Margaret. You're a bad girl. You did this a lot in this room..."

She sucked her lips in, held back a gasp, closed her eyes and nodded.

"Such grace, Maggie, look at those elegant fingers. So talented, you play so beautifully." He lowered between her legs and Max felt his heart race now but he only kissed the back of her hand. Maggie's belly bounced when he did. She moved her hands away, Cole was a breath from her bare and eager pussy. She pushed her sex to him, wanted him to kiss her between her legs. But he retrieved her hand, held it, pulled it to his mouth. Took her shining middle finger that had just been in her body and he took it in his mouth. He sucked her finger and Maggie's mouth fell open.

It was almost too much for Max to take. Weren't they supposed to just fuck? What was with all this voodoo? He stopped himself from saying something. Wanted to interject, make a funny noise, say something stupid to make them laugh and break this fucking spell between them, but he heard Cole's words echoing from those white-painted Trinity walls. Saying he should commit to this. *Wild Man. Do it for her.* She was in ecstasy right now. It hurt his heart that it was with his friend but he couldn't take this from her. He rested his hand over her knee closest to him, felt her familiar thin feel, let his fingers drag up the inside of her leg. She liked it. Responded to it. Her eyes were still locked on Cole and her finger disappearing into his mouth but her lips had fallen wider.

Cole raised up, a suspicious smile on his face.

SHE WATCHED him between her open legs. Kneeling between them, confident, shirtless, hand in the pocket of his pants, doing something. His belt was unbuckled, his fly down but his cock had slipped back inside there, evident against the fabric, but hidden. The light cast from low, up high across his body, threw deep shadows on his face, showed his masculine angles. His shoulder muscles flexed as he worked something out of his pocket. He held it bunched in his fist, extended the fist towards her, opened it, and let the silky fabric scroll and dangle between them. The tie he'd worn today, the one she'd smoothed her hands over when they stood on the pulpit, the spot where she and Max would wed.

Cole held an end in each hand, leaned and hooped it around behind her head, sawed it in place along the back of her neck. His hands worked it into a loose Windsor knot. Max's eyes were wide, could not believe what he was watching. Neither could she. He held the knot, worked the wide end of the tie down her chest, drew the knot up close to her throat. Pulled her by the tie then, drew her up to sit, her mouth at his waist. Her hands went up the front of his pants, rubbed his cock through the cotton.

She could not believe this was her friend. Knew Cole had a reputation, didn't know it would be so intimidating to be with him. He was so dominant, so controlling, and she was falling into it, doing it willingly, wanting to feel what it would be like to be taken over. She'd spent so much time with him and there had never been a thing between them. Drank pitchers of beer, got drunk, did homework, movies, hours of video games. She knew he was hot. Saw him play lacrosse before, saw him shirtless before. Innocent. Not sexual. Knew he had a hot body. When they were in public she liked to be seen with him, wanted other people to know they were friends. Liked to put her hands on him innocently, liked it when he played around with her. Just good fun. Couldn't believe where they were now. Max was allowing something incredible but it was beginning to appear it might be more than either of them expected.

"Put your hand in my fly."

She did, slipped her hand between the unzipped flaps. He wasn't wearing underwear and she ran her fingers along the base of his cock. He thrust his hips towards her and her hand went under, brushed his scrotum hanging loose. She cradled his balls.

"Oh, Cole."

"You like those?"

“Your balls...are...they’re so huge.” They were. Bigger than Max’s, bigger than Jay’s even. They were hot and loose in his dangling hairy scrotum. She fondled them carefully and looked up into his eyes.

“You want to see what’s in them?”

“I do,” she whispered.

“I’ll show you. Take my cock out.”

MAX HAD SEEN Cole naked before. Showers at the gym, once when they roomed at a conference in Washington D.C. He averted his eyes. Could tell he was doing all right down there. Had heard from two girls that he was hung. Last night saw that he was indeed endowed. Now from Maggie’s own lips he was learning that his best friend had a big set of balls. It turned his stomach. Seeing Maggie with her hand in his fly and then remarking at how big they were had twisted him further, and he thought he’d been flexed to maximum density already. He sat on his knees right next to them, folding his arms up with his hands under his armpits because he didn’t know what else to do right now.

Maggie gripped Cole’s cock, admired it. Held it loose, her hand not enough to come right around his girth, his fat glans peeking at her from its tight sleeve. She pulled it back, let the foreskin peel behind the flared rim.

“Suck it, Maggie, get it wet,” he said.

She took him in her mouth again, sucked and twisted her hand on his shaft.

“Easy, easy,” he said, “not too much. Lots of spit.”

She slowed and he gently humped her open mouth. Maggie hummed around it, made lots of wet sounds. “That’s it,” he said, running his hands through her hair, then tying up her tie again, like they were about to head into church. She was naked except for his tie, sitting on her knees, sucking his cock, and he thought she was more beautiful than ever. The tightness loosened, a warmth spread over him. He could enjoy it. She certainly was.

“That’s it, more spit...we want it wet, don’t we?”

She nodded with his cock stretching her lips wide and her eyes squinting as it went in and out.

“Yeah, nice and wet...”

Max frowned, said, “Don’t you...shouldn’t you wear a condom?”

“With Maggie?”

“Yeah...”

“Not my Margaret. She’s as clean as they come. She’s my little virgin.”

Maggie moaned.

“I’m always protected, but not for her...she wants my bare cock...”

She nodded again, hummed an affirmation.

“You sure?” Max said, trying to get her eye.

She nodded again, stroking and sucking.

Cole said, “Max, it’s Maggie—I’m not fucking around, she’s my best friend...”

“Okay,” he said. Excited and frightened at the prospect.

Cole said, “Okay, Maggie, okay, that’s it, girl,” he held her cheeks in his hands and pulled her mouth slowly off him until it was free and bobbing in her face. It glistened with her spit, saliva filled his creases, spilled from the groove where his foreskin bunched up at the glans, a long wiggling rope of Maggie’s spit fell to her bed.

He unbuttoned his pants and slipped them down his thighs, said, “Nice and wet, Maggie. Now I can fuck you. You want this cock, don’t you?” he said, guiding her to lay back.

“I want that cock so bad.”

“Tell me. Tell me how bad you want it.”

“I want that cock so bad, Cole...”

“That’s it—say my name...”

“I’ve been aching for that cock all day, Cole... You got me so wet...”

“That’s it,” he said, getting between her legs.

“Max,” she said, her eyes still on Cole’s.

“What?”

“Don’t sit there with your clothes on, take them off.”

“We’re going to have a lot of fun tonight, Maggie,” Cole said with her on her back, him over her, still cradling her face. “I’m going to fuck you every way tonight, but I want to look in your eyes when I put it into you.”

“Oh,” she gasped, her wet eyes going wide, the two of them staring into each other. Cole put his hands out on either side of her, on all fours over her, while she spread her legs wide for him. He was in position.

His face hovered over hers, his cock thrust up between them. He was rock hard. So thick, a curve bending it back so the tip pointed upward now.

He bounced it, made it tap her belly, moving lower and lower between her legs while they still said nothing but stared into one another's eyes.

Max unzipped his pants and unbuttoned his shirt while he watched. He swallowed hard.

Maggie ran her hands up Cole's arms, Cole bounced the plump end of his cock til it touched her pussy. Maggie jolted, gasped.

"Mm," Cole said, "feel that pussy, mm, Maggie I've wanted this for so long."

She nodded, pulled her lower lip into her mouth.

He wiggled it into her. Just the head of it slipping inside her. She inhaled, her chest rose high and her nipples bunched and stretched.

"What a nice little pussy, Maggie. All this time, all the days we spent together, we could have been doing this..."

Her lips plopped out and she gasped, "Please just do it, God, you're killing me..."

"Maggie wants this big cock..."

"Fuck, Cole, please give me that big cock..."

He sunk himself some more.

"Oh that's it, that's it," she cried. "Yes..."

"Fuck, Maggie, you've got such a tight little pussy..."

"Oh Cole, ah," she gasped, her knees rising higher, up to the backs of his arms, opening her flower up for his penetration. "Oh, ah-I've wanted this for so long..."

With her knees up now, Max could see their sexes coming together. Saw Cole's thickness push her apart, swell her shining mound, slide itself inside her body. He got deeper and deeper and Max saw his balls touch down and settle against her pussy as he sunk himself almost the whole way. His balls *were* very big. Maggie cried out and then slapped a hand over her own mouth.

She sobbed into her own hand and her brow furrowed deep, a vein rose in her temple and disappeared into her hairline. A sweat broke out on her skin right before his eyes.

"Oh fuck," she gasped, the hand on her mouth turning to a fist and thumping down into the mattress. "Oh fuck, oh that dick..."

"Mm, fuck," Cole growled, "God, this pussy Margaret."

"Oh fuck, oh Max, his cock is so big, Maxy, oh he feels so fucking good," she hissed, her head twisting lightly in her pillow, her sweaty skin

blossoming red now, over her shoulders and across her cheeks. “Oh fuck, Max, oh, God...”

Max stood, eyes glued to his Maggie, let his pants fall and stepped out of them, threw off his T-shirt. His best friend sunk himself deeper, then pulled back, about halfway and Maggie mewled, hand coming up and she bit her knuckle this time. Cole plunged into her again

“Ah,” she cried, and as he drew out her eyes went wide like she’d been shocked. “Shit wait, wait...oh God...”

Max settled next to her again, close enough to touch her.

“Oh God, oh God, please, oh don’t move...”

“What is it?” Max asked.

She kicked her legs til they wrapped around Cole’s waist, her eyes were wide still, her mouth falling open. “Oh...oh...oh...” she gasped. Her legs kicked til she had his hips locked even tighter, her feet arching and wriggling, hooking over one another. Her hands formed claws and dug into Cole’s shoulders.

“Shit, Maggie,” Cole growled, “Get it, get it...”

“Ah, ah,” she inhaled and inhaled, now her eyes were on Cole’s like laser beams. He held still and she started to writhe on him. He gave her more cock to hold and her hungry little pussy swallowed him right up.

“Oh shit, oh my God,” she gasped, nails digging harder, eyes trembling, face going beet red, mouth twisting to a snarl like she was suffocating. Tendons rose on her neck, her little hips went in wild circles and then she hitched another squeaky gulp of air and she moaned like a tomcat, eyes going narrow but still intent on the man that had his cock inside her.

“That’s it, Maggie, that’s it, come on my cock, come for me, that’s my Margaret, God, you’re such an amazing girl...”

“Ah,” she exhaled, a stream of spit leaped from her mouth and went over her chin, and she didn’t care. Her face twisted more and she sunk her pussy deep onto Cole cock. “Oh, ohhh,” she breathed, her nails lessening the dents they’d dug into him, “Oh,” she breathed and huffed, her exhales carrying the soft voice of her crying on it. “Oh wow, oh,” she whispered, her chest lurching up and down. Her hands caressed Cole’s face, smoothed and brushed his jaw. Her eyes looked a lot like love.

“Oh Cole, oh...”

“That was a day long orgasm,” he said.

“You built that all day.”

“I thought we’d do more fucking first.”

She shook her head, a smile coming to her. “Oh Cole, oh my God...”

“Was it good?”

“You have no idea,” she said and she kissed his lips. He kissed her back, their sexes still joined, her legs still locked around him.

“Ew, oh, ah,” she moaned. “No, oh, take it out. Careful.” She thrust both her hands between them and smoothed them over her mound around where he entered her. He slowly eased himself out of her and she hissed, her hands already starting to smooth her flesh. “Ha,” she said, mouth wide and brows tented.

Cole laughed, “Maggie’s sensitive.”

“Mm,” she hummed, rubbing herself. “That was crazy.”

Cole admired her, his cock thrust between her knees, bobbing and wet from her.

“Oh Max,” she said. “Wow.”

His eyebrows were high, his eyes round, his expression was otherwise lifeless. He cleared his throat, said, “Was that good?”

Cole kissed down her thigh, low, over her hands. She moved them, watched him between her legs.

“Yeah,” she said, “it was huge.” She twirled a finger in a lock of Cole’s hanging blonde hair while he suckled a mouthful of flesh on her thigh, so low his chin grazed her sex.

Secret Society

SATURDAY, SEPTEMBER 30TH

HIS STUBBLE PRICKLED her sensitive labia and she squirmed from him. He'd just given her the biggest orgasm of her life. It had suffocated her, squeezed the air from her lungs, and when it split from her, finally burst from its threatening swell she blacked out. Her vision went from dim to black and she saw sparkles in her eyes. The sound of Richard Lester's cello playing the G10 Affettuoso became underwater and cotton. Cole had worked her into a frenzy, built her desire. Then she watched her best friend flick his hard fat cock until it fell into her folds and he sunk it inside her. The wrongness, the taboo, was off the charts. She loved taboo. The badder the better if it meant she would have another orgasm like that one.

Cole kissed his way back up to her knee and she shut her legs, said, "I need a minute...I need just a minute...Where's my Max?"

"I'm here," he said and he walked closer on his knees and got next to her, his hands planted on the bed. He looked beat up. She smiled for him. "Did you like that?" she said.

"Yeah," he nodded. "You're so sexy."

She sat up, got cross-legged, looked at her two best friends. Still couldn't believe they were here like this, but the more time she spent with them doing these things, being naked, the more natural it started to seem. She worried then what would happen when they went back to school. Would they stop?

Her hand went up Max's thigh. He'd stripped himself naked, his cock was hard, straight up from between his thighs. She wrapped her hand

around it.

“Get up for me, Max,” she said. Then, “You too,” to Cole. They both got to their knees and she held Max’s cock.

She looked up at them both, their eyes turned down on her, both faces lustful. One confident, one worried. She knew what she was going to do, worried about the doing. Did it any way. Took Cole’s cock up and stroked it. Two cocks, one in each hand, her grip stroking and twisting on them. Her familiar Max, the cock that was hers, that she’d entertained so many times over the last four years. In the other, her good friend’s cock. Thick, bulbous, the glans set with an angry deep eye right now. He hadn’t come yet and she had a good mind to draw it out for him too, make him beg for her to let him come. That in fact was a quite arousing thought.

She eased her mouth over it, let her lips glide over that tight porcelain feel of his cock head. He filled her mouth. She ran her tongue along the underside, swooped and tickled. Slurped off, licked her lips, looked to her Max. Then put her mouth over him. Stroked Cole with her wet and let Max’s cock sink deep into her mouth. Went deeper on Max, stuck her tongue out and wriggled it along his underside. Drew back and plunged again, heard him moan.

Then off, both her boys cocks gleaming from her spit. She jerked them lightly, drew them closer to her mouth. Max and Cole worked themselves nearer. Her legs opened and stuck straight out and they got their knees between her open legs. She smiled. She’d got them hip to hip. Max went back in her mouth, her other hand cradled and coddled Cole’s big hanging testicles. Examined their feel, imagined how she would draw them. The way they hung even when he was hard, their size and color, a dark brown with an underpainting of quinacridone.

Put Cole in her mouth, circled Max and twisted her grip tight around his end. Bobbed and used her tongue to stretch his foreskin. Back to Max. Each time she worked on getting their hips to rotate, angling her head to draw her two boys to face each other. When she had them close, she gripped them, hand slipping up and down, looking up at them, switching from Cole’s eyes to her Max’s. Worked them closer and closer. Her tongue darting out and swiping wet over their already glistening ends.

They touched, and she squeezed her tummy in, seeing their soft wet plump cock heads squash and flatten, slip across each other. Hottest thing she could imagine right now, seeing those sensitive and secret parts of the

two boys in the world who meant the most to each other. Knew that on their whole body there was nothing with more feeling, knew they would have jolts going up into their brains, that she was doing it, controlling them, making them be more bad than they had intended. Gripped them tight, worked their urethras against each other, winding in circles, over and over. Max's narrow head pointed into the hollow of Cole's bigger blunter one, mashed into it like it was going to get swallowed. A quiver trembled Cole's tight belly. She moved her mouth to breathe against them, heard Max's breaths come heavy. Ran her tongue over the seam where they connected. Ran it under their heads, tickled at the underside, wiggled it on their frenulums, Max's tightly bowed.

ONE WEEK AGO TODAY, Max could not have predicted that this is where he and Maggie would find themselves. Couldn't have predicted that Cole would be involved. Maggie held both of them. Max was as hard as possible. So hard he ached. Cole was hard too. His cock in Maggie's hand, swollen and flush and wriggled with veins. Maggie slipped their tips over one another. The tip of his cock was pressed into Cole's and he wanted to recoil. But Maggie's hand held him firmly, ran their slippery tips together and it felt so incredible. Cole didn't pull away. He let it happen.

He watched what his cock looked like next to his best buddy's. Cole's head much bigger and fuller. His shaft thicker, barely curving Maggie's petite fingers. Forced himself to accept it. Pushed it down. They were friends. It had been inside his future wife. It would be again. This was for Maggie now. Once it was for him, now it was for her. He'd have to open his arms and make this work.

Cole put his hand over the top of her head, held his cock, eased it into her mouth, Maggie was eager, wriggled her face to accommodate it. She pulled him closer to her, his tip grazing Cole's shaft where it entered her mouth. She guided him and Cole eased out.

Then he watched his shy little girl try to get two cocks in her mouth at the same time. His eyebrows came up higher. Maggie full of dirty surprises. Worried where her limits were. She took Cole's tip, tried to get Max in, then broke out laughing, spitting on their cocks and then covering her mouth, embarrassed. "Nope," she said, wiping at her mouth. "Too much."

“Mm,” she said, then sighing, “Look at you two.” She gripped them tight, stroked them hard and slow, brought them close and moved them so they touched, worked their undersides together, belly to belly. Cole’s wider and longer, and Maggie using both hands to stroke them together.

She said, “I’m ready again.”

Cole cupped her head, ran his thumb over her eyebrow, traced its line, said, “That’s our little Maggie. That’s our little girl.”

“What do you want us to do?” Max asked.

“Mm,” she said, hands still stroking them. They’d eased away from each other and she had one apiece now. “I told you.”

“Told me?” Max said.

“I want an exorcism.”

“That doesn’t sound good, Maggie,” Cole said.

“Really? ...” Max said, starting to feel a worry.

She nodded, her eyes steady on his.

Cole asked, “What’d she tell you?”

“She wants to...downstairs.”

“The beach?”

“No...”

Maggie looked to Cole and said, “My music room.”

Cole regarded her, his eyes narrowed, trying to comprehend her. So familiar with her, tuning in to her, getting her. Maybe more than Max. More accepting. While he’d allowed her this freedom to explore it had been initially very selfish. He saw in Cole an openness. A friendliness and support. It hurt to see a better connection between him and Maggie. But fuck, Cole wasn’t engaged to her. He was just her friend. He had no stake. He was, of course, the fun guy. The one who had no rules. Max chewed the inside of his lip.

“Yeah,” Cole said. “An exorcism...”

He took the tie in his hand, and he gently pulled it to raise her up to kneel between them. “I want that,” he said next to her ear.

Max disagreed but he said, “Yeah, we can do that.” Just saying it made his temples throb. He could envision being caught. Could see the chaos if they were discovered. The shame for his Maggie. Their future with her family forever altered. His stomach knotted.

MAX'S HAND smoothed across her belly and up high under her breast. She looked in his eyes. He was scared and that was good. Cole wasn't, his hand on her neck, his mouth close, wanting to kiss, his cock touching her belly, hot wet, slipping easily across her skin as they both breathed.

"I want you both to fuck me down where I used to play."

"You've got me so hard, Maggie," Max whispered.

She felt him, stroked him, gazed in his eyes while she did, built his courage. He kissed her, his other hand coming up under her other breast and he tried to sit her down. She went with it, but she knew her Max, knew what he was doing.

"Maxy, Maxy," she said around his kisses. He had her sitting, and she held his arms for balance. "Take me downstairs."

"Let's do it here," he whispered.

She spun on her butt and got her legs out to the side of the bed, put her feet on the floor. Got up, naked, crossed to her turntable and raised the needle. The room was quiet. She turned, saw both their eyes on her, felt very vulnerable and naked. Weird, because she was intimate with both of them, but being seen at a distance like this made her feel self-conscious. She fought the urge to cover her nipples.

"I want to go downstairs."

Cole smiled. He got off the bed and joined her and she felt her own happy face spreading.

"Yeah?" she said.

He held a hand out to her and she took it. "Max?" she said.

"Maggie..." Max worked his head around, trying to frame his argument. She knew what it was. Knew he was right. But she wanted this bad. Compulsively. This was what *needed* to be done.

"Max." She repeated.

His face had no humor. His brow was worried but he moved to get his pants.

She said, "No, Max. Naked."

"Yes," Cole laughed, excited by the danger.

"Naked?" Max said.

"Come on, Cole," she said, going to the boy who was supporting her right now. She went to his arms and he took her, wrapped them around her. He felt good pressed to her, bare skin to bare skin.

She posed with him for Max. Pressed her cheek to his strong chest, let his cock appear at her side, touching her along her ribs. She writhed her body against it. "Come with us, Max."

"Maggie, it's too crazy..."

"No, it's not, Max."

Cole said, "Let's go, Maggie. Max'll follow."

Max put a foot through the leg of his pants and she said, "Max, if you put your clothes on don't even bother coming down."

MARTIN AND CAROL would freak the fuck out. Without a doubt. What would Martin do? Would Martin get physical? He could see it. See it play out in his mind. Imagined himself finding his own future-daughter fucking two guys in his house while he slept. Laughing at him. So disrespectful. He would be furious.

"Guys..." he said.

Maggie kissed Cole on the lips, up on her tip-toes to do it.

"Come on," she whispered then, and they both laughed. Hopped across the room, her tight little body giving a shake when her feet touched down. Cole's erection wagging. They ran to the door and bold Cole opened it and looked around the hall. Stuck his head out, looked left and right.

Came back in and said, "Coast is clear." He took her hand, said to Max, "Come on, Max. This is fucking exciting." He guided Maggie past him, said to her, "Ladies first," and she stepped nervously into the hall, covering her breasts and putting a hand over her crotch. She looked up and down the hall.

Cole looked back to him, deviously closing the door, said, "How much would you give me to lock her out right now?"

"Don't," Max said, his worried face pinching down. More worried.

"I'm kidding, buddy. Come with us..."

Then Maggie reached in, one thin arm coming through the doorway and her hand holding Cole's cock. She pulled him out to the hall by his manhood. They were both giggling.

"Guys, wait..." he said. He pulled his pants up and made his way to the door quickly. He peeked around the edge of the door.

They were being quiet but he could still hear them. Watched their two gray-blue bodies trot on the hardwood floor in bare feet. Maggie's tight little butt working next to Cole's. Cole slapped her ass with an open hand and she yelped, grabbed both her cheeks, and as they disappeared down the hall into the darkness he caught one last glimpse of his fiancée as she glanced over her shoulder at Cole. Her face was happy, eyes bright, biting her lower lip like she always did. Having fun without him.

He groaned. The pain was so deep and so profound. Her moving away from him so symbolic. Laughing and carefree with another man. Another man could make her happy. She didn't need her Max. He rubbed the heels of his hands over his eyes until he saw blobs of light. "Fuck," he whispered to himself. Why did he ever hide in that closet? Maybe she would have cheated on him. Maybe she wouldn't. Maybe she would have just done it once and had so much remorse she never would have strayed again. Maybe he never would have even known about it.

"Fuck," he hissed, thumped his forehead with a balled fist.

God, his cock was hard and upright, his belly ached with sexual tension. The thought of them down there having fun without him was killing him. He could picture her face like he'd last seen it, down there with Cole enjoying his body, appreciating his sexuality. Cole was appreciating hers. Delivering boldly the thing she had point blank asked him yesterday afternoon with his finger up her pussy. An exorcism. She needed it. Her fiancé was the one to give it. Not Cole. He could be there, but Maggie...was *his* Maggie. She fucking superseded his fear of her parents.

Or, should he help her see the light...was she sick? ...Did she need help? His guidance would be a benefit here, help her see that this was so wrong, so dangerous, not worth the risk.

Fuck, maybe if he knew Maggie he would see it was worth the risk.

"Maggie, Maggie, Maggie," he moaned and whined. Undid his zipper, slipped his pants off. Kicked them farther into her room. He covered his throbbing hardness with both hands, stood naked in the archway of her door, looking up and down the dark hall. He stepped both feet into the hall. This was it. God, shit. If he got caught...

He slipped down the passageway, his bare feet making wet sounds that echoed lightly off the concrete, steel, and glass, the big high ceilings having a lot of fun bouncing it around out of his reach. He stepped more lightly, feeling bolder, feeling excited, feeling like he would make Maggie happy

when he showed up for her naked. He stuck to the wall, though if the lights came on there would be nowhere to hide he still felt safer. His scrotum grazed his hand, balls completely gone, so frightened by what he was doing they checked out. Didn't want to be a part of this at all. His cock, on the other hand, was completely on board. Throbbing and pulsing in his hand as he trotted along. Jesus, this was fucking insane, but as long as he pictured Maggie's face when he showed up he could get through this.

Passing the closed guest room door, where he and Cole should be if they were sane, he got a great idea.

MAGGIE DIDN'T THINK she could go through with it. Not without her Max. She needed him.

She said to Cole, "Is he going to come? ...Do you think? ..."

"Don't worry, Maggie," he answered. "I'll give you what you need."

They stood in the center of the private music hall her father had the architects design for their house. It was built while they were still in Holland. Wanted to make sure that his son and daughter were supported in the pursuit of music with which her mother obsessed.

Cole kissed her. Took her face in both his hands and turned up her face. She kissed him back. Took his thick cock in two hands and stroked it for him while they made out. Cole was a good kisser. Passionate and seductive. He'd just about killed her today with all his dirty mind games. She wanted to go again. Wanted to do it right here on this cold floor. But wanted Max to be there with her.

She sighed as Cole's hands slipped down her back, and over her waist. He smoothed them over her and she hoped he liked what he felt. Danced with him, swayed her body against his, kissing and stroking. He cupped her ass, pulled her against him and she put her hands up to his neck now.

Moaned as his finger stroked her pussy from behind, his thumb pressing up between her cheeks and against her anus. Then he lifted her. Fast and swift, and she jerked her legs up for support. Her knees shot up to his waist and her feet instinctively locked behind him so she wouldn't slip down.

"That's my Maggie," he said, looking in her eyes. His finger stroked at her, dipping deeper into her creases.

"What about Max?" she said.

“His fault for not coming. He’s going to miss out.”

“I want him to be here.”

Cole just smiled. She realized, with his eyes narrowed on hers, that he was capable of meanness.

She felt it then. The plump glans of his cock penetrating her while she was spread.

“Oh shit,” she gasped. “Oh Cole...”

“You like that?”

“Oh shit, yeah,” she said. “Okay...”

He stood with her wrapped on him, sunk his cock inside her, her body weight settling it deeply. He was big. She really felt it like this. Thicker than Jay though Jay had never taken her in a position like this.

“Oh Cole, your cock feels so fucking good.”

“Fuck, Maggie, you dirty talker, God, I never knew you were like this.”

“I didn’t either,” she laughed.

“Oh fuck, you feel so good on my cock. I’m going to fuck you every day.”

“You are?” she squeaked, a giggle coming with it.

“Fuck, yes. I want to be in this pussy every fucking day.”

“Just until my wedding,” she said. “Ah, mm, that’s it...”

He eased deep and started stroking. Spread her and gave a full feeling in her. A high pain once, then it settled, and she could just enjoy the feeling of him opening her wide.

“You like it like this?”

“Mm-hmm.” She nodded her head.

There was a sound in the hall. It came from the stairs. She squeezed Cole with her arms and her pussy. “Wait, wait, wait,” she hissed. Never thinking she would actually be caught, now hearing a noise, she was panicking.

She hugged him. They stood still.

Someone was there. Something moved in the dark. It grew closer and she could see its pale form, arms and legs.

“Max?” she whispered in Cole’s ear, hoping and praying it was him. She couldn’t see his head, just the ghostly white movement of limbs.

“What the fuck?” Cole whispered.

She bristled, unsure what was coming. Then she laughed. Cole shook under her too as he figured it out.

A naked man stood in the concrete arch at the hall, one step higher than the music room. Naked, erect, iPhone in one hand. Over his head he had the blazing black-eyed raven, one hand shakily holding it in place.

Acoustics

SATURDAY, SEPTEMBER 30TH

HE SAW THEM. Engaged without him. Fucking without him. She didn't need him. There was tons of guys who'd fuck her, make love to her, make her laugh, be good to her. Make her hot and sweaty. She didn't need him.

Cole was fucking her. Maggie clinging to him while he stood, and Max could see that his cock was upright, inserted into her spread sex. Fucking her standing up. Maggie eagerly fucking his friend without a care for him.

But no, he wasn't going to allow that badness in. She was fucking him because he wasn't giving her what she needed. She needed boldness and Cole was bold. He would commit.

He was proud of himself. Thinking to get his phone, get the raven head. He could be fun, bold. He could be the one who was her anchor in this thing he'd put out to deeper water. The raven was hoisted up over his head, he made his way to the entrance to the music room. The head had two small holes in it, partially obscured by its own feathers, and the light was already dim. He made his way towards where he'd last seen them, worried he would tumble off the step and fall naked on the floor at their feet while his girlfriend was fucking a guy with a bigger cock. Found the step, made it safely down, heard snickering now. It was hot and smelly in the head and he whipped it off to their light and quiet applause.

"Hey, you came, buddy," Cole said.

"Oh Maxy," Maggie whispered. She was on her feet now, their union disconnected by his fortunate arrival. Maggie came to him with a joyous

face, dim, but so expressive he could read it. His heart soared. He'd done the right thing. This was a victory.

"Hey, Secret Society," Cole said and he took the raven head from under Max's arm and he walked it to the baby grand piano, a black silhouette in the dark room, its top surfaces lit up with a hazy polished gleam.

Maggie was between them but she walked away. Left both of them and wandered into the cold interior of the cavernous concrete space. It was dark, and the further she got the harder it was to make her out. Max followed her, got a chill thinking about losing her. Went to her, followed behind, said, "If you want an exorcism, I'll give you one."

"Thanks," she said, softly, soberly. Her head lolled on her neck, her eyes in contemplation as they looked at every high corner of the ceiling.

She lowered her eyes to him and said, "That's what I want, Max."

"Come here," he said, and he held both hands out. She stepped close to him and she took them. Held both his hands with hers. Cole was next to them coming out of the dark.

"We'll do it for you," he said.

"I'm in," Maggie said with a light laugh.

Max brought her close to kiss and she stood under him and they put their mouths on one another. Cole pressed his naked body to her back and Max was aware of his hands moving, feeling her ass, coming around and going up over her breasts and working his fingers across her hard swollen nipples, his knuckles grazing Max's chest.

Then Cole said, "Max, come on," and he was pulling Maggie from him, leading her to the chair that he had sat and watched her play her cello last night and her magic had brought tears to his eyes.

Maggie put a knee up like she would get on it and one of them could fuck her from behind but Cole pulled her back, said, "Let Max sit there, you stay with me."

"What?" Max asked.

"Sit on the chair," Maggie said.

"Okay," he said, and lowered his bare ass onto the old French chair.

Max could see Cole loom over her shoulder, talking into her ear with a hand over each of her shoulders. He said, "I want you to suck his cock for me. You do that?"

"Yeah," she laughed.

“Suck it for me,” he said, and he helped her down to her knees between his legs. The weirdness and excitement had him as hard as he could be. His cock stuck straight up. Maggie touched it and he bubbled and streamed precum.

“Whhoo,” he exhaled.

“Drink that up for me,” Cole said into her hair as he got to his knees behind her.

Max felt a twinge, his friend seeing his semen come out, about to watch him and Maggie do their intimate thing. Wrong, but something about it drove him. Wanted to do it, wanted Cole to see, wanted things to get worse. Maybe not wanted, but he had a writhing curiosity. Something in him wanted to see how bad Maggie could be.

Maggie took him deep, sucked hard, squeezed his balls and the base of his shaft and he felt himself pulse more into her waiting hungry mouth. She drank it. He closed his eyes, almost shut, but he struggled to keep them wide, not wanting to miss a moment of this. She hummed a nice sound around his cock and he could tell Cole was doing something to her from behind. She bobbed on him, her breaths growing heavy and urgent while she gave him pleasure and Cole touched her sex, or stroked his cock against her.

Her face came away from him, her eyes unfocused, pointed towards him but Max could tell she had every iota of attention focusing on what Cole was doing. Her mouth went wide, a happy turn to the corners, her brows came up high as they would go, and she chuckled, the light laugh forming the word *Ow* at the end. She bit her lower lip and her eyes went to Max’s, she said, “He’s really big, Max.”

“You don’t have to,” he said.

Her expression changed from surprised curiosity to a fallen pained frown. “Oh, ooh, wait,” she said. Max watched her lips purse as she brought her cupped hand to her chin and she drooled spit into it, her tongue darting out as she spit and filled her wrinkled little bowl. She took her hand, wriggled her fingers as she reached behind her, throwing a look at Cole and giggling. She stroked his shaft with her saliva. Back to Max then, her elbows together between his legs, eyes unfocused again, mouth agape and breathless as Cole resumed his wide intrusion.

“Does it hurt?” he asked her.

“Yeah,” she gasped, “let him, though, let him, ah...”

Cole's hips worked, one side at a time, easing his size into her anus.

"Yeah," she encouraged him.

His penetration was producing crackling noises, wet painful sounds. There was a belch of air. No one said a thing.

"Mm, Maggie," Cole began to hum as he got halfway into her. "Fuck, that is so tight..."

"You're so thick," she sighed.

His hands went up her back, and he rubbed her muscles, his fingers digging and massaging. He said, "Relax on it, I don't want to hurt you, just accept it. Sit like this a minute, feel it..."

"Mm-hmm," she squeaked and nodded.

"Put your mouth on Max," he told her.

She did what he told her. Her tongue rolling up Max's underside, right to his tip, then swallowing him.

Cole gripped her shoulders, found his tie where it was looped around her neck, wound it around and undid the knot. Bundled the tie and let it sit at the small of her waist in a twisted ball. His hands were over her shoulders again, smoothing her upper arms. He led one behind her, then the other. It drove Max's cock deep into her mouth without her hands out to support herself.

Cole lay one of her fine wrists over the other and his fiancée didn't protest. She rolled her mouth on his cock stuck in her mouth, one cheek rounded out. The tie was rolled out and Cole worked it under her stacked wrists twice, Maggie only grunting, he believed, because his movements were jostling his cock imbedded in her rear. Max watched the tie weave around now in a complicated way that reminded him of nautical hitches. Like Cole had tied girls up before. Seemed to remember him telling him that one time, maybe back in their first year. Cole could pretend to be as preppy as he wanted to be, growing up near the water in Connecticut, but his father was a personal injury lawyer and Cole had never been sailing in his life. With a careful and deliberate tug he secured her wrists together in an artful bow, pulling snugly the two loose ends of his tie.

He lay himself over her narrow back and he purred, "Fuck, I could be in this ass all night."

"Mm," she squeaked around Max's cock. Her brow grew a crease in the center.

"It hurts, doesn't it?" he asked her.

She nodded, her mouth slipped off him and she lay her face on his thigh. "Ow," she said quietly.

"It hurts," he said to Cole.

"Want me to stop?" he said to her.

She nodded. Said, "You're too big. I want Max."

"Mm, Maggie," Cole smiled and backed himself out of her, the withdrawing making all sorts of slick protestations.

She sighed when he was out.

COLE WAS TOO wide to be comfortable. It just didn't feel sexy. It was hard to concentrate on Max's pleasure when all she could think was how one wrong move back there and she would be hurt. It was a relief when he was out.

Max pulled her up to him, her thighs and tummy flexing sharply so she would not fall with her hands tied behind her back.

"Come here, Maggie," he whispered and she flopped her chest on to his, her forehead bouncing onto his chin where her lips were aiming. "Ow," she laughed.

"You tied too tight?"

"No, I like it."

"I love you," he said and his arms went around her.

"I love you too, Max. You know that."

"I know."

"Help me up," she laughed.

"What do you want?"

"Someone needs to fuck me soon. In the front. I'm going to scream, I don't want any more teasing."

She felt him laugh.

"What?" she said as he eased her to stand.

"I've never heard you talk like that."

"Sorry," she said as she turned her back to him.

"No, I like it," he said and he got her to sit in his lap. Both facing out now they noticed Cole was gone.

"Where's Cole?" she said over her shoulder.

"I don't know," he said to her.

She felt his hand moving, gripping his cock, then his tip poking her anus. It felt stretched, different, opened. She turned her nose up at the thought of what that might look like. "Is it...open?" she asked him.

"Kind of," he said as he eased himself into her. "Is that okay?"

"Yeah," she said. Then hissed to the empty room, "Cole?"

Heard him somewhere in the dark. His feet on concrete. Then the sound of her cello being handled. She bristled. Worried about the potential noise and worried about her good wooden friend.

She heard the strings being plucked.

"What are you doing?" she whispered.

Cole came into view holding her cello like it was a guitar.

She stifled a laugh, but seeing him like that also made her nervous. There was a chance for real damage and she didn't like it.

He plucked the strings again, strummed quietly. He said, "You want an exorcism? Want me to smash your cello?"

"Shit, no," she gasped.

"Take it down to the beach and set on fire?"

"Cole, no," she said, her heart hammering.

He raised it up over his head like he would slam it and she yelped. He held it poised, his cock hard and wagging, throwing a shadow across his thigh.

"Say the word, Margaret," he said.

"Put it down," she hissed. Max's cock poked at her insides.

"You want to banish your demons? ..."

"The room, Cole. That cello is my friend."

"I'd get you a new one with no bad memories..."

"I love my cello," she said. "And it was fifty grand."

She heard him whisper *Jesus Christ* as he carried it back into the dark.

"You okay?" Max said at her shoulder.

"I'm fine, Max. Stop fawning..."

"I just ...I'm here for you..."

"I already know," she said.

HE BIT HIS TONGUE. Thought to say she was grumpy when she didn't get cock, try and make her laugh, but he was not convinced she would laugh

right now. So he committed himself to this anew.

She gazed into the dark waiting for Cole to return and he eased himself in and out of her anus. Let his hand come around her hips and swoop in the slippery V around her eager sex. Her hands pressed into his belly, still tied, leaving her vulnerable. His hands came up and squeezed her breasts. Her nipples were tight buds, propelled from her body with her fervid excitement. He had her moaning. He wasn't going to talk. He'd say the wrong thing. She wanted something tonight and it wasn't his good natured camaraderie.

Cole emerged from the shadows and made his way to her. Her breaths doubled when she saw him coming. He stood with the raven head under his arm, his hand draped over it, pressing it to his hip. He regarded the two of them for a moment, then set the head on the floor. He dipped down and sucked on her breasts, quickly got her gasping, then he was up, his face close to Maggie's, close to Max's. He said, "Is he inside you?"

"Yeah," she said, and Max felt her hands wriggling against him like they wanted to be free to hold Cole.

"He feel better?"

"Yeah," she said.

"You want it in your pussy again, don't you?"

"I do," she said. Max could feel her shoulder blades press him when she inhaled.

Cole raised higher, stroked his cock where she could see it, said, "You want this big cock, don't you?"

"I do, please, Cole, just give it to me..."

"Told you I'd have you begging for it."

"Please..."

"Beg me for it."

"Fuck me, Cole."

"With what?"

"With that big cock."

"One more time, Margaret," he said, stroking himself, a white shining light on the round wet tip of his cock.

"Please, Cole, I need you to fuck me with your big thick cock..."

"There she is," he whispered, and he slipped his arms along her sides, his forearms grazing Max's hips.

The outside of Cole's thighs dragged the inside of Max's thighs as he got himself in between their legs, close to Maggie's sex. One of Cole's hands came back, went down between them all and he felt him touching Maggie's anus. His hand moved over her squashed cheeks where she sat against Max, then Cole's hand fondled his balls and they instantly retreated.

"Mm," Maggie grunted, in angry hunger, and Cole kissed her, his hand still exploring her anus and when he touched her pussy she gasped and trembled, her body racked with tension against him. She hummed around Cole's kiss, made wet sounds, struggled to breathe, gasped for air, so aroused her body was needing volumes more oxygen to handle her high heart rate.

"Please," she whispered up to the ceiling.

Cole pushed his fat cock head into her and she said, "Ah, mm, yesss..."

Max felt him sliding over the underside of his own cock as he slid it into Maggie. His poor innocent fiancée now stretched so wide, two cocks inside her. She was so dirty. He had no idea she would ever entertain something so base, so libertine. His hands went up and down her, felt the ribs press out against her skin, felt her hard nipples. Went low until his hands were pressed by Cole's hips against her. He felt the desire of the love of his life, and he felt the aroused hardness of his best friend. So wrong, so amazing. He worked against Cole's cock, made Maggie cry happy sounds. They fucked her gently, both of them plunging her tight holes, enjoying her wet and her heat, enjoying each other's hardness. It felt incredible and loving, and his whole body tingled. Sparks went off in his heart, he felt love—he felt like that one time they did molly at Dreamscape in first year when the three of them went to Maryland for the festival and cuddled in the grass outside their tent and giggled. But this was times ten. This was for real.

Cole kissed at her neck while Max fondled her breasts. Cole whispered, "You going to come for me again, Maggie?"

"Mm-hhmmm." Max could feel her nod her head with enthusiasm.

"You already come for me like a good girl, didn't you?"

"I did," she gasped.

"You want to come again?"

"Please..."

"Cole's going to get really good at making his Maggie come..."

“Ah,” she cried out, a high injured sound like she hated to hear it but was so excited about the words.

“Cole’s going to learn all Maggie’s secrets, unlock all her doors, make her come like she never had it before...”

“Holy, ah, oh...” she coughed with each exhale and she wiggled against them, her hips seeking specific movements, wanting them deeper or harder.

“You want that?”

“I do,” she cried again, her voice carrying around the high ceiling.

“Shh-shh,” he reminded her.

“Oh God, oh God, I’m going to fucking come,” she cried.

He shushed her again.

Cole said, “You going to come with your two best friends’ cocks inside you? How do we feel ? ...”

“Yeah...”

“We feel good?”

“So good,” she said.

“You like having two cocks? ...You like two men fucking you?”

“Yeah...ah...”

“You fucking dirty slut...”

“Yeah...”

“You going to drink our come?”

“Mm...ah...”

“Want me to come in your mouth again? You like my come?”

“I do, oh...”

Her legs went around Cole. They’d been draped over Max’s thighs, but now she was hooking them around, digging her heels into his rump and spurring their friend to fuck her harder and faster. Cole picked up his pace, thrusting into her harder and harder. The chair began to squeak on the floor and the room was filled with the noise.

“Shhh-shh, guys,” he hissed.

They were relentless and he was being taken along for the ride. He started gasping, his own breaths, unmonitored, had come baying at him and now he chugged behind Maggie as out of control as she was, feeling like he was being fucked by Cole too. Each thrust of his fat cock was pulling Maggie’s membranes tight against him, running Cole’s thick cabled underside along his own, his longer cock slipping up and tickling Max’s buried frenulum. Cole was going to make them both come.

“Oh fuck, Cole, oh mm man, Cole,” he cried.

Maggie joined him, “Cole, oh shit, I'm going to come, yeah, oh, touch my....my clit, please...”

There was shifting and Max jostled behind her, his scalp tingling, feeling like it was rising up off his head. Maggie cried out sharp, Cole had found her clit and his shoulder muscles were jumping as he shook it like crazy while he kept fucking her.

“Oh God, oh shit, oh Cole,” Maggie cried.

But Max came first. Came with the feeling of his friend stroking him, shot hot wet jets into Maggie's tight anus and he cried out on his own, jumped and struggled under her, the pleasure too much, the difficulty of restraint and keeping all the bounteous noise trapped inside him too much. And as he wrestled for his own control underneath her, his cock poking and stroking while he did, Maggie came next. Her knees shot up to Cole's armpits, and her hands tensed to tight balled fists of steel against his stomach as she strained against Cole's tie.

“Fuck ah, fuck,” she cried, way too loud. Her head tossed left and right, she bumped Max on the nose and he saw stars, felt it swell up and go tight and he wriggled it, tried to chase the discomfort away. “Oh fuck, oh fuck,” she moaned, and Cole kept stroking into her.

He was laughing, “You two, look at you...”

Maggie sighed and chortled, she was sweaty now. It had come up all at once, dry one moment now he felt her dripping on him, felt her skin against his go slippery.

“Fuck, where's that phone?” he said, his hand feeling around at Max's back. “Where'd you put it?” he said to Max over her shoulder.

“It's there some—”

“Got it,” he said.

“I want this for posterity,” he said.

“No,” Maggie said, “Cole...”

“Cover your face, Maggie. Don't you want to see what my cock looks like inside you?”

“Yeah,” she sighed. “Yeah.”

“Tell me,” he said, and Max had a vague awareness of him moving off of her, leaning over the side of the chair.

“Show me what your cock looks like inside me, Cole,” she moaned. She breathed heavily against Max's chest.

“Here,” he said, and Max felt something bumping the side of his head and onto his shoulder. Cole was slipping the raven over Maggie's head. He could hear her breathy exhausted laugh, draggy and enervated from inside the costume head. Cole got between her legs and fixed his cock deep again. Maggie moaned, sounded like she wanted more.

The flash went off and the room went bright, a tense white, and he jolted.

In that tiny fraction of a second he'd seen a man in the hall. Watching them. He tensed to steel. He couldn't breathe.

Cole laughed. “Look at your perfect little pussy, Maggie. God, you look good on my cock.”

She said, “You feel so fucking good right now.”

Max looked over Maggie's shoulder at the blackness that was now tenfold black after the assault of white on his rods and cones. He blinked. Frozen with fear, blinked again. Could imagine being bludgeoned now out of the blue, a sudden rampage as Martin beat him and Cole to death with a fireplace poker. He was panicking. His throat frozen, his voice lost, pinched and squeezed in the coffin of his chest. He opened his mouth and there was a creak. But no more.

The flash went off again, Maggie and Cole giggled. Maggie sighed.

White. Black. In an instant. And now, painted in phosphorous on the inside of his eyelids was the plaintive slump-shouldered image of Ken. Standing and witnessing two men fuck his sister.

“Oh shit,” he whispered.

“Show me how much you like it,” Cole said to Maggie.

Maggie laughed again. She flashed double peace signs behind her back though the camera couldn't see. The flash went off. Now there was no one in the hall.

“OKAY, come on. Just fuck me...” she said. She could barely see out of the eye holes in the dumb costume. And it smelled as well. Smelled of its significant age, and smelled of men. Pictured some sleazy carny—toothless carnies suddenly, somehow surmising that it was doubtful that this was worn at some elegant costume ball by sophisticated yet devious elites.

“Get this off me,” she said, wiggling her head and struggling with her arms. Max pulled it from her. She saw Cole, the iPhone gone now, his cock still inside her, moving only with the effort of the helmet’s removal.

“Come for me, Cole,” she said, blew a strand of hair from her face. “I want you to finish.”

“You get your exorcism?” he smirked.

“I did. Don’t you think I did?”

He said, “You taught this room you can’t be contained.”

She inhaled deep. “I did,” she agreed. “Now fuck me.”

“Where you want me to come?”

“Inside me,” she told him. “I want to feel you come inside me.”

Now Cole inhaled, he moaned, “Fuck, Maggie,” and he got his arms planted on either side of her, pressed her into Max and slid his cock deep inside her. It swelled her heart and made her fingers tingle. He fucked her. Slow at first, building up. She could feel him get larger inside her, get harder. His cock swelled to tremendous proportion and he felt amazing. His cock felt incredible inside her. She was ashamed to admit it, but she liked big cocks. A big cock felt better. It felt full and tight and it seemed to come with a confidence behind it. She liked that confidence in bed. Liked that assuredness, that tinge of domination. Cole had that, but she also felt so wonderfully safe with him. He was her friend. Her good friend, and he made her laugh, and he could be so playful too. She whispered, “Hurry, Cole, I can’t wait to feel you come inside my pussy...”

She made him groan and she wished she could hug him, run her hands over his muscular back, run her nails over his skin when he finally came inside her.

He fucked hard now, getting himself close. He drew a pleasure out of her again and she felt like if she allowed it she could bring herself another orgasm but she wanted out of here. She’d done what she’d fantasized, done it grander than she’d ever imagined. Didn’t just have sex with her boyfriend in this cold concrete prison, she had dirty mind-blowing sex with her two best friends. The two men who meant the most to her in her life. She started gasping and couldn’t stop herself. Panting and sweating. Feeling Cole’s heat against her, feeling his slick sweat, his hard swelled neck, his semen was leaking and they were more slippery than ever. She guided her orgasm away, wanted to be done. They’d pushed their luck as it was, and with that

orgasm under her belt this was more frightening than erotic. “Come for me, Cole, give me that big, big load, baby, put it deep inside me...”

That was what he needed, and she felt him go like iron and she winced as he drove himself deep and emptied his balls in her. Felt him jet his hot liquid against her cervix, felt a rising nausea from having it touched. But it was so, so sexy to feel him come. To feel him put that heat so deep, to hear his animal noises, and to know *she* had done it. She could please her handsome friend.

“Ah fuck, Cole, I feel it, I feel it so deep,” she cried, for Max’s benefit. Felt Max now swelling inside her. When she had the head on she felt him dwindle and almost get spit out. Now he’d returned to hard. Wished they were at Farmingham, wished they could do this all night but the reality was they’d have to go to their separate rooms after this and go to bed.

Cole pulled out, grunting and roaring, his cock hot against her belly. She looked down to see its slippery shape thrust across her mound, pearly seed still spurting in weak bursts.

“Oh fuck, ah, oh fuck, Maggie,” he groaned. She liked to hear him come. Liked to watch him come. Wished she could hold him. She writhed, bucked her hips so her pussy would stroke the underside of his surging cock.

At last she laughed out an *Oh fuck* and she let her head fall back against Max. She turned her cheek to him, held it to be kissed, waited, and finally he did. She hoped he wasn’t being mopey again.

Cole still loomed, using his hips to run his wet cock between her legs and over her belly. He moaned, “Oh fuck, that was so fucking crazy.”

Maggie agreed, then said, “We have to get out of here...” Leaned forward and scratched at Max’s belly with her fingernails and said, “Untie me, Maxy.”

Cole took her lips with his own and Max untied her. When she was free she carefully brought her hands to her front, worked out the kinks in her shoulders while kissing Cole. Worked her hand in circles and rubbed at her wrists. Then touched Cole. Felt his body, felt his hot skin, down and held his cock and cradled his heavy testicles. Broke her kiss and said, “Seriously, we have to go to bed.”

“I want to fuck you all night.”

“Me too. In Vermont.”

“Mm,” he smiled, kissed her, said, “Can’t wait.” Stood then, with a proud but devious smile, and held a hand, helped her to stand. He caressed her shoulders. She turned, saw Max still slumped in the chair, legs open, penis deflated, his eyes were averted, looking towards the hall. He was sullen.

“What’s wrong now, Max?” she said.

“Nothing,” he said. “We should go to bed.”

Kill Switch

SUNDAY, OCTOBER 1ST

MAX AWOKED to the sight of Cole asleep in the bed across from him again. It was early, just the moment after dawn where the grayness was burned from the morning sky and color had been pumped into it. A brilliant azure sky rose from the sleeping crests of Cole's mountainous horizon. He was hard again. Morning wood. Laying on his back like a proud conquering male. Satisfied and satiated, well-fed and capable. His thick cock had pushed up his shorts and the bulbous head stretched a tight threadbare knot in the cotton, protruding over his waistband. When he'd come inside Maggie last night it had seeped from her. Plopped in cold spatters onto Max's scrotum and slithered over his balls and down the crack of his ass.

That was something to think about. Cole had pumped his semen into Maggie's willing pussy. More than willing. Eager, more precisely. Thankfully, Ken hadn't seen that display. But what had Ken seen? How much had he witnessed?

He'd have to tell Maggie, but he just couldn't. She'd be devastated. He didn't want her to have that shame. No, he would hold onto this bit of juicy truth. This would be his kill switch. As long as Ken himself never mentioned it he would keep this in his back pocket and draw it like a weapon when he lost further control. He would use it to restore order. Bring his little slut back to reality. Last night had been a horrible heart and soul crushing battle. But it had something glimmering in all that darkness. There had been moments where his heart had soared. There was a moment when all three of them had felt like one, and that was quite magical. Feeling

Maggie against him while she got fucked was far different than hiding in the closet and watching. It was more than front row even. It was being one with her sexuality. It was Cole's cock running against his that had brought his orgasm. He was one with Maggie. Her pleasure in that moment was his pleasure. And Cole was a friend. Jay wasn't. Jay was unknown. He was accomplished and while it wasn't certain he was serious he had mentioned the L word. Love.

That was a no-no. That would initiate the kill switch. This was, for Maggie, about the things she had missed—for Max it was about watching her be intimate with other men to discover more about his own sexuality. Why did that drive him wild? Love, however, was a complication he didn't need complicating what was already complicated. Cole was fun, he was tuned into her and he was Max's best friend. Four years he'd known Maggie and he'd never made a move. Cole could be trusted. Jay would now be pushed to the side of Maggie's plate. They had someone who would play and he seemed manageable.

Cole stirred. His hand moved to his stiff cock and gripped it. He pushed it down gripped it tighter, squeezed it, groaned and yawned. Let it go, turned to Max, saw he was awake, and said, "That was fucking wild."

He nodded but his expression didn't change.

"You okay?"

"I am," he said, but he didn't commit emotion to the words.

Cole went to his back now, and his arms went out, flexed and twisted while he stretched. "Fuck...that Maggie...she is something," he said.

Max agreed, reminded him that they had to go early and that they were going to take Ken to T. F. Green. Worried about the ride in the Jeep. Would he say something? Max imagined he would keep it to himself. How could he say something? What would he say? Imagined if he saw his own sister with two of her friends—knew he'd carry it to the grave. He would shudder every time he thought of it, would never forget it, but it would not be uttered. Still, he wasn't sure if Ken knew that Max had seen him watching. That would be uncomfortable. Something *that* awful, and the two of them shared the knowledge.

They skipped their showers. Brushed their teeth together, looking at each other's reflections in the mirror and both of them coming close to smiling but not actually doing it.

They packed quickly, hoping to get out of the house unaccounted. Moving silently, stuffing dirty clothes on top of clean. When they made their beds and got to the door Maggie was in the hall waiting for them.

“How long have you been standing here?” Max asked.

She looked worried. Cole put his arms round her and let his bag fall. She let herself be hugged, but her eyes were on Max. She said, “Ken’s not here.”

Max said, “Oh? What do you mean?”

“I mean he left already...”

“Without us?” Cole asked.

“Yeah, his room is empty, his bags are gone...”

“He was going with us—I got that right?” Cole asked, holding her face away from him so he could look in her eyes.

“Yes...”

Max asked, “He leave a note?”

“Nothing,” she shrugged, a restrained look of horror on her face. “You don’t suppose...”

Cole said, “What?”

She said, “That he...” she let it hang, afraid to even suggest what she was afraid of.

“No,” Cole said, “no way. He would have said something.”

Max kept his mouth shut.

Cole held Maggie and she stared blankly into Max’s eyes. He looked supportive for her. Showed her strength.

Cole said, “Hey,” and he hooked a bent finger under her chin and tilted her mouth to his kiss. She let him kiss her but she was reluctant. Max was aroused by it. Felt pleasure from seeing her kiss his handsome friend, but not commit. He watched their lips press against each other, the plump shapes mash, then pout, come away.

He said, “Let’s get out of here before your parents are up.”

“They’re up,” she said.

“Shit,” he said.

Cole said, “Fuck.”

“They’re not downstairs yet,” she said.

None of them said a word, they picked up their bags and things and they ran down the stairs to the darkened kitchen and out the door, onto the gravel. Crunched across the drive and into the Jeep. They put their bags in

the back and Cole put the raven head in the back seat next to Max. Max asked Maggie. "There's room for your bird cage. You want me to go back and get it?"

She shook her head with a sad expression. "I want to leave it behind," she said. Her hands were folded over the center console of the Jeep and Max reached out and he held one of them, softly ran his thumb over it.

"I think that's a good idea." He kissed her and she kissed him back with enough gentle passion that her eyes closed. When she pulled away she looked in his eyes and they held that contact for a good long quiet moment. He couldn't say for sure what was in those eyes but he knew it was good and he knew he liked it.

As they made their way down the driveway and paused for the metal gate to open and let them out of the Becker compound Max asked, "You don't think your dad has security cameras do you?"

It just came to him. Sitting alone in the back while Maggie scrolled her phone and Cole drove it hit him. The gate, the security it provided, the value of some of his art. He had real Pollocks.

Maggie's head turned and regarded Cole. Max watched her eyebrows raise as she considered what he'd said. It was real.

"Oh shit," Cole said.

"No," Maggie groaned.

"Did he have cameras before?" Cole asked.

"No. Not when I was growing up. Not in the house," she said. She tossed her phone in her purse so she could concentrate. She put her head in her hands. "Oh fuck," she said into them, her voice muffled.

"Does he have cameras?" Cole asked, his voice urgent, his octave a little higher now.

Maggie looked back to Max. He shrugged his shoulders.

Cole had calmed down, brought himself under control. He said coolly, "Even if he did, he'd only check them if something was stolen, right? Why would he look at dumb old videos of nothing every morning?"

"You think?" Maggie asked. She'd gone pale.

Cole said, "Yeah, he'd only check if something was out of the ordinary. Right, Max?"

Maggie looked to him.

He frowned. Considered it. It was true. If he had cameras at all there would be no reason to check them. Unless a suspicion was raised. He said,

“Yeah, it’ll...if there was a recording...record over itself in a week or two.”

Maggie said, “Oh shit... why didn’t I think of that? ...”

The gate opened and they exited, headed out to the narrow country road that would take them to Jamestown.

THEY CRESTED a gravelly hill in the wobbling Jeep and Cole gasped, tugged the wheel hard. They were enclosed on both sides on the narrow treacherous road by towering pine trees and as they topped a short hill, their guts tingling at the sudden rise, they all saw a lone figure walking the road with a bag over his shoulder, slumped low like a Depression-era hobo.

“Fuck,” Cole hissed as he wrenched the wheel hard and brought the Jeep to a tearing halt in the rough surface, drawing it sideways across the road.

It was Ken. Walking the road, a backpack over his shoulder, head hung over his iPhone as he walked.

“What the hell...” Maggie whispered aloud in the quiet Jeep, not expecting an answer.

Dust settled around their windows, churning, falling below the height of the high Jeep doors. Ken had turned to them, he was startled. Max detected a weak artificial smile on his face. Maggie wound her window down, using the manual lever, her head bobbing with the effort.

“Ken, what are you doing out here?” she said out the window.

He made his way to her, said, “I called an Uber.”

“We were taking you,” she said, folding her arm out the open window and leaning on the door.

“I know,” he said, looked to Max, looked away quickly, down the road and up to the hill they’d just crested. He said, “I didn’t want to wreck...your schedule.”

“Our schedule? ...Ken, we want to take you—it’s no problem...”

“Yeah,” he said, hoisting his bag higher on his shoulder, still having trouble looking in her eyes.

Cole said, “You called an Uber out to the middle of nowhere? ...”

“Uh-huh,” he said looking the screen of his phone.

Maggie said, “Cancel it, Ken. You idiot. We’ll take you.” She opened her door and got right out of the Jeep, set her feet down on the gravel.

Ken looked back the way they came and said, “We should get off the road, there’s a hill right there...”

Maggie said, “Just get in the Jeep already.”

He climbed in and he sat himself next to Max. He made eye contact. There was nothing there. Nothing blatant, but there was a guardedness that wasn't there before. Ken knew things had changed. And Max knew too.

Ken looked to Max’s lap, at the raven head he’d placed there to make room for him. The one he saw over his sister’s head as she fucked two guys at once. Her groom and the Best Man. Max took the raven head and passed it to the front seat. Maggie climbed back in the front, took it from him and she put it in her lap, did her belt up.

Max looked to Ken and smiled. Ken looked away. He was forlorn. Max didn’t press it. Looked out his own window and stayed quiet.

Cole said, “Dude, it’s no problem to take you to the airport. We left at the same time. No hassle at all.” He got the Jeep in gear and they were under way again.

Ken said, “Okay,” very quietly.

They drove half an hour to Warwick in relative silence. The Jeep was noisy and conversation between front and back was difficult. Cole tried to engage Ken, and he was responsive, but he kept his answers short—flipped through his phone and had one earbud in. When they got to the airport, Maggie hopped out and flipped her seat forward so he could climb down. Max watched them in the V between the door frame and the forward angled passenger seat. It was bright and crisp out but their two figures stood in blue shade under the canopy at the drop-off.

Maggie cocked her head, said to Ken, “You okay?”

“Yeah,” he said. “Overworked. Not looking forward to getting back to it right now.”

“I’m sorry I was rude last night. I didn’t mean to be.”

“It’s okay,” he said. He hugged her, held her a good long while. When he let her go he said, “I love you. I want you to be happy. I want you to be careful.”

“Careful?”

He held her wrists, she had her arms at her sides. He said, “You can come visit me anytime. You’ve never seen my place.”

“Okay,” she said. “Maybe I’ll come see you. You can come to Vermont too.”

“Maybe I will,” said Ken. He hugged her again, let her go, waved to Cole and Max, said, “Thanks for the ride.”

They watched him disappear behind the sliding glass doors. They closed and all they saw was their own reflection. Maggie got back in the Jeep.

“What do you think?” she said, looking to Cole with worried brows then between the seats to Max.

Max said, “I think Stanford is killing him.”

She bit her lip, looked to Cole, said, “You think?”

Cole took her hand and said, “I think it’s okay.”

Maggie let her head fall against the seat, whispered, “I hope so.”

Max looked at their two hands combined. His Maggie’s familiar little graceful hand held in another man’s. He hated it but still felt a spark of excitement. He leaned forward, let his hand curve over theirs and he held them warmly. He looked to Maggie and he said, “Secret Society.”

She laughed and rolled her eyes.

Cole said, “We’ll take care of you.”

Max agreed, said, “We will.”

He squeezed their hands. They would do this a little longer. Do it until he didn’t want to anymore. There was more he wanted to see but he felt like it was in his control again. He felt like he was riding up top, if he held the wheel tight enough he could steer this machine, make it go where he wanted.



Easter Egg

THIS IS A HIDDEN FANTASY SHORT INVOLVING MY MOST BELOVED CHARACTERS. IT'S AN EPILOGUE, OR PERHAPS A PROLOGUE OF SORTS, FEATURING PETE AND JESS MAPPLETHORPE FROM THE FIRST LOSING HIS WIFE SERIES. IT MAY BE REAL OR IT MAY NOT. I'D LOVE TO HEAR YOUR OPINION AT MY [WEBSITE](#). LET ME KNOW WHAT YOU THINK!

Wednesday, April 8th

PETE RAN across Conway Street where it met Water, and then did a loop around the brass statue of Ellie Callou, the town of Peavey Falls' noted suffragette. 5 A.M. and fifty-five degrees out, and while it was spring, the time and temperature and his own body heat were enough to send roiling clouds of frosty breath from him. But his feet tapped away. Not afraid of the cold. He ran every day, even the sunny ones.

The Peavey 10K Run for Charity was two weeks away. Raising money for the St. Joan of Arc Hospital's pediatric unit. He'd logged more than fifty 10Ks over the winter, one day at a time. Pretty much got himself *over*-prepared but these morning runs were for therapy more than fitness anyway. And most of his best ideas were born on these runs. The idea to integrate scaleable inventory management services controlled by Save-Mart but

accessible by key vendors. Check. The sudden sale of their first Cleveland home, upscaling themselves into a nicer neighborhood (where prices had remained fixed) with their gains. Check. The hire of three young unpaid interns from the college, forming a vendor outreach program with them and giving them accreditation. Check. Even simple things like planning a Christmas get-together with Patty and Russ, a rapprochement in the midway point between Cleveland and Columbus, and even trading in the Oldsmobile and getting the Tahoe. Well, that wasn't a *good* idea. That was kind of stupid. A waste of money. The smile though on Jess's face was worth it. And the boys? ...They thought old pop was real swell when they pulled up to the rink on Saturday mornings for hockey practice in that luxury truck. But he bought it two years old, depreciation hit already gone, and they scaled down to one vehicle.

He hated giving in to the lure of extravagances but living in a nicer neighborhood came with its responsibilities. He didn't want people talking about Andy and Petey's cheap old weird dad. They'd been through enough. The more the appearance of stability the better.

He came to a red light and jogged in place at the edge of the crosswalk. Traffic was sparse so early in the morning, but there were cars out, headlights on, people embarking on their dim commute on an early Wednesday morning. He unzipped his phone and flipped the screen to see if he had any news. He was Save-Mart's Divisional Merchandise Manager now. A VP, in charge of maintaining merchandising relationships with Save-Mart's prime suppliers all over the northeast; Mid-west to Cleveland to the Canadian border to the Atlantic and down to the Mason-Dixon. Today was his presentation to Porter Papers which sold just about every paper product under Save-Mart's roof, from tissues and toilet paper to plates and packaging. It was a no-brainer, and just a bit of hand-holding. The execs at Porter were just as gushing to Pete at how they were represented in Save-Mart stores. Only, he'd sent an e-mail to Becky last night to get a preview of the changes to the Powerpoint and she hadn't got back to him. He didn't need to worry but he did anyway. Becky was new. Pretty and flirty and he hated to have to discipline her. So many of these kids today never got back to you after hours even though he knew they got the messages. They were always on their goddamn phones. The light changed and he headed onto the crosswalk early, slipping his message-less phone into his pocket.

There was a raucous horn that scared the shit out of him. An aggressive pickup truck looming in height and muscle charged him, nose diving, rubber chirping and horn bellowing. He put his hand out, his heart pounding in his chest. The horn continued angrily. *All right, already, sorry!* His hand rested on the mouth of the lifted truck's grill. He waved to the driver, it was his fault, avoided eye contact and trotted off again, trying to find his pace. By the time he hit Peavey Street, looking over the railing and down to the white thrashing water of the falls, he'd shaken off the jangled nerves and his thoughts were back on work.

THE MAPPLETHORPE FAMILY Tahoe gleamed in the driveway of their Holly Springs white clapboard suburban Colonial. Forty-five hundred square feet with a fully finished lower level that opened onto a hilly green lawn where the boys would play. A large lot on a cul-de-sac, with a gravel trail behind the house, hidden by trees, that wound around a pond and led to the Holly Springs community pool and tennis courts.

He was cooling down, shaking his legs out as he walked the driveway then up the path between two towering lilac shrubs, their buds just starting to blossom. He hid his keys when he left, slipping them on a hook hidden under the backyard deck, on a joist behind the cedar ledger. Trotted up onto the deck on springy new Sauconys, between the two iron patio tables he'd brought out of storage on Sunday but hadn't got the chairs around or an umbrella into yet. He'd get to it tonight. Get the furniture out, get it cleaned. Spring was here and company was coming.

Got the smallest key on the ring into the sliding glass door lock and opened it, slipped into the kitchen as quietly as he could. Kicked his shoes off and left them there on the rubber mat next to Sargent's water bowl. Sargent, the lone woken member of the household—black eyes watching old Pete from his wicker dog bed, too early for anything more enthusiastic than a lazy swishing wag from the feathers at the tip of his tail.

The coffeemaker began to hiss on the counter, programmed to be at the ready for when the family got up. He checked his watch. It was early but he might still have time.

The stairs could creak even though the house wasn't that old, so he slipped along the edges where they met the wall, making no sounds in his

socks. At the top of the stairs he turned right, headed between the boys' doors and made it to the master bedroom.

Last night Jess had taught her dance class down in the village at the Peavey Falls Little Theater. She taught on Tuesdays and Thursdays, her class had an age range of little girls (and one brave little boy) between eight and twelve years old. Pete had the boys and baby Annabelle last night. Class was out by eight but she went out for a drink with some friends and she didn't get home until ten.

He slipped in the double doors and locked them behind him. Jess was sleeping where he'd left her when he woke at 4:30 and headed out for his run. Sleeping on her belly, her long blonde hair tangled around her on her pillow. Head turned to the center, looking at his pillow, looking at where he would be if he were still warm in bed with her. Her arms held a deep tan. One week with the boys and Annabelle in Orlando had given her a very sexy color. One wonderful week with the love of his life, (no work!) and his boys, and his baby.

Skated quietly then in his sock across the hard maple floor and into the master bathroom. Brushed his teeth quickly and rinsed with Scope. Peeled the tight running clothes off and threw them in the hamper. So cold outside his penis was just an acorn in his pubic hair, his testicles gone, hiding up in his body. Didn't tug it, just let it be. Took a bath towel and he dried himself off, his skin cold, but a chilly sweat on the surface. She would complain.

He'd been in the mood last night but exhausted. Watched Ghostbusters with the boys down in the TV room, baby Annabelle asleep in her crib, baby monitor on the coffee table. After the movie Petey took Andy up to bed and he tried to stay awake for Jess but he fell asleep on the couch. Went to bed before ten, heard her come home shortly after that, wake him up, and by then it was too late.

He was still in the mood. Not even a quarter to six and he wanted a piece of his wife before he had to go to work and deal with the suits from Porter.

Their bedroom faced over the yard, their bed a maple sleigh under a cathedral ceiling that formed a bank of bay windows. He slipped naked into the bed, lifting the bedding and getting in right next to her from her side.

She moaned softly, feeling him coming, then hissed and jumped.

"Pete!"

Her legs kicked back from him, recoiled. He bounced himself under the sheets and covered up, soaking in the warmth from the bedding where she'd just been laying.

"You're freezing," she said, turning now, her face very mad, hair tangled over her, caught in the wet of her lips.

"I didn't know," he laughed, "I don't feel cold."

He didn't. Not until he settled into her warm spot and realized how good it felt.

"Why would you do that?" Her eyes were closed again and she lay with her face turned to the ceiling, a hand rubbing her cheeks.

"I missed you last night," he said.

"Mm, I know. You were asleep when I got home."

"Did you have fun?"

"Yeah," she said.

"Who was there?"

"Uh, Shelly from Peavey Public, she brought a friend who's a mom of one of my students—"

"From dance?"

"Mm," she moaned and stretched, rubbing her eyes, "Yeah, from the dance class, her daughter's pretty good."

"Who else?"

"Uh, Rose from yoga, and Marnie."

"I know Marnie."

"You do."

"Hey, I'm going to touch you..."

"You better not," she said, blinking, letting her eyes get adjusted to being awake.

"Come on, Jess, warm me up," he said, refraining from reaching out and touching her like he wanted.

She sighed and smiled and wormed her way closer to him, but kept a space between them.

"You sex maniac," she said.

"I tried to stay awake last night but I was so tired."

"Why do you go to bed so early?"

"Because I get up so early."

"It's that cold out this morning?" she said, looking in his eyes.

"Feel how cold," he said, smiling back.

Her hands were folded up on the pillow under her cheek and he took one by a wrist and led it under the covers. She watched his eyes as she felt around his shriveled penis. She touched it, her fingers tweaked his tip and jiggled it.

“Where did it go?” she said.

“Warm it up for me.”

She pulled it, and gripped it, tried to squeeze it in her warm hand. When she felt lower, she said, “Pete, your balls...”

“I know.”

“They’re gone, Petey.”

“Kiss me,” he said.

“You got to brush your teeth, I didn’t...” she giggled and she kissed his shoulder.

“Come on, Jess,” he said, pleading warmly with his eyes.

“Your hands are like ice,” she said, still tugging at his shrunken size.

“Your mouth is warm,” he said.

She smiled and narrowed her eyes at him. Took the sheets then and wrapped them around herself, protecting her bare arms from touching his skin. She slipped under the blanket and he watched her ghostly shape move down between his legs. Her mouth went over his little penis and his eyes closed at her lovely warmth. The whole thing went past her lips, his raisin scrotum, his quickly hardening cock. She sucked, bobbed, his flaccid genitals entirely in her mouth. As he grew hard, as his cock stuck out from his body he peeled the cover up so he could watch her.

“Hey,” she said, catching his eye, and then frowning.

“Let me watch you,” he said.

Her heart pendant lay flat on his thigh and her hands rested on his trim belly. He put a hand over one. She grinned for him, held his erection between her fingers and slipping his tip along her bottom lip. She left his eyes and sunk his little thing in her mouth and sucked again, bobbed and fed off his reactions. He grew to steel in just a minute.

Her thumb and forefinger went gently up and down, and she said, “Did you lock that door?”

“I did.”

“Get me in the mood?”

He nodded, feeling excitement tighten his ribs.

“Don’t touch me with your cold,” she giggled as she lay back and he took *his* turn under the covers. Her knees drew up and he got between her legs. Her warmth radiated from the flesh between her thighs and he was careful not to freeze her with his coldest parts. His shoulder touched the inside of her knee and she flinched but she didn’t protest.

She was wearing a white undershirt and black cotton panties and he slipped his fingers into her waistband, keeping the contact with her sensitive belly to a minimum. He pulled them up her thighs and her knees rose above his head, came together to a point and he hooped them over and then down her calves. He smelled her. She was warm and sleepy and she smelled like his Jess. He tasted her. Just his face touching her.

His tongue swept her wrinkled folds and she began to moan in anticipation. Two fingers came up and touched her in her center where she was so hot his cold was extinguished. His fingers parted like a V and he spread her, kissed her at the warm wet inside of her labia, his tongue starting to curl and point and penetrate. She moaned more loudly and her hips started to rock. The deeper her breaths grew the closer he came to her hood and when he had her breaths scoring and her hips writhing he took her swollen clit. He worked it and his finger gently caressed and plunged ever so slightly. He brought her up slowly, let her body tell him what it wanted. He responded, kissing and suckling and stroking and lunging, giving her what she needed, advancing when she did, receding when she wanted. Hard strokes and delicate tickles until those breathes became whines and he felt her nails in his hair. There was a tremble in her thrusts as she ground her hips into his driving tongue.

When she got like this he wondered if she thought of the other man. He thought she must. That she would do it to take herself over the edge. He didn’t mind if she did, just don’t tell him. He imagined it, but he didn’t want to know for sure.

He felt safest with Jess when he was between her legs like this. Or if he took her from behind. Sometimes it hurt him to look in her eyes when they made love. *Most* of the time it hurt—it hurt to see her face in ecstasy because it made him think of bad things. Not *all* the time, just when things were stressful or he was feeling down.

“Pete, Pete,” she whispered and her hands left him. His eyes wandered up her belly, up over her breasts pressing against the white undershirt and saw her face turned to the ceiling, her hands over her head and clutching the

top of the polished sleigh. She was going to come. Closed his eyes then and he gulped her. Took all her hot wet flesh in his mouth and pulled it, sucked it into him, tongue driving, flexed and curled, the strong base of it riding her bucking clit. She gasped, and the headboard banged, and her hips thrust up against him. She tightened and twisted and she held her breath.

She turned to her side, ass still flat on the bed, but spun at the waist holding a pillow clutched over her face as she groaned into it. He kissed his way through her bushy pubic hair, up her flat belly, and ran his tongue over her belly button like a pool ball being drained. He pressed his cold body to her and she inhaled sharply and said something into the pillow. He held her, took her heat from her and she didn't fight him.

He fixed his penis inside her. She was hot and wet still, so slick, and his small size slipped right up. His fingers clutched into the pillow, pulled it from her face. She turned her head too, and he didn't try and look in her eyes. He fucked her missionary with his face buried in her collar. Sucked on her neck and along her clavicle, and she rubbed his back, waiting for him to come. Her knees came up and she clasped them to his waist. She was soundless. Just his breaths rushing as he got closer and closer to orgasm, dry burgeoning desperate sounds as his semen began to boil in his balls hiding somewhere inside his body.

He closed his eyes and pictured her out last night with friends. His bad Jessy. There was a guy who brought his daughter to her class that hung around sometimes. Single dad. A mechanic down at Ray's Auto Shop. He was a good dad, burly, big gut, friendly smile but dazzling icy blue eyes and white teeth. He pictured Jess lying last night. Meeting him, whatever his name was. Maybe she didn't know his name. Maybe she just took him behind the Theater, down the walkway that looked out over the Peavey River and he fucked her from behind, bent her over the metal railing, the rushing river drowning out her cries of passion.

"You, uh...off your...pill?"

"Yeah, I...I stopped..."

"You ovulating?"

"Close...You going to give me an-another baby?"

"Tell me...Jess, tell me you want my baby..."

Her hand rubbed his back as he humped his little cock inside her hard and fast with short earnest strokes.

“That’s it, Petey,” she cooed in his ear, “Give me a little baby, I want another little baby...”

He stabbed her, stabbed her as hard as he could and he made her grunt with each one. She felt him coming. Could feel his seed shooting out of him. He grunted and groaned and thrust himself into her, trying to get that seed of his as deep as he could. He’d give her another baby. If it kept her in the house, he’d keep her full of babies.

PETE CAME downstairs after his shower to his family in motion. The boys were at the kitchen table and Jess was at work in the wide space between the island and the stove, weaving around toys and Sargent, who was following her and almost purposely trying to get in her way. Annabelle was on her knees, three-years-old now, blonde hair, long and silky and light like Jess’s. Pete pulled the latch on the baby gate that crossed the door from the hall into the mouth of the spacious kitchen. When he closed it behind him, Jess turned and smiled and she squat right down on her heels next to Annabelle and said, “Who’s that?”

She lifted a finger and pointed it to Pete as Annabelle turned, one hand on her Peppa Pig, the other on Peppa’s piggy husband, George. She had her Peppa’s Deluxe Playhouse hinged open on the bleached maple floor, pig tables and chairs, and a bright yellow clawfoot tub scattered at its base. Her face brightened, eyes went wide when she saw Pete and she worked her way to her feet and ran to him, saying, “Daddy!”

Annabelle came to him, sure-footed these days, and Jess patted her bottom before she went. He squat down too, just across from Jess and held his hands out for his daughter. She fell into them and he hoisted her as he stood and plopped her against his chest and kissed her cheek. Annabelle launched into a story and while it made no sense to him, (he thought it might have been about the Pig family) she was enthusiastic and lively and had a flare for drama. He nodded and said, “Oh, really?” at appropriate points. Jess pressed herself against him in her robe, kissed Annabelle’s cheek too, and sneakily patted Pete’s bottom so the boys wouldn’t see.

“Eggs?” she asked.

“The works,” he said, seeing she had bacon and sausage on paper towels, and buttered toast.

“How you want yours?” she asked as she returned to the stove and Pete walked with Annabelle on his hip to the kitchen table where the boys were getting themselves together with their breakfast. Andy was bringing Petey’s tablet to him, watching something on the screen and stumbling along.

“Scrambled, Jess,” he said, then to Andy, “Come on buddy, come and sit, please.”

“Petey, buddy, what’s with the long face, kid?”

Petey said, “My face isn’t long, Dad.” He frowned, swiped the tablet that Andy had brought him, his long lashes blinking while he watched his fingers manipulate the screen.

“Buddy...” he said.

“Yeah?” he said, looking up now.

“You’re going to cream those Tigers, you know.”

“I know, Dad,” he said. He was worried. This was a big weekend coming up. He had his Aunt Patty, Uncle Russ, and cousins coming, they would be attending his Saturday morning hockey game and that was giving him stress. He was pushed to the limit already with his team. It was Peewee hockey, but the coach was straight NHL. Hammering plays into them, making them memorize complicated strategies while some of them were not even competent skaters or puck-handlers. Left Wing Locks, forechecking, face-off strategies... Petey was a good player, getting lanky this year, shooting up just before his tenth birthday. He was tall, uncoordinated, but a fast skater. Coach was throwing him into a lot of plays because he knew he could get to spots fast, but the anxiety of accepting the puck was working his poor son, making him tense. Some of the other parents had complained about the stress, but Coach Harrison hadn’t changed. He was young. A real bearded hothead and he was the kind of guy who didn’t know any other way to do things than the way he already did them. There weren’t many games left in the season any way.

“Here, Pete,” Jess said, coming over to the table holding a plate with one piece of raisin toast spread with peanut butter on it. It had been cut in half then in narrow strips.

He made an excited face for Annabelle and said, “What did mommy bring for you? Your favorite...you want some? ...” He took a corner piece of the warm bread, held it by the crust and swooped it towards her talking mouth and she paused her story.

He paused too, said, “What do you say?”

She smiled and squinted hard like she was going to sneeze, didn't, then said, "Yes, peez."

"You are so smart," he said and he kissed her head and she took the toast into her mouth.

"Okay, Annie, let's get you in your spot," he said then, and he took her and lifted her into her high chair, holding her by her armpits and dangling her legs into the chair's holes. Set her down, got her situated with her toast in front of her and sat back at the table, in time for Jess to bring him his breakfast.

He looked up at the clock on the wall above the archway that led into the laundry room. It was after seven now, almost a quarter after. He scorfed his eggs, and washed it back with coffee.

Petey, said, "Dad, you're eating too fast, you're gonna choke."

"Mmn-mm," he shook his head, felt a crisp piece of bacon stick to the back of his throat and cleared it, felt it shoot up and hit the roof of his mouth. He coughed and his eyes watered.

Petey laughed and said, "I told you so," and went back to his tablet.

There was a sound in the hall, someone coming in to their house and Jess watched the dining room where she could see through to the hall, watching to see who it was though they knew who it would be.

Stuart Tillman, neighbor and also a Save-Mart exec, lived down the street and they walked to the train together in the mornings. He was the same age as Pete but he didn't get up early in the mornings to run and he also didn't watch what he ate. He was a big guy, he carried his weight well, but he filled his suit out pretty good.

"Hey, Jessy," he said and he kissed Jess's cheek as he came into the kitchen, stepping over the baby gate instead of opening it. "Petey, Petey," he said, looking at Pete trying to stuff a sausage in his mouth while he stood up, coffee cup poised to wash it all down. "Let's go, chop chop," he joked.

Pete nodded and Jess said, "Stuart, you want a cup of coffee, can you sit for a minute?"

Pete shook his head no, drinking his coffee, his other hand lifting his short juice glass.

"That's all right, Jess," Stuart said, "I had one already. I'm flying high as it is."

Pete knocked his juice back and looped around the table, kissing the top of Annie's head and dodging her peanut butter hands as they reached for

him, tried to grab his tie. He kissed Petey on his hair, Andy too, then crossed the kitchen to Jess and Stuart. He stepped between Stuart and her, took her in his arms and kissed her for real and she leaned back with him, one foot coming off the floor. He caressed the small of her back, dipping a little low for public. He got her laughing and she pulled from him and wiped her mouth.

“You taste like bacon,” she laughed, then darted in and kissed his cheek and he winked.

“See you tonight,” he said

“By-eye,” she said, with exaggerated desire for him to get the hell out of here.

“Bye, boys, bye Annie,” he said waving from the baby gate. They waved back, Petey not looking up from his tablet. He and Stuart headed out their front door.

They walked down the cul-de-sac and made their way to the Holly Springs boardwalk that would take them across the marsh on a wooden bridge, a shortcut that would bring them into the Village in time to grab the train to Cleveland. As their feet hit the pressure-treated planks, Stuart turned to him and said, “You’re one lucky guy, Pete. That Jess is something. You got a real great family.”

“Thanks,” he said. “They’re everything to me. I’d do anything for them.”

JESS GOT THE BOYS FED, helped them clean up after themselves and walked them to the end of the cul-de-sac and got them on the bus. It was still such an odd feeling to get used to. Standing with the mothers of other children, waving at the school bus full of kids, then turning around and going home to her quiet house, alone but for baby Annie.

She was taking a break from teaching, taking a break from a lot of things since they moved to Cleveland. She’d had her baby, her beautiful little Annabelle. Then took time to stay at home with her and run the house. Pete had settled in at the corporate office and within eighteen months he was promoted to a VP position in charge of vendor relations. It just worked out well with her not going back to work. There had been the new house to

be bought, and all the work that comes with that. She was doing well staying at home.

So if Pete wanted another baby that was fine for her. She would love another little one. She could always pick up substituting in a few years and try and get back in the swing then if she wanted.

Frankly, she was enjoying being at home so much with the kids. Planning their schedules, helping with their homework, making meals. Her little babies were getting well-prepared when they were receiving the full attention of a very organized Teacher of the Year.

For an hour after her family had left she cleaned. Vacuumed, ran the dishwasher, and put on a load of laundry, folded one that just came out of the dryer. Then she took Annie up to the master bathroom with her and she got herself in the tub.

This Colonial they were in was luxurious and spacious. Even nicer than the home she'd grown up in. It wasn't even that expensive. Pete was so good with money that they were able to get themselves into this quaint little neighborhood in one of the nicest spots outside the city without a blink from the bank. They'd be paying for this place until they were sixty but it was really feeling like home.

The tub she took her bath in every morning was a freestanding oval under a tall window that looked out over the front lawn. She had a leafy palm on either side and it was like her spa break every day. The tub was even heated, she could lay her back against it and let the warmth work through her back, her neck, and her shoulders. Annie lay for a nap in her crib and Jess could watch her from the baby monitor she left at the end of the counter near the foot of the tub.

Once she was cleaned and dressed she bundled little Annie up and got her into her car seat in the back of the Tahoe and she headed to the Kroger. There was shopping to do for this weekend and she'd been dreading it. They had company coming and, while she was excited, it was still tough. She'd been trying to patch the relationship with Patty. Patty hated her. Had physically threatened her twice when Pete and she had got back together. Had fought and cried with her own brother for taking her back when she had a big round belly, another man's baby in it.

How can you do this to yourself, Pete?

She was right. Pete was a special man. She told that to Patty. Cried and poured her heart out how sorry she was and how good her brother was. It

was met with stone. It wasn't until this last Christmas that they'd tried to get together. Enough time had passed, she thought. Though, how much was enough time considering what she'd done? There wasn't enough time. It would never be forgotten. All of them would just have to get over it.

As she got out to Orange Street she signaled right to get out to the highway, then changed her mind, easing the big SUV through the intersection at an awkward angle, turning across two lanes and then heading west along Orange Street and into the Village. It was all right, no cops around, and the pickup truck behind her did the same thing, butt itself right up to her bumper. No one honked. She would go to the Heinlens instead of the Kroger. Pete hated it when she shopped at the grocer in the Village because it was so expensive but they just had nicer things and she wanted this weekend to make a good impression on Patty.

This Christmas Pete had broken his sister down and they'd spent Christmas Eve together at a restaurant. It went well. There was nothing left to say. Small uncomfortable talk for sure, but no bad words were exchanged, though Patty's eyes shot black daggers at her. She was on her best behavior. She wanted Pete to be happy. Wanted his sister in their son's lives.

The biggest fear she had going in was that Patty and Russ would bring gifts for Petey and Andy but bring nothing for Annie. That would have killed her. That would have made her cry. But they didn't. They were thoughtful. It was a sign of hope. Maybe Pete had told them it was possible Annie was his. It was possible. Highly unlikely. Given the circumstances, which she hated to consider, that baby was not her husband's.

Old Pete never missed a step. He took Annie as his own. Sometimes, especially in those first few months back together, she would lay at night and cry at how forgiving he was. At what a good man he was. When Annie was born he treated her as he treated his own sons when they were born. He doted, he changed diapers, he got up at three in the morning and let her sleep. She was very lucky to have her family.

WITH ANNIE KICKING HER LEGS, dangling out of the slots in the seat of the shopping cart, Jess poked through the selections of appetizer trays. She got an antipasto platter, charcuterie and artisan cheeses, and one with

grilled veggies and a peppercorn ranch dip. She bought the roast beef and some chicken breasts and a ham for Easter dinner. Stocked up on vegetables and some lunch meat for the boys, black forest ham for Pete.

She bought chocolate eggs and some bunnies for the kids so they could hide them on Easter morning and bought some eggs they could decorate. She'd already gone down to the Michaels just outside the city on Monday and bought all sorts of colored paper, felts, dyes, packs of cartoon eyes, and pipe cleaners and paints and egg decorating kits. She had a whole host of activities planned for the kids on Saturday afternoon and Sunday.

The lineup was long and she had to wait forever with her packed cart. The Heinlens was in the Village, an awkward sort of spot and had cramped aisles but it was nicely decorated and they carried better quality things. Usually it was quiet and they almost always had enough employees present, but three days before Easter it was very busy. She scrolled through her phone, played peek-a-boo with Annie who laughed and giggled and then said *mom-mom-mom*, over and over and when Jess said *What?* she launched into a long tale that at times made sense then other times really didn't—the whole while she kept Jess engaged with her enormous crystal blue eyes. She caught the attention of an older woman in the next line over and made her laugh.

She said, "How old?"

Jess said, "She's three," and the woman said *Gosh, she looks just like you, she's so pretty*. Jess laughed and said *Thank you*. Then in the silence after the exchange her smile faded and she felt suddenly very sad and very scared. She didn't know why. A rolling torpor, a sadness tinged with dread. She looked up around the grocery, felt like she was watched, felt guilty for some reason.

SHE FELT BETTER in the fresh air.

Pushed the cart with Annie in it to the Tahoe, got her groceries loaded, stacked her cart through the others against the supermarket brick, and walked Annie back on her hip to the truck. Stopped at a Starbuck's drive-thru on the way home and got herself an iced cappuccino hoping the cold would settle her stomach.

Patty and Russ would be driving to Cleveland from Columbus on Friday afternoon, staying over Friday night and Saturday night. She had two guest rooms made up for them. One for Patty and Russ, one for Tammy, she figured Jacob might want to be in with the boys but that was up to him. If he wanted his own space there was a pull out couch in Pete's office. They had Petey's hockey game on Saturday morning and then afterward there was a farm out on the edge of Peavey Falls that was offering a fun Easter Egg Hunt and they would go to that. Dinner on Saturday night, that would be their Easter dinner, she was prepared for that. Then an Easter Egg Hunt of their own on Sunday morning, then a brunch (she'd shopped for that too), and hopefully there would be peace when they left on Sunday afternoon. Hopefully there would be another stitch in the tear in her husband's relationship with his sister. She'd ripped it. She was responsible. She liked to help mend it.

Once home, she backed up the driveway and unloaded the groceries through the garage, put on some music and started thinking about what she would do for dinner. She got a pot boiling to cook potatoes and had the fridge open when she thought she heard the front door open.

Annie was behind her, banging plastic pigs together in front of her open playhouse. She heard it too. She looked up and smiled and said, "Daddy."

"Don't think so," Jess whispered and her hands went cold. No one came through their front door except Stuart. He wouldn't come here now.

She listened, held onto the fridge door and strained to hear.

There were footsteps in the hall. Someone was in her house.

HE STOOD in the hall of their home like he'd only been away for days. A photo of Annabelle held in his hand, lifted from the table that sat below the angled slash of stairs leading up to the bedrooms.

"Tyler," she whispered and fell down in a dining room chair.

He smiled and set the frame back where he'd found it, turned then and put his hands in the pockets of his pants, said, "Hi, Jess."

He wore a suit. No tie, just a jacket and pants and an unbuttoned white shirt. His hair was much the same, thick sandy brown and combed off his handsome face.

She was steel. Her insides churning molten metal. Her mouth opened to say something and she had no air. The hinge of her jaw worked but no voice came out and she didn't even know what to say.

His shoes made hollow sound against the polished wood as he came to the step into the dining room. He looked around her home. Annabelle babbled, *Daddy* from the kitchen, behind her baby gate.

She stood, unsteady benumbed movement on languid legs; she still had failed to breathe. He stepped down, fixing his eyes on hers, that smile still there. She stepped back wordlessly. He stepped again and she took another one backward. Her back pressed to a six foot tall mirror fixed to the wall, it's gilded frame touching her calves, her shoulder blades to the glass.

She exhaled, then whispered, "Don't."

But he came to her, a smirk twisting his mouth, his head cocked, studying her as he took the final steps to bring them together, face to face. One hand in his pocket still, he leaned the other against the mirror above her head, she looked up into his blue eyes.

"It's been a long time, Jess," he said, his breath whispering against her cheek.

"What are you doing here?" she sighed.

"I'm here to see you."

"Don't, Tyler. Get out."

He laughed, his eyes never leaving hers. "I think about you all the time, Jess. I think—"

"Stop, Tyler," she said.

"Every time I come through Ohio—anytime someone says the word Ohio—it..." he made a fist and punched the center of his chest, "it gets me, Jess."

"I don't want you here," she said, her hand coming to her chest and closing the lapels of her open shirt.

His face got closer, he loomed over her, his eyes boring into hers. A slight smile tugged at those plump lips. He was clean-shaven, he smelled of leather and spice.

"Don't," she said.

He touched her thigh. His big hand smoothed the front of her left thigh, working higher. She shivered.

"Tyler, please..."

"Turn for me, Jess..."

“What?”

“Face the mirror.”

Facing away was easier than facing him and she turned on shaky feet, her house slippers working in little circles and she faced the mirror. She saw herself with him. His handsome face looming over her shoulder. Confident and masculine. Filling out his suit jacket, the ridge of his muscular chest evident under his dress shirt.

She whispered, “What are you doing here?”

“I think about you every day, Jess. Today’s the day I came for you.”

His hand went to her hip, and her eyes lowered to it, watching in the mirror. The backward letters of LIVE on the first knuckles of his fingers. FREE would be on the other hand, the one still pressed over her shoulder against the mirror. She had the same phrase, his phrase, tattooed below her breast, pretty script across her ribs.

The hand slipped around her, coming to her tummy and then fixing its grip on the buckle of her belt. He worked the leather out of the pewter, let the two ends hang and he undid the top button of her pants.

“Take them down for me, Jess,” he whispered in her ear.

“I’m not going to do that, Tyler,” she said, fixing his gaze now over her shoulder looking at his reflection in the mirror.

His hand slipped under her waistband and he pushed her zipper down with the back of his hand as his fingers stroked over top of her panties.

She pushed his hand away, and yelled, “Tyler!” She spun then, faced him, looking up in his yes, his real eyes. She said, “Get out of my house.”

He rested his hand on her collar, his thumb stroking her clavicle. “I’ve missed you, Jess.”

“Don’t lie to me.”

“We had something.”

“Pete will be home soon,” she said.

“No, he won’t. He doesn’t come home for lunch. Doesn’t even have a car. What’s he going to do, take the train home for lunch? He won’t be home until after six. We’ve got a long time. We’ve got all afternoon. A lot of catching up to do.”

He leaned to kiss, his lips poised to take hers and she turned away from him. He kissed her neck, kissed her just below her ear. She put her hands on him, one on his chest, the other touched his neck, felt that familiar strength, that hard feel of the man who she’d almost ruined her life for. The boy.

“I’ll call...the police,” she gasped.

His face changed, his hand came off the wall and he stood upright. He watched her, his head nodding almost imperceptibly. He turned his back to her, put both hands in his pockets again. He was looking out to the hall where he’d come in.

He said, “I thought this would be easier.”

“What would?” she said, buttoning up her pants, pulling her zip.

“I thought you’d want to see me.”

She didn’t answer him, did her belt up, looked at his big body, how it filled out the suit, watched his profile as his eyes went around her house.

“Pete’s doing well, I see,” he said.

“What are you doing here?”

“I’m not doing too bad now, Jess, either.” He still spoke away from her, spoke to the room. “Six figures. Salary and commission. Maybe I never should have been a teacher.”

“Why would you come here?” she said, folding her arms over her chest so he wouldn’t see her nipples standing out.

“Got the nerve, finally. Coming through Ohio again. I travel all over. Coming through here...I looked you up.”

“We’re over...”

He huffed. “I find you. I watch you. Can’t believe what I’m seeing. I’ve been here three days now...”

She felt a cold tingle of dread, a thatch of fiery needles rushing up her neck and through her hair, all over her scalp. She didn’t speak.

He turned, not to her, but a fraction away from her. Pointed to the kitchen.

“Tyler, no,” she whispered.

He went to the baby gate and she followed him. Tyler squat down, his fingers weaving through the rungs, draped over the top and he peered at Annabelle.

She said, “Hi-ii.”

“Hi,” Tyler said, “What’s your name?”

“Annabelle,” she said.

“Hi, Annabelle,” he said. He held his big index finger out to her and she gripped it.

Jess collapsed to her knees behind him, her knees cracking on the maple.

“Don’t,” she cried, “please, don’t.”

Tyler said to Annabelle, “You’re so pretty, Annabelle.”

“Fank you,” she said and she held the top rail of her baby gate, either side of his hand that read FREE.

He turned to Jess then and put a knee on the floor, he looked at her with a serious firm look. “Is she mine?”

“No, Tyler,” she said, looking as fierce as she could. “She’s Pete’s.”

“She has my eyes,” he said, looking to Annabelle again and giving her his finger to hold.

“She has *my* eyes, Tyler. She has *my* eyes,” she hissed.

Tyler shook his head angrily, stood up and reached over the gate and hoisted baby Annabelle up to him, hands under her arms so he could look in her face. He kissed Annie’s cheek.

Jess covered her mouth and her nose as she watched. Exploding inside, wanting to cry but afraid to do anything, afraid to speak, afraid to move. She watched in horror. He settled her then against his chest, held her to him and she rested.

“How could you, Jess?”

“She’s Pete’s. She—”

“Jess, how could you?”

She shook her head and breathed into her hands, felt her lips tremble against her palms.

“You know,” he said, his head shaking, mad, stopping, then continued, “You know...my time with you...that was the best time in my life...”

“Don’t say that,” she whispered through her hands.

“If she’s a product of that, Jess...” He shook his head and looked up to the cathedral ceiling of the kitchen. His eyes were wet with emotion.

“Get out,” she whispered.

He cleared his throat. Said, “I’m going.” Then to Annie, he said, “You want to say bye?”

She smiled and hid her face against his chest like she was shy and she said *Bye-e* into his suit jacket.

“Oh man,” Tyler sighed. “Nice to meet you, Annabelle. I’ll see you.” He set her down on the other side of the gate and she plopped to her butt then crawled to her piggies.

Jess’s tears came now and she cried, “She’s Pete’s baby, okay?” She brushed them away.

Tyler said, "Don't cry, Jess." He reached out to hold her shoulder with his hand but she pushed it away.

"Just go," she said, more tears streaming down her cheeks.

He put his hands back in his pocket and he headed for her hall. She followed him, went past the picture he'd held when he came in, followed him right to the door getting angrier at him with every step. Coming in here like he did. Thinking he could say the things he said.

At the door he turned to speak and she lashed out in fury. She thumped his shoulder with her balled fist, striking him four times like she had a hammer. She yelled, "You never came back! You never came back! I don't want you any more! Get out, just get out!"

He flinched and raised his shoulder to protect his face, held a hand up to block her if she tried. "Stop, Jess, stop," he said and he watched her hands, grabbed her wrists then and held them steady, looking in her eyes. "Stop," he repeated.

When she was still, and they held each other's eyes for too long a moment he kissed her. His lips came to hers and she kissed him. Her lips were tight and stiff and closed but he pressed his to hers and she twisted her face up in remorse but she didn't pull away. He let her go then, stepped back and looked her up and down. Then he left. Opened the door, stepped out to their brick stoop and walked down the manicured walkway that Pete had snipped with shears just this last Saturday morning. They were beginning to bud. She watched him walk all the way out to their driveway, out onto the cul-de-sac and get into a lifted pickup truck parked in front of their house. It started up with a mechanical rumble, exhaust shaking and clattering. She thought he might hammer out of here, squeal and roar, but he put it in gear and the truck eased itself out to the stop sign at the end of the street, signaled then turned left. She closed the door and she got down on her knees and she cried.

Afterword

SIGN UP for my newsletter to get the latest info, sneak peeks at upcoming stories, and even a free story or two down the road!

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Other Books by KT Morrison

Losing His Wife Series

[Losing His Wife: Book One](#)

[Losing His Wife: Book Two](#)

[Losing His Wife: Book Three](#)

Pete and Jess Mapplethorpe have been married for seven years now. They've got two wonderful little boys and an Irish Setter. Everyone that knows them would say they are the nicest couple you'd want to meet.

Well, they might say that Pete can be a bit of a jerk sometimes—but Jess? Regional Grade Three teacher of the year, three years running. Pretty, polite, sensitive, kind and thoughtful...

It must have been black magic that brought them together...

Behind closed doors everyone would be shocked at what goes on. They'd never believe the dirty things that sweet Jess might do or say. Pete doesn't think he has what it takes to please his beautiful wife and they fantasize about larger men taking her and making her happy.

She's just starting to discover herself at thirty-five... She wants to make up for lost time.

They've found a handsome, well-built young man to play along. It's better than they even imagined.

Now that they've started will she be able to stop? What if she doesn't want to?

Her husband loves enduring distressing levels of humiliation and she's finding a crazy pleasure now in delivering it...

Losing His Wife 2 Series

[Losing His Wife 2: Box 1](#)

[Losing His Wife 2: Box 2](#)

[Losing His Wife 2: Box 3](#)

Geoff J. Kane is a successful children's book illustrator. Ten years ago he married the girl of his dreams. She'd been his best friend and he'd helped her through tough relationships and gave her his shoulder to cry on many nights. Then after two years, she kissed him. Now they're married and they've got a beautiful seven-year-old daughter.

Nia Kane was a wild one. She liked to have fun and she liked to cause trouble. Everything she did, in the end, blew up in her face, hurt her. One night she realized the best man in her life was sitting with her, telling her it was all going to be okay. She kissed him and it was wonderful and he's always good to her.

Their daughter is growing up, she's away at school now and it seems like it might be a good idea for Nia to return to the workforce. The city isn't getting any cheaper. She gets a job offer from an old friend. The brother of her very hot ex-boyfriend. She cried on her husband's shoulder a lot over this guy, back when Geoff was just her buddy.

Having her ex back in her life stirs up old feelings in both of them. They both like it. There was something exciting about that time when they were twenty. It's safe now. He's got her. They can fantasize, right?

Obsessed Series

[Obsessed: Book One](#)

[Obsessed: Book Two](#)

Four couples lives intertwine as they explore their erotic boundaries. From simple wife-watching to cuckolding and domination and humiliation, these couples have one thing in common: they all share the same incredible bull. And he is far more than they even expected.

Mike and Gretch: Not married, but dating for a good long while. Two comedy writers just at the edge of love, that strange and delicate space where the act of sharing can be so dangerous. But they're two cool cats and they're sure they've got it all locked down. They call her ex-boyfriend from college, Atticus Hawke, a guy who has in the years since their breakup, and before Mike, been a reliable booty call for her.

Sean and Courtney: Sean's a Type A stick of dynamite. A rocketing studio exec, competitive and driven, he shares an incredible bond with his gym-toned wife. Courtney is all in for the new game she and her handsome husband have devised. Their ten-year-old daughter is out of the house and away at boarding school. They've planned a one-year commitment to one another about honesty, openness, and exploration. They're going for broke. Their new thing? Sean likes to watch and Court likes to be watched. They've found a guy online. He seems too good to be true. A guy called Finch, endowed, muscular, handsome like a fashion model. Courtney's been working out and she's going to put this stud through his paces.

Steve and Becky: Becky's a headstrong X-Ray technician who landed herself a multi-millionaire tech investor husband thirty years her senior. Steve loves to be dominated and he found the girl of his dreams in Becky. She's got an iron will and she loves her husband. Loves him enough to lock him in chastity and keep him abstinent for months on end. It's okay, don't worry about Becky, she gets a regular visit from a drop-dead gorgeous man named Finch. He keeps her satisfied. Sometimes, if he's been good, she'll even let her husband watch.

JJ and Amy: Two young country bumpkins just arrived in Los Angeles. JJ wants to live a lifestyle he's only dreamed of and this city is part of it. He's married to the sweetest little nineteen-year-old outta Jackson Pond, South Carolina and he's sure she's on a fast ticket to stardom. She just needs her first big break. While they're waiting he's got a fantasy he wants to see lived out. He would do anything to see his little Amy with a man who's got a big one, one'll make her scream like those girls he watches on the internet. He found a guy online, one Amy didn't make her vomit-face at. He's got everything JJ's been looking for and, thank the stars, he's agreed to do it.

Atticus Hawke: Finch is his online name. His nighttime name. The one he uses on a site that puts him in touch with couples looking for a bull just like him. By day he is Atticus Hawke. You might have heard of him. You know the song from the eighties, 'Going With That Girl'? No? You'd know it if you heard it. That was Atticus' dad, Ricky Hawke. Yes, that Ricky Hawke. Now you know. Made a bunch of singer-songwriter hits in a time when all the kids wanted pop coming out of synthesizers and their stars to be pretty boys and have colourful hair. Ricky had real talent. So does Atticus. One of L.A.'s hottest emerging Modern artists, his work commands a fortune. But it pales against his enormous trust fund. These days his real work is done at night. His masterpieces. That's where his passion is. Watching and participating in intense psychological dramas in dark hotel rooms across the city. He gives women what they want. They're a canvas, a medium. His audience: their husband.

The Cayman Proxy Series:

The Cayman Proxy (Box One)

Mitchell Sutton's family is one of the wealthiest in London. But Mitch is an outsider, the handsome young son who took his own path. He's in love with a girl from the wrong side of the tracks. Kate's a troubled Council house girl thrown into a lifestyle she never imagined. But she's more than his dressed up little princess.

He's got just about everything she needs. But she's got a mind full of dark thoughts she can't escape. And there's something Mitch can't give her.

She needs something his money can't buy.

He would do anything for her.

They hit the hot beaches of Grand Cayman, a reunion with an old friend and a handsome stranger. Passion boils in her blood. Can she make this work or will her desires destroy the man she loves?

Going A Little Too Far

You couldn't picture a sweeter couple than Troy and Emma.

Troy's a former Division One college wrestler. A walking water park at two-sixty-five, with shoulders no woman could get her arms around and a set of abs you could scrub laundry on.

Emma's a sweet little Georgia Peach. Pretty as can be in her proper dresses; she's a good girl from a good family that raised her right.

You couldn't tell by looking at them that they were two straight-up freaks that loved to push each other's kinky buttons.

Emma, with all her book club shyness, loves to be man-handled, loves to be lifted off her feet and dominated. Troy is a monster with a six-hundred-fifty pound deadlift and she's like a feather in his arms.

Troy likes to be humiliated. He knows he doesn't have much 'down there' and he likes his virginal wife to tell him he's no good and she'd have to get what she wanted elsewhere.

Couple of closet freaks.

A summer housewarming party on a scorching hot West Texas day puts a gift in their lap. A big, larger-than-life playtoy for Emma to tease her husband with. He wants her to. She wants to do it. But once it starts, where do you stop? What's going too far?

Taken While He Watches: On Their Honeymoon

Ken and Ashley just got married and while money is super-tight they've got themselves a weekend getaway in the Honeymoon Suite looking out over the ocean on the sunny Carolina coast.

The room was a steal. Turns out it's Bike Week and no one books the Honeymoon Suite during Bike Week. Especially not two dopey white kids from the suburbs.

A mix-up leaves them in trouble and they don't know how they can get out of it, don't even know how they'll get home. They get some help from their hotel neighbours. A half dozen handsome, muscular, and very wealthy black men.

Ken's wary but Ash is all in.

When they find out she's saved herself for her special night she becomes the star of the show and they'll offer anything to help her...

Ken doesn't like it but she's going to do what they ask. She says it's for their future...

Taken While He Watches: At The Combine

Coralee has put her own career on hold to help her husband keep his Sports Podcast afloat. He's spent eighty grand on his tiny entertainment empire.

Bobby just needs a big break. His business is a half second away from going belly-up. When their camera captures an XXL wardrobe malfunction by the combine's star prospect they see an opportunity.

Coralee will do anything to get an interview with him. She'll use the video as leverage. She'll get to this bad boy super-athlete, even if she has to break into the locker room...

She's doing it to save the family business, right?

Taken By His Best Friends: At The Hockey Rink

Marguerite was a sexy little French student Randall fell in love with at college. She loved hockey. He played hockey.

They fell in love and they married. They live a regular 9 to 5 now, but Randall and his best friends still play once a week. They are four big guys and they play rough and Marguerite is always there to cheer them from the stands.

When they all end up alone in the locker room after a bench-clearing brawl passions are already high. And when some innocent flirting starts it quickly tumbles out of control.

Marguerite does nothing to stop it. Randall is frozen...

He's going to watch his best friends do all the dirty things they've ever dreamed of doing to his wife...

Measured Next To Her Ex: A Medical Size Comparison Cuckold Fantasy

When Ben Watson went to the new Sexual Performance Clinic across from his office he was just looking to get some help.

But when he showed up on Opening Day the place was so overwhelmed they started doubling up in exam rooms to make sure all the patients were assessed.

Of all the gin joints in all the—

Guess who his exam partner is? Yeah, his honey-pie's ex-boyfriend. He is going to be sitting next to him, knees practically touching, while these nurses assess their size and performance using only their latex hands.

He could leave, get the hell out of there. That would be sensible. But he's kind of curious. A dark part of him wants to know something. Wants to know what his precious girl's ex-lover has between his legs.

He's going to wish he left.

Then, when his obscenely endowed exam mate starts to relate to the nurses the casual but very dirty hook-ups he's been having with an ex, Ben's hands really start sweating.

This is going to be the worst day of Ben's life.

Size Curious Brat

Matt Walsh is on his way home from Harvard. It's Thanksgiving recess and he hasn't been with his sweet Chloe Rose in months. He can't wait to get off the bus and wrap his arms around his baby girl.

Chloe's a perverted little high-schooler with a habit for trouble. She loves her boyfriend Matt and she's been aching for him.

But there's a problem.

Matt's step brother came home early. He's a bully. A domineering man's man who made Matt's life miserable growing up. Now he's a sexy deep-sea welder just getting home from Louisiana after two months at sea and he hasn't even seen a woman in ages.

After a brief, naked encounter in the hallway little Chloe can't get something out of her mind. Matt's stepbrother Moric is built much better than other men and she can't stop thinking about it.

It makes Matt mad but Chloe is just naturally curious. She doesn't think it's a big deal. She's just never seen anything like that before.

Now Moric's got his eyes on his little brother's prize possession. She's not exactly unwilling. Moric is a big powerful stud and Matt is powerless to stop him. Once he starts neither of them could stop him. He could take whatever he wants. It might be better—if Moric would let him—to just join him...